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Hedging and Boosting in Media Discourse: a Comparative Analysis of the Two Features in English and Arabic Newspaper Editorials

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Statement

The researcher clearly declares that all the parts of research were written and designed by the researcher himself. Therefore, anyone who wants to cite or reference any part or the whole research should follow citation rules and conventions. Moreover, the researcher used some artificial intelligence (AI) software applications such as *DeepSeek* and *ChatGPT* to paraphrase and summarize some difficult texts and long paragraphs that originated in other resources especially to write the introduction, review of the literature, and conclusion chapters.

Abstract

Hedging and boosting, as two rhetorical, communicative, and metadiscursive features, have been demonstrated to play an effective persuasive and argumentative role in the genre of newspaper editorials (NEs). The purpose of the present research is to compare and contrast the use of such features in media discourse, namely in English newspaper editorials (ENEs) and Arabic newspaper editorials (ANEs) and consider the similarities and differences in the frequency, form, and function of such features in the two corpora. Theoretically, the research aims to examine whether the factor *sociocultural context* where these NEs were written affect the use of such features in the present two corpora. To this end, 40 NEs (20 ENEs and 20 ANEs) were randomly selected from the electronic sections of the leading international and national newspapers published in the Anglo-American and the Arab World in the period between 1 January and 1 August, 2021. Depending on Gee's theoretical *cultural model* of linguistic features (2011, 2012), Fraser's (2010) analytical model, Hyland's (1996) definition of English hedging, and Hyland's (2005) definition of boosting, these NEs were thoroughly read in order to identify quantitatively and qualitatively the linguistic structures that are considered as hedging or boosting features with the help of corpus linguistic methodology. The findings of descriptive statistical analysis showed that the English newspaper editors (ENErs) used hedging significantly more frequently than the Arab newspaper editors (ANErs). On average, the ENErs used 48.94 tokens of hedging PTW (per a thousand word), whereas the ANErs used 34.08 tokens PTW. In fact, the ENErs, in the present research, hedged their propositions approximately twice more often than their Arab counterparts. Moreover, the ENErs used totally 169 tokens of boosting. On average, the ENEs contained 10.57 tokens of boosting PTW. However, the ANErs used 182 tokens of boosting, i.e. ANEs contained 12.95 tokens of boosting PTW. In other words, the ANErs boosted their propositions more often than their English counterparts. The functional analysis of the use of hedging features showed that the ENErs and ANErs utilized hedging categories to modify their claims, indicate imprecision, avoid categorical commitment, achieve politeness, and indicate modesty. Similarly, both the ENErs and ANErs seemed to use hedging to establish journalistic reputation, to avoid direct criticism, to interact with the reader, to present their claims as opinions rather than facts, and finally, to develop argumentation and achieve persuasion. The findings also showed that the ENErs and ANErs seemed to use boosting to develop argumentation and achieving Persuasion, to establish authority and power, to engage the reader, to establish conviction, and to obey cultural norms and models.

One major reason of the similarities and differences between the ENErs and ANErs in terms of usage of hedging and boosting provided by discourse analysts was the different pattern of *cultural models* which each group of newspaper editors (NErs) adopted in their socio-cultural contexts to achieve various rhetorical, persuasive, social, or ideological purposes. The findings of present research was aimed to contribute to such areas as designing syllabi, materials development, and ESP (English for Specific Purposes, EAP (English for Academic Purposes), or even AAP (Arabic for Academic Purposes) instruction. The findings was argued to increase the awareness of press and media students, translators, and ESP (English for Specific Purposes), EAP (English for Academic Purposes), AAP (Arabic for Academic Purposes) instructors about the socio-cultural, rhetorical, communicative, and metadiscursive functions and characteristics of hedging and boosting in newspaper discourse in general and in ENEs or ANEs in particular.

List of Abbreviations

Abbreviations	Words Abbreviated
ANE/ANEs	Arabic newspaper editorial (s)
ENE/ENEs	English newspaper editorial (s)
ANEr/ANErs	Arab newspaper editor (s)
ENEr/ENErs	English newspaper editor (s)
PNEs	Persian newspaper editorials
PNErs	Persian newspaper editor (s)
NE/NEs	Newspaper editorial (s)
RA/RAs	Research article (s)
MSA	Modern standard Arabic
ESP	English for Specific Purposes
EAP	English for Academic Purposes
AAP	Arabic for Academic Purposes
EFL	English as a Foreign Language
MSE	Modern Standard English
SBrE	Standard British English
SAmE	Standard American English
DMs	Discourse Markers
PMs	Pragmatic Markers
PTW	Per Thousand Word
MF	Mean Frequency
RF	Raw Frequency

Romanization of Arabic Words

Arabic Letter	Description	Romanized Sound
Hamzah	(sounds like *h* in *hour*	(‘)
Bā	(same as *b*)	b
Tā	(the italian dental, softer than *t*)	t
Thā	(between *th* in *thing* and *s)*	th
Jīm	(like *g* in *gem*)	j
ḥa	(very sharp but smooth gutteral aspirate)	ḥ
Khā	(like *ch* in the scotch word *loch*)	kh
Dāl	(italian dental, softer than *d*)	d
Dhāl	(sounds between *z* and *th* in *that*)	dh
Rā	(same as *r*)	r
Zā	(same as *z*)	z
Sīn	(same as *s*)	s

Shin	(same as *sh* in *she*)	sh
ṣād	(strongly articulated *s*, like *ss* in *hiss*)	ṣ
ḍad	(aspirated *d*, between *d* and *z*)	ḍ
ṭā	(strongly articulated palatal *t*)	ṭ
Zā	(strongly articulated palatal *z*)	z
‘ain	(somewhat like a strong guttural *hamzah*, not a mere vowel)	(‘)
Ghain	gutteral *g*, but soft	gh
Fā	(same as f)	f
Qāf	(strongly articulated guttural *k*)	q
Kāf	(same as *k*)	k
Lām	(same as *l*)	l
Mīm	(same as *m*)	m
Nūn	(same as *n*)	n
Hā	(same as *h*)	h
wāw	(same as *w*)	w
Yā	(same as *y*)	y
Short Vowels		
fatḥah (ٱ)	as *u* in tub	a
kasrah (ٱ)	as *i* in pin	i
Long Vowels		
long fatḥah	as *a* in father	ā
long ḍammah,	as *oo* in moot.	ū
long kasrah	as *ee* in deep	ī
fatḥah before wāw	as in cow	au
fatḥah before yā		ai
Tanwn (ٱ)، (ٱ)،(ٱ) is Romanized as *an*, *in*, *un*, respectively.		

Adopted from Romanization of Arabic in ALA-LC Romanization Tables of the Library of Congress and retrieved from http://www.loc.gov/catdir/cpso/romanization/arabic.pdf

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Introduction

This chapter presents the introduction of the research, which includes the preview and theoretical background that locate the present research in the relevant literature. Afterwards, the chapter presents the hypothesis the research assumes; the problem it addresses, and its objectives. Following this, the significance of the research to justify its importance and the research questions are provided. Finally, the chapter concludes with the structure of the research.

1.1 Research Background

1.1.1 Research Preview

Writing is one channel of communication, and journalistic writing as one form of written discourse involves an *interpersonal* relationship between the writer and the reader in academic or similar-to-academic discourse governed by certain conventions (Dafouz-Milne, 2008). Thus, writers or speakers attempt to attract their hearer(s) or reader(s) attention in a dialogic interaction and participation in the text. To achieve this objective, writers or speakers should use the most appropriate linguistic and rhetorical strategies or features (e.g., hedging and boosting). Discourse analysts distinguish between two levels of language: *Discourse* and *metadiscourse*. According to Hyland (2005a), metadiscourse refers to the way writers or speakers project themselves in their texts to interact with their receivers. It is a concept which is based on a view of writing or speaking as a social engagement. Metadiscourse is "discourse about discourse" in which writers or speakers demonstrate their interaction with their receivers in the text through using multiple metadiscoursal features (Crismore, Markkanen, & Steffensen, 1993). Similarly, discourse analysts distinguish between two main categories of metadiscourse in written texts: *Interactive metadiscourse* and *interactional* (*interpersonal*) *metadiscourse*. Interactive metadiscourse features "primarily involve the management of the flow of information and thus serve to guide readers through the content of the text" (Hyland, 2005b, P.59). Interactional metadiscourse features "are aspects that aim to involve readers in the argument or *ethos* of the text" (Hyland, 2005b, P.59).

At present, media has become influential powers in modern society, since it has a persuasive ability to influence the public opinion. Newspapers, as an integral part of media discourse, in addition to reporting facts and neutral information, are tools used to convey ideologies, cultures, politics, societies, and negotiations by using different *pragmalingual* features

such as metadiscoursal resources (Salahshoor, Najjary, & Tofigh, 2014). According to McNair (2011), "the most important voice of a newspaper is its *editorial*, which embodies its political identity" (p. 70). Newspaper editorials (NEs), featured in newspapers or magazines, serve as persuasive texts that blend factual information with argumentative content to affect public opinion on social, political, and economic matters (van Dijk, 2006). NEs as *leading articles* are a typical example of a discourse that combines arguing, narrating, and exposing to influence the public opinion (Khalil, 2000, p. 23). NEs are usually written by an editor and represent the views and the opinions of the newspaper. They generally reflect the newspaper's analysis, discussion, opinion, or judgement on the issues of the day (Bhatia, 2013, p. 170). According to as van Dijk (2006), as the voice of the newspaper, NEs are "public discourse that communicate with a mass audience and play on obvious role in the determining and shifting of public opinion" (p. 41).

Hedging, characterized by tentative language (e.g., *may*, *perhaps*) to express uncertainty, and boosting, which employs assertive terms (e.g., *absolutely*, *certainly*) to convey confidence, are key rhetorical strategies used to persuade readers and shape their perspectives on the text's subject matter (Crismore & Vande Kopple, 1997; Dafouz-Milne, 2008). Hyland (2005b) states that hedging and boosting are essential rhetorical strategies in media discourse, particularly in NEs, where they function to maintain a balance between objectivity and persuasiveness. These linguistic features play a significant role in shaping the credibility of arguments, as they convey the writer's stance and affect public perception (Hyland, 2005a; Salager-Meyer, 1994). Skelton (1988, p.38) commenting on the importance of hedging and boosting in language states that: "Without hedging and boosting, the world is purely propositional, a rigid place where things either are the case or are not. With a hedging and boosting system, language is rendered more flexible and the world more subtle." In his research on metadiscourse, Hyland found that "hedges and boosters accounted for 83 per cent of all metadiscourse (…), with hedges being four times more frequent" (2005a, p.67). Hedging softens assertions by signaling tentativeness or likelihood (e.g., *might*, *possibly*, *suggests*), while boosting reinforces certainty in statements, conveying confidence and assertiveness (e.g., *clearly*, *undoubtedly*, *always*) (Hyland, 1996).

According to Farrokhi and Emami (2008), in English-language newspaper discourse, hedging is frequently used to maintain journalistic neutrality and acknowledge alternative perspectives. While hedging is a part of Arabic discourse, its function may differ. In Arabic discourse, hedging serves as a politeness strategy or as a means of acknowledging religious,

cultural values, and societal norms (Al-Ghamdi & Alrefaee, 2020). Hedging and boosting are two crucial *interactional* metadiscourse features used by writers to convey their epistemic stance and position related to the writer–reader interaction. Hyland (2004) demonstrates that through presenting information as an opinion rather than a fact, hedging features emphasize the subjectivity of a position and therefore open that position to negotiation. However, boosting features function to indicate the writer's strong confidence when presenting a claim (Holmes, 1982) and affirmation of that claim confidently (Abdi, Rizi, & Tavakoli, 2010). In contrast to hedging, boosting expresses the author's confidence in their assertions, demonstrating engagement with the subject matter and alignment with the audience's perspective. In other words, boosting increases the force of the statement (Jalilifar & Seidian, 2016) and allows the writer who has various positions in argumentative writing to narrow these alternative positions and confront choices by expressing their ideas with certainty and confidence (Hyland, 2005b). According to Dafouz-Milne (2008), a persuasive text seems to consist of a combination of tentative features (i.e., hedging) and assertive ones (i.e., boosting) in order to produce a discourse that balances assertiveness with clarity, avoiding extremes of forcefulness or ambiguity.

Hedging and boosting, as distinct interactional metadiscourse feature, are supposed to vary in frequency, form, and function across languages and discourse types (spoken or written). This variation arises because different languages employ unique rhetorical-pragmatic norms and linguistic systems (semantic, syntactic, etc.), shaping how they deploy textual markers like hedging and boosting to achieve communicative goals. Research comparing ENEs and ANEs shows that they employ hedging and boosting regularly. However, their usage varies in frequency, form, and purpose, influenced by socio-cultural and linguistic contexts. (Al-Khatib & Salem, 2011; Hyland, 2005b). According to Alghazo, Al-Anbar, Rabab'ah, Abusalim, and Rayyan, (2024), English academic and journalistic discourse tends to adopt tentative claims and open-ended argumentation, while Arabic academic and journal discourse historically tends to adopt assertiveness and expressive persuasion. Similarly, Farrokhi and Emami (2008) argue that ENEs frequently employ *modal verbs* and *epistemic markers* to soften assertions and foster critical reader engagement through dialogic interaction. In contrast, Arabic discourse relies more on forceful language, predominantly utilizing boosting features to assert positions emphatically (Al-Khatib & Salem, 2011; Abdel Salam, 2011). Williams (1981) argues that NEs, as argumentative and persuasive texts, use interactional metadiscourse to strengthen the relationship between the writer

and the reader. In other words, as important interactional metadiscursive features, hedging and boosting are used by the writer/speaker to indicate their epistemic position related to the writer–reader interaction or to the claim they present. That is to say, whenever a writer hedges his/her propositions or claims, he/she also aims to strengthen his/her relationship with his/her readers since he/she avoids imposing claims or views on them.

The researcher in the present research specifically examines the use of two important interactional metadiscoursal features, namely hedging and boosting. Despite the fact that NEs have attracted a very wide readership and much research (e.g., Dafouz-Milne, 2008; Al-Ghoweri &Al-Kayed, 2019), a little research has been done to explore the use of hedging and boosting features in ENEs and ANEs. Connor (1996) argues that "research on editorials cross-culturally is significant" and that "little is known cross-culturally about the genre" (p.144). For instance, Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed (2019) studied English and Jordanian Arabic economic newspaper articles (i.e. NEs) to compare similarities and differences in terms of frequency of use of hedging and boosting. To this purpose, the researchers selected 60 NEs published in both Anglo-American and Arabic newspapers (30 for each type of NEs) to investigate the use of such two features in these articles based on Salager-Meyer's (1997) and Hyland's (2005a) framework of hedging and boosting features. The findings of research showed that the ENEs used a more frequent number of hedging than their Arabic counterparts. Findings also revealed that the socio-cultural (i.e. language factor) determined the frequency and the function of these features. The findings also showed that *modal verbs* and *approximators* were the most frequent hedging categories in the ENEs, while approximators and lexical verbs were the most frequent hedging categories in the ANEs. *Emphatics* and *amplifiers* were very frequently used boosting features by both the ENEs and ANEs. Hinkel (2005) and Dafouz-Milne (2008) have analyzed the used of hedging and boosting in media texts. However, their findings were limited to Western discourse. Previous research has primarily focused on hedging and boosting in academic writing (Hyland, 1998; Salager-Meyer, 1994) or within single-language contexts (Mauranen, 1997; Alqam, 2020), leaving a gap in understanding their cross-linguistic and cross-cultural characteristics in media and newspaper discourse.

1.1.2 Theoretical Framework: Gee's Theory

The present research uses Gee's (2011, 2012) theoretical framework of *cultural models* of linguistic features. Analyzing hedging and boosting features involves necessarily studying the

socio-cultural context where these features occur. Socio-cultural context is the social surrounding or society in which the language is used as a means of communication. As interactional metadiscourse features, investigating hedging and boosting provides us with critical insights into how cultural contexts shape their frequency, purpose, and linguistic realizations. However, scholars argue over the extent to which these contexts, embedded within specific discourse communities, influence the deployment of such features (Sanjaya, 2013). Research suggests that an author's cultural background, disciplinary norms, and genre conventions significantly shape the function, form, frequency of these features (Gee, 2012; Sanjaya, 2013, 2015). Gee (2012) defines cultural contexts as cultural models that guide individuals' linguistic and behavioral patterns within a given discourse community. Cultural models may affect the pattern of use of rhetorical structures in general and *metadiscursive* features such as hedging and boosting in particular (Gee, 2012; Sanjaya, 2013, 2015). One important aspect of Gee's linguistic theory is the notion of *situated meaning*, *cultural model*, and *discourse*. The *situated meaning* of an expression is that meaning determined by the cultural specific context where the expression is used, and this context is relevant to a specific *cultural model* followed by the language producer. *Discourse* comprises both linguistic and non-linguistic resources employed by a speaker/writer to construct a particular kind of person (i.e. the person's identity). For instance, by using hedging and boosting in different discourses, writers may construct their desired identity, which may or may not be recognized by their readers.

Gee (2012) argues that his theory constitutes a social and cultural approach to language based on the claim that the best way to understand language is "to displace it from the center of our attention and to foreground society, culture, and values" (p.1). Sanjaya (2013) states that Gee's theory of language can be considered as socio-cognitive, rather than purely social and cultural. Gee (2012) characterizes hedging and boosting as socio-cognitive phenomena, as their use and interpretation inherently engage cognitive processes that link linguistic forms to intended meanings. In essence, all language use, whether constructing or interpreting texts, involves cognitive engagement. However, when writers employ hedging or boosting to modify the certainty of their claims, cognitive processing constitutes only one dimension of their multifaceted rhetorical strategy. According to Gee (2012), the mitigation (hedging) and amplification (boosting) of the statement's truth value by the writer can be cognitively planned to build some sort of social relationship with the reader, and this can be achieved by using such features. Gee's (2012) socio-

cognitive framework posits that language is not an isolated system but is deeply shaped by its socio-cultural environment, including cognition, societal norms, and cultural values. Accordingly, understanding language requires analyzing how specific communities employ it within their unique social and cultural contexts (Gee, 2011, 2012).

Since language cannot be separated from the social and cultural contexts in which it functions as a communicative tool, the meaning and function of linguistic elements are not universal, but they are associated with the specific contexts of their use. Gee (1999) emphasizes that meanings are collectively constructed through the cultural models shared by social groups and internalized by individuals, rather than existing as fixed or independent entities. The multiple meanings created and adapted to specific contexts of use are what Gee referred to as situated meanings in socio-cultural settings (Gee, 1999, p. 40, as cited in Sanjaya, 2013). Although hedging and boosting features have referential meanings or utterance-type meanings in a particular context, they might be interpreted differently when they are used in different socio-cultural context as they might have different ideological structures. The fact that hedging and boosting features are used differently (in terms of form, function, and frequency) by writers/speakers from different cultural contexts means that these rhetorical features are associated with different *cultural models* adopted by those different writers/speakers (Gee, 2012; Sanjaya, 2015). The writer's cultural models include: The writer/speaker's *intrapersonal factors*, low or high *power distance* between the writer/speaker and the reader/listener, the speaker/writer's degree of *individualism* vs. *collectivism*, the writers' educational backgrounds or journalistic experiences, and the speaker/writer's degree of high or low *uncertainty avoidance*. All these aspects are a part of the concept of *cultural models* or *belief systems* proposed by Gee (2011, 2012) which are determined by the socio-cultural circumstances of the writer (Sanjaya, 2013, 2015).

Furthermore, empirical research examining linguistic and cultural variations presented in the review of literature chapter, demonstrates that socio-cultural contexts profoundly influence the use of hedging and boosting strategies. According to Sanjaya's (2013, 2015) findings, RAs written in two or more different languages did not contain hedging and boosting at comparable rates. In other words, the socio-cultural context factors seemed, to some extent, to determine the rhetorical characteristics of the RAs (i.e. use of hedging and boosting). The referential meaning of hedging involves the use of linguistic features (e.g., *perhaps*, *suggest*) to signal the writer's cautious stance, avoiding absolute certainty about the validity of a claim or statement in the text. The referential

meaning of boosting is the use of expressions, such as *strongly*, *certainly*, to indicate that the writer is committed fully toward the truth value of the presented proposition (Hyland, 2005a). However, there are other meanings and functions for such features, which are the situated or cultural meanings or functions. Gee (2012, p.87) states that "one and the same speaking and acting can count as different things in different contexts." Hedging and boosting can mean and function differently in different socio-cultural contexts (where a *language* and *genre* occur) and can be used at different frequencies in different discourses or genres written in different languages (i.e. in different socio-cultural contexts). To put it differently, hedging and boosting can have multiple situated meanings or functions depending on the various contexts where they occur. In other words, different cultures or languages may adopt different ideological structures or rhetorical features such as hedging and boosting in their discourse. The ideological structures mean the *cultural values* or *models* prevailing in specific societies, which determine the use of words or expressions (Gee, 2011, 2012). Moreover, Hyland (2005a) argues that the use of hedging and boosting features is deeply associated with the structural dynamics of a discourse community. Specifically, the community's conventions and its members' adherence to these shared norms critically influence how and when such rhetorical features are used. Accordingly, in the present research, the socio-cultural context of the ENEs is the English-speaking countries such as the U.S, Britain, Canada, Australia, New Zealand and the journalistic discourse community where these articles are written. Similarly, the socio-cultural context of the ANEs is the Arab world and the journalistic discourse community where these articles are written.

1.2 Research Hypotheses

Because of the linguistic and cultural differences between English and Arabic discourse particularly in media writing, the use of hedging and boosting (i.e., frequency, form, and function) by English newspaper editors (ENErs) and Arabic newspaper editors (ANErs) is assumed to vary considerably. Depending on prior research examining how hedging and boosting function as persuasive and argumentative features within media discourse, the following hypotheses are proposed for testing in this comparative analysis of ENEs and ANEs:

1. There are some noticeable differences in terms of frequency, and structure of hedging and boosting features used in the ENEs and the ANEs.

2. Linguistic and cultural variations are believed to influence how the two editor groups employ hedging and boosting. In other words, the use of hedging and boosting in the ENEs and ANEs is supposed to be language or culture sensitive.

3. The frequency of hedging is higher in the ENEs than in the ANEs, whereas the frequency of boosting is higher in the ANEs than in the ENEs. Moreover, it is assumed that the linguistic structure of hedging and boosting differ significantly between the ENEs and ANEs. Previous research suggests that the Anglo-American journalistic tradition tend to use objective and cautious language through the use of hedging features such as *modal verbs* (may, might), *epistemic adverbs* (probably, possibly), and tentative verbs (suggests, appears) (Hyland, 1996; Farrokhi & Emami, 2008). However, Mejdell (2006) demonstrates that because of different cultural conventions regarding academic discourse, Arabic writers may seem to prefer more direct and assertive argumentation through using boosting features than their English counterparts (i.e. hedge their texts less frequently). Arabic media discourse tends to prefer assertiveness and persuasive rhetoric and use a very frequent number of boosting features such *as emphatic adverbs* (definitely, certainly), *emphatic structures* (possibly, probably), *repetition*, *evaluative adjectives* (*undeniable*, *absolute*), and *rhetorical questions* to emphasize the author's conviction and authority (Al-Khatib & Salem, 2011; Abdel Salam, 2011).

4. There are some significant differences and similarities between the ENEs and ANEs in terms of functions of hedging and boosting features.

1.3 Research Problem

One important issue the present research tackles is cross-cultural differences, which can lead to different realization of hedging and boosting features. Different realization of such features, consequently, may result in cross-linguistic or cross-cultural miscommunication between Anglo-American and Arab readers, writers, or translators of Arabic or English language. In other words, a breakdown or failure in communication is likely to happen due to "cross-culturally different perceptions of what constitutes appropriate linguistic behavior" (Fraser, 2010, p.13). The primary cause of this breakdown is that these metadiscursive features are specific to each language or culture. That is to say, (Thomas, 1983; Hyland, 1995). To put it differently, the frequency, function, and form of hedging and boosting differ across discourse communities and cultures,

which can lead to misunderstandings in intercultural exchanges (Thomas, 1983; Hyland, 1995).

To put it differently, when speakers or writers use hedging or boosting inappropriately, his or her claims can be considered as too assertive or too tentative according to the *cultural models* of each language group (i.e. English or Arabic). The present research also investigates whether ENErs and ANErs employ hedging and boosting in comparable ways or if their usage is shaped by cultural and linguistic factors. Cross-cultural findings suggest that English discourse tends to feature hedging more frequently and with a greater variety of tentative constructions, whereas Arabic rhetoric and discourse typically adopts a more forceful, expressive style, marked by frequent use boosting features (Najjar, 1990; Al-Khatib & Salem, 2011). These differences point to distinct hedging and boosting patterns across the two discourse traditions.

1.4 Research Objectives

One important objective the present research aims to achieve is to contrastively analyze and compare the form, frequency, and function of hedging and boosting features in the genre of NEs as a distinctive genre in journalistic discourse. In other words, the present research investigates the effect of the independent variable (i.e. *language* or *cross-cultural context*) on the dependent variable (i.e. the use of hedging and boosting in the English and Arabic corpora). Accordingly, the present research aims to achieve the following objectives:

1. To analyze the frequency of hedging and boosting used in both the English and Arabic corpora (ENEs & ANEs).
2. To compare the frequency and distribution of various categories or subcategories of hedging and boosting used in the ENEs and ANEs.
3. To identify what linguistic grammatical and lexical forms or categories functioning as hedging and boosting features used by writers with different cultural backgrounds in the genre of NEs and how NErs mitigate or amplify their claims (Dafouz-Milne, 2008; Hinkel, 2005).
4. To identify what pragmatic functions hedging and boosting features can achieve in the two corpora.

1.5 Research Significance

Despite the importance of cross-linguistic differences in the use of hedging and boosting in media discourse, the research done in this area is limited particularly between ENEs and ANEs.

There has been a great deal of research on hedging and boosting across languages, disciplines, and genres (e.g., Vassileva, 2001; Abbas, 2011; Andrusenko, 2015; Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed, 2019; Zarza, 2018; Lafuente-Millán, 2008; Sanjaya, 2013; Amirrostami, 2019). However, to the best of the researcher's knowledge, no comparative research has been carried out to examine hedging and boosting in English and Arabic newspaper discourse particularly in ENE and ANEs except for Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed (2019) (cf. Abbadi, 2014). The limited amount of research that is conducted in this area has shown that there are some noticeable variations in terms of use of such features cross languages and across genres. The findings of the past comparative research on the use of such features in English and other languages (e.g., Spanish, Persian, & Arabic) are inconclusive or incomprehensive, and they have offered scant insights into how these features vary in use. Consequently, this research examines hedging and boosting cross-culturally in ENEs and ANEs within a non-Western European language specifically Modern Standard Arabic (MSA) and English as a European language to see if there are any differences or similarities in their frequency, form and function. The present research has significant theoretical and practical implications for understanding hedging and boosting in media discourse, particularly in ENEs and ANEs. The present research can be particularly beneficial to nonnative editors, readers, translators, and second language learners, for it provides insights and information about how to deal with two different metadiscusive systems of using such features. Furthermore, the investigation of hedging and boosting realizations in two different cultures is an important area, as it allows us to explore the impact of linguistic and cultural variations on cross-cultural communication and the use of such rhetorical features. By comparing the frequency, form, and function of such rhetorical features across two linguistically and culturally distinct contexts, this research contributes to the growing field of contrastive rhetoric (Connor, 2002) and media linguistics (Bednarek & Caple, 2017). Investigating how the ENErs and ANErs use these features can provide deeper insights into how persuasion and argumentation are linguistically structured across languages (Al-Khatib & Salem, 2011; Najjar, 1990). Practically, the findings of this research have important implications for journalism, cross-cultural communication, and translation studies. Understanding the rhetorical strategies used in two different languages can help journalists, translators, and discourse analysts to develop more effective strategies to writing and understand NEs in multilingual and multicultural contexts (Biber & Finegan, 1989).

1.6 Research Questions

This research aims to investigate the use of hedging and boosting in the ENEs and ANEs by addressing the following research questions:

1. What is the frequency of occurrence of hedging and boosting in the ENEs (English corpus)?
2. What is the frequency of occurrence of hedging and boosting in the ANEs (Arabic corpus)?
3. What are the linguistic forms or categories/subcategories of such features used in the English and Arabic corpora?
4. What are the pragmatic and socio-cultural functions of these features in the ENEs and ANEs?
5. What socio-cultural and rhetorical factors influence the use of such features in the ENEs and ANEs?
6. What are reasons of differences or preferences in terms of usage of such features (if there are any) between the ENEs and ANEs?
7. Do the ENEs tend to use a more frequent number of tentative features and an indirect style (hedging features) and the ANEs tend to use a more assertive and expressive style (boosting features), as suggested by previous research (Najjar, 1990; Alqam, 2020)?

1.7 Structure of the Research

The present research is divided into five chapters: Chapter one presents the theoretical background of the research. It deals primarily with the position of hedging and boosting within body of literature as two rhetorical linguistic features of metadiscourse. It combines the theoretical framework, the hypothesis, the problem, the significance of this research, and its research questions. Chapter two presents the methodology the research applies, the analytical framework and taxonomy the research adopts, the description of the two corpora, and the descriptive and inferential procedures of data collection. Chapter three presents the review of literature which provides a theoretical account of evolution of hedging and boosting concepts, scholars' several views on these two linguistic rhetorical features, their definitions, categories, models, and the position of hedging and boosting in the body of both theoretical and empirical literature. The

researcher supports this theoretical account with some empirical research conducted in this area. Chapter four introduces the analysis of the data, findings and discussion of the findings. Chapter five provides some limitations the research encountered and presents some recommendations for future researchers. It concludes with providing some contributions the research achieved and implications for teachers, translators, leaners, and editors, and it summarizes the major procedures, methodology, and findings of the present research. Moreover, a list of references and appendixes containing the frequency and distribution of hedging and boosting in each ENE and ANE are presented in the last section of the research.

1.8 Summary

The present chapter introduced the theoretical basis of this research. It proceeded to present the hypothesis, the problem, the objectives, and the significance of the present research. Identifying the previous components helped in building the research questions, which were also provided in this chapter. The final part of chapter one involved the structure of the research.

Chapter Two

Methodology

After establishing the theoretical background of the current research, this chapter aims to describe the analytical framework the research adopts to identify hedging and boosting features in the two corpora. The chapter also presents the nature of the current research, the size of the two corpora the researcher analyzes, the research method, and the procedures that are applied to conduct statistical analysis and collect the data.

2.1 Identification of Hedging and Boosting in the two Corpora (ENEs & ANEs)

Since hedging and boosting features can be derived from various lexico-grammatical categories and realized in various strategies, there has been no predetermined definite lexico-grammatical taxonomy of hedging and boosting feasible to all types of discourse (Hyland, 1996). That is to say, hedging and boosting features are open functional and formal classes. A further methodological challenge is that a single structure may be classified as either a hedging or a boosting feature, depending on its contextual use. For example, in the sentence "*Further research is obviously necessary in this direction"*, the adverb *obviously* could function as a hedge or booster depending on the context or the author's intention. Accordingly, the researcher conducts a thorough manual contextual examination to identify hedging and boosting occurrences along with their functions in their contextual use. This analysis draws on Fraser's (2010, pp. 23–24) analytical framework, Hyland's (1996) definition of hedging, and Hyland's (2005a) concept of boosting.According to Hyland (2005a), "A hedge is … any linguistic means used to indicate either (a) a lack of complete commitment to the truth of a proposition, or (b) a desire not to express that commitment categorically" (p. 251). According to Hyland (2005a), "Boosters … allow writers to express conviction and assert a proposition with confidence, representing a strong claim about a state of affairs." Moreover, the researcher incorporates other categories that are not found in Fraser's model for both English and Arabic corpora. As for Arabic, and to the best of the researcher's knowledge, there is no definite classification of Arabic hedging and boosting features of any type; therefore, Fraser's model (2010, pp.23-24) of English hedging features is adopted as main guidance to identify occurrences of hedging and boosting features in the Arabic corpus. The

researcher adopts and modifies Fraser's (2010) analytical model to identify and categorize the two features in both the ENEs and ANEs as table 2.1 shows:

Table 2.1 Fraser's (2010, pp.23-24) Analytical Model

Category of Feature	Example of Hedging	Example of Boosting
Impersonal/Indefinite Pronouns	(e.g., one, it, some, and so on)	(e.g., nobody, nothing, nowhere, and so on)
Concessive Conjunctions	(e.g., although, though, even though, while, whereas, even though, even if, and so on).	----------
Introductory Phrases or Clausal elements	(e.g., I believe, to our knowledge, it is our view that, we feel that, I believe that he should go, if possible, and so)	(e.g., it is clear, I present, it is certain that, as a matter of fact, without any contradiction, nothing can be achieved, and so on)
Adverbs of Degree, Time, Frequency and Quantity and Modal Adverbs	(e.g., approximately, roughly, about, often, occasionally, generally, sort of, perhaps, possibly, probably, practically, presumably, apparently, and so on).	(e.g., absolutely, actually, always, assuredly, basically, certainly, clearly, completely, definitely, entirely, evidently, exactly, fully, indeed, in fact, never, and so on)
Adjectives and Modal Adjectives	(e.g., apparent, approximate, common, considerable, frequent, Improbable, possible, probable, un/likely, uncertain, unobvious, unclear, usual, and so on)	(e.g., clear, complete, absolute, certain, obvious, and so on)
Nouns and Modal Nouns	(e.g., assumption, claim, possibility, estimate, suggestion, and alternative, assumption, belief, chance, claim, doubt, hope, idea, implication, indication, opinion, possibility, tendency, and so on)	(e.g., certainty, conviction, confidence, evidence, fact, precision, truth, and so on)
Modal Verbs	(e.g., might, can, would, could, and so on).	(e.g., must, will, should, shall, can't, couldn't, have to, won't, and so on)
Epistemic Lexical Verbs	(e.g., to seem, to appear, to believe, to assume, to suggest, and so on).	(e.g., see, and so on)
Agentless Passive	Many of the troops were injured.	----------
Conditional subordinators	(e.g., as long as, assuming that, given that, unless, and so on). Unless the strike has been called off, there will be no trains tomorrow.	----------
Conditional Clauses	If you are going my way, I need a lift back.	----------

Metalinguistic comments	(e.g., strictly speaking, so to say, almost, just, about, and so on).	(e.g., it is clear, definitely, exactly, obviously, and so on)

2.2 The Present Research

The present research can be described as a quantitative, qualitative, comparative, and corpus-based research. Since the present research compares two linguistic features, which exist in both English and Arabic languages, a comparative corpus-based approach can be ideal to this purpose. Adel and Mauranen (2010) argue that scholars comparing languages or genres typically rely on corpus-based methods that use a fixed taxonomy of lexical items or features (for example, "however" as a connective, *possible* as a hedge, *definitely* as a booster, and so forth). Moreover, a contrastive or comparative research can be an important method for understanding cultural specific features as well as linguistic universals (Adel & Mauranen, 2010). To put it simply, contrastive research provides an essential means of gaining detailed descriptive insights into particular languages and cultures, as well as a deeper understanding of language-mediated communication (Pery-Woodley, 1990, cited in Connor, 1996, p. 6). Moreover, because of its theoretical and practical strengths, the present research adopts a corpus-based approach, utilizing the instruments and techniques of corpus linguistics.

By applying these tools and techniques to compare hedging and boosting patterns in ENE and ANE newspaper discourse, the present research can shed some light on differences and similarities in terms of use of such features in this discourse. According to McEnery and Hardie (2011), using corpus tools refers to "the actual text collections and software packages for corpus access" (p. 206). Corpus methods, on the other hand, refer to "the analytic techniques that are used when we work with corpus data" (McEnery & Hardie, 2011, p. 206). In terms of tools, the research investigates two collections of texts as described above depending on a mixture of manual contextual and computer-based analysis. The present research also employs corpus methods—such as generating concordances, calculating frequency lists, and producing word sketches—to to identify hedging and boosting caqtegories. As Conrad (1999) demonstrates, corpus-based research uses computer tools to analyze bodies of authentic texts, enabling the investigation of linguistic features and usage patterns of language that have been extremely difficult to investigate without the use of computers. A corpus-based research is very useful when the purpose is to derive occurrences of a linguistic feature in a large amount of texts. Furthermore, corpus-based analysis

is vital for researchers because corpora provide a rich repository of data not only on word and phrase frequencies but also on empirical inquiries into discourse community. Beyond simple frequency counts, these large text collections allow for systematic, data-driven exploration of how discourse structures unfold in authentic language use. Such empirical insight into discourse organization underscores the value of corpus methods in both descriptive and functional studies of language (Biber, Connor, & Upton, 2007).

2.3 Research Method

A research method can usually be described as either *quantitative* or *qualitative* and *mixed* methods when these are combined. It is argued that a quantitative research method is extremely effective and sufficient for obtaining accurate results (Adel & Mauranen, 2010). Qualitative research typically involves an in-depth analysis of a small number of texts, meaning that achieving broad generalizability or representativeness of the results is not its goal. However, a quantitative research method is "important for generalizable results" (Biber, 2009, p. 1287). Adel and Mauranen (2010) compare their quantitative method "unfavourably with their own qualitative approach, which also seems to involve counting features but which sees the metadiscusive unit as larger than the search term" (p.4). A quantitative method involves "data collection procedures that result primarily in numerical data which is then analyzed primarily by statistical methods" (Dornyei, 2007, p. 24). The results are often statistically analyzed and then used to generalize findings. A qualitative method involves "data collection procedures that result primarily in open-ended, non-numerical data which is then analyzed primarily by non-statistical methods" (Dornyei, 2007, p.24). This approach typically produces textual insights rather than numerical data. Moreover, in qualitative research, "the information is subjectively interpreted by the researcher with the goal of providing greater understanding of a range of phenomena" (Dornyei, 2007, pp.37-38). Quantitative and qualitative approaches may be integrated within a framework known as mixed-method research (Dörnyei, 2007, p. 24).

The present research employs both quantitative and qualitative data collection techniques, aligning with what Dörnyei (2007, p. 24) refers to as a mixed-methods approach. In other words, both methods are used to answer the research questions and achieve the objectives of the research. The qualitative method is used in the present research to interpret the metadiscoursal and pragmatic functions of hedging and boosting features used by the two groups of NErs and to provide details about forms of such features. The quantitative aspect of this research involves analyzing NEs

written by both the ENErs and ANErs to determine the frequency of categories of hedging and boosting features. Aijmer (2002) argues that sometimes a manual analysis is necessary to avoid disambiguation. A computer-based analysis may not consider the linguistic context surrounding each feature, making it likely inadequate for this research, as understanding contextual usage is particularly important because computer-based analysis faces the risk of assuming some linguistic features (when they are not) as hedging or boosting features and can damage the validity of research (Abbas, 2011). In other words, the current research incorporates both manual and computer-assisted analyses. To put it differently, identifying hedging and boosting is done manually using Microsoft Word Office as well as Adobe Acrobat Professional X program, whereas frequencies and percentages of hedging expressions over the total number of running words are computed, identified, and tabulated quantitatively.

2.4 Procedures of Data Collection

The data collection in the current research includes retrieving 20 ENEs and 20 ANEs from the electronic version of influential, national, and international Anglo-American and Arabic newspapers available on the internet. The NEs are electronically retrieved, labeled, and stored as TXT files to create a database for the two corpora. Data collection is done in March 2025, and the collected NEs are published in the period between 1 January and 1 August 2021. The texts are carefully examined to count instances of hedging and boosting, as well as to identify the specific structures and expressions serving these functions. Then, the expressions or items that are considered to be hedging or boosting features are identified, categorized, and subcategorized in the texts based on Frazer's (2010) model and Hyland's (1996) definition of hedging and Hyland's (2005a) definition of boosting. Then, two independent lists of Arabic and English linguistic features of hedging and boosting are generated from these manual readings to compare and contrast the two sets of data: The English list and Arabic list of hedging and boosting. Afterwards, the number of hedging and features boosting is recorded in each text and in each corpus separately to calculate the frequencies and percentages of different types of hedging and boosting categories. Each category and subcategory of hedging and boosting in the research includes Romanized versions of the Arabic examples and features. In the case of the Arabic corpus, examples taken from the main text are presented in Romanized Arabic, accompanied by their English translations and original Arabic script. The Romanization is in accordance with the transliteration of Arabic in ALA-LC Romanization tables adopted by the Library of Congress. Finally, a major concern in

most quantitative research is the process of ensuring random sample selection (Henning, 1986). Therefore, the researcher is concerned that all NEs are chosen randomly from their newspaper's websites. Random selection is carried out using a freely available Random Number Generator tool found online (www.random.org). However, the researcher also takes into account two key factors when choosing each text. First, the corpora represent writing samples of different writers, and second, these samples are comparatively in equal length. In other words, texts in both corpora are limited to a maximum of 1500 words, as longer texts often pose challenges in tracking the argumentative elements during data analysis. Moreover, a preliminary pilot analysis is done to select a representative sample of NEs. To achieve this, newspapers with a specific political bias or targeted at a particular audience are excluded, while those covering a broader range of topics and appealing to a wider audience are chosen. From this selection, a group of ENEs and ANEs is ultimately selected for this research. Translated NEs are not chosen. The construction of the entire corpus for analysis in the present research is also based on what Connor and Moreno (2005) refer to as *"tertium comparationis"*, which simply refers to the idea that "we compare elements that can in fact be compared" (p.154). In other words, prior to data collection, selection criteria are established to ensure that both data sets are comparable. The first criterion is that both corpora must consist of the same genre. The second criterion is that the field in which the texts are produced should also be similar. Third, in order to compare two natural and authentic set of data, the texts from the two languages have to be written by the native speakers of the respective languages, determined from the name of the author. However, this criterion is not applicable to unsigned and unnamed NEs, making it one of the limitations faced in this research. The coding and identification of linguistic realizations of hedging and boosting is done by the researcher alone, because it is difficult to find English and Arab native-speaker expert volunteers carry out the coding or identification tasks in the present research.

2.5 Corpus Description and Size

The current research analyzes two data sets, each consisting of 40 NEs—20 written in English by Anglo-American ENErs and 20 written in Modern Standard Arabic (MSA) by ANErs. The first data is the English corpus, which consists of 20 ENEs often labeled under the title of *opinion articles* or editorials. The second one is the Arabic corpus, which comprises 20 ANEs often labeled under the headline of *al-ra'ay articles* (مقالات الرأي /*opinion articles*) or under the headline of *iftitaḥīya* (افتتاحية /editorial) (also known as comment columns and opinion columns).

The whole two corpora, which comprise 40 NEs, 20 ENEs and 20 ANEs, amounts to 29,744 words. The English corpus contains 15,692 words, whereas the Arabic Corpus contains 14,052 words. Oostdijk (1991, p.50) reports that "a sample size of 20,000 words would yield samples that are large enough to be representative of a given variety." It can be said that the current two corpora were sufficient and representative, as the number of words in the two sets of data is over 20,000 words. The NEs are all published during the period between 1 January and 1 August, 2021 due to the assumption that time influences the style and convention of writing. The two corpora are drawn from the electronic versions of major international and national daily Arabic and English newspapers as table 2.2 illustrates:

Table 2.2 Distribution of ENEs and ANEs

Name of English Newspaper	**Number of Editorials**	**Name of Arabic Newspaper**	**Number of Editorials**
The New York Times	7	Alwatan Syrian (الوطن السورية)	5
The Independent	1	Alquds (القدس)	4
The Guardian	5	Alshaarq alwsat (الشرق الاوسط)	5
The New York Post	2	Alhram (الأهرام)	1
The Washington Post	3	Qassioun (قاسيون)	4
Los Angeles Times	1	Tishreen (تشرين)	1
The USA Today	1	Total	20
Total	20		

These NEs are randomly selected from a pool of leading and influential newspapers in the Anglo-American and Arab World. These newspapers were selected due to their large circulation, global reach, significance in the media industry, and their wide-ranging coverage of diverse topics in both the international Anglo-American and Arab Worlds. As table 2.2 shows, 20 ENEs are selected from 7 Anglo-American newspapers, and 20 ANEs from 6 Arabic ones. Table 2.2 shows that the selected English newspapers are: The New York Times, the Independent, the Guardian, the New York Post, the Washington Post, Los Angeles Times, and the USA Today. The chosen Arabic newspapers are: Al-Watan Syrian (الوطن السورية), Al-Qūds (القدس), Al-Shārq Al-Awsat (الشرق الأوسط), Al-Ahrām (الأهرام), Qassiūn (قاسيون), Tishrīn (تشرين).

These newspapers are leading daily international newspapers because of their professional and well-known experienced journalists or editors. All these newspapers are printed and distributed simultaneously in Europe, the Middle East, the UK, and the USA, which means that they have an extensive market in the World. Although there may be minor differences in their

styles, these professional writers represent a writing sample following the convention of newspaper discourse in the English-speaking and Arab countries. These NEs are written in variable length, ranging from a 200-word text to a 1350-word text. The subjects covered in these NEs primarily focused on political issues that are significant to both the local community and the global population due to their impact on people's lives (Maynard, 1996; Van Dijk, 1998). The texts analyzed in the present research represent a single genre of journalistic writing, specifically NEs. McCarten argues that corpora containing various genres can lead to misleading findings (2010, p. 414). Thus, it is essential to construct a corpus consisting solely of NEs written by ANErs and ENErs to guarantee the data's representativeness and comparability.

2.6 Statistical Procedures

Once the hedging and boosting features in the data are quantified, the frequency of each category or subcategory, along with other relevant variables in the two main corpora and their sub-corpora, is input into SPSS (version 22) software, a program used to calculate statistical significance. SPSS software can be effective in identifying and analyzing the raw and mean frequency of use of hedging and boosting for the two corpora. Following the counting and recording of the total occurrences of hedging and boosting features based on formal categories and subcategories, the mean frequency of these features *per one thousand words* (PTW) is calculated for each text group and for each category individually. The relative frequency is calculated per one thousand words (PTW) to allow for fair comparison between the two corpora and categories, as the sample sizes are inherently unequal (English corpus = 15,692 words; Arabic corpus = 14,052 words). In fact, the ANEs are comparatively shorter than their English counterparts. Therefore, the analysis is conducted on normalized, rather than absolute or raw occurrences of hedging and boosting. According to Biber (2009, p.1299), when examining the counts of features across texts, “it is important to make sure that the scores are comparable.” This process is very common to academic researchers, and they name it *normalization*. Normalization of counts refers to “a way to convert raw counts into rates of occurrence, so that the scores from texts of different lengths can be compared” (Biber, Conrad, & Reppen, 1998, p.1299). The following normalization formula is used to change raw frequencies into normalized mean frequencies for all the values of the two corpora:

$$\boldsymbol{Mean\ Frequency\ PTW} = \frac{\boldsymbol{No.of\ occurrences\ of\ hedges\ in\ a\ text}}{\boldsymbol{No.\ of\ words\ of\ the\ text}}$$

Thus, 1,000 value is used as a base number of normalization. Adopting a higher basis, for

example, 10,000 words would result in artificial inflation of rare features, more particularly in ANEs (Biber, 2009). For example, if a text containing 1,110 words includes 44 hedging features, the normalized mean frequency (MF) of these features is 39.63, rounded to two decimal places.

2.7 Summary

The present chapter introduced the methodology the research applied to achieve its objectives and answer research questions. It presented the analytical model adopted to identify the use of hedging and boosting features, the nature of present research, the research method, which was applied, the procedures of data collection, the corpus description and size, and concluded with the statistical procedures, which were done to obtain valid results. Next chapter provides a theoretical and empirical review of the literature in relevance to hedging and boosting features.

Chapter Three

Review of Literature

This chapter aims to provide a theoretical background that puts the research within the body of relevant literature. It reviews the development of such concepts as discourse and metadiscourse and concurrent emergence of hedging and phenomena. It also gives an account of the concept of hedging and its evolution. Following this, the chapter reviews the literature of boosting concept and scholars' views of the phenomenon. Afterwards, the chapter provides some perspectives and approaches that investigated the feature of hedging and boosting. It also highlights some characteristics of the genre of newspaper editorials (NEs) which the current research analyzes. This chapter also provides some approaches that investigated hedging and boosting in Arabic language, and it concludes with some previous research that is conducted in relevance to such features.

3.1 Theoretical Framework

3.1.1 Discourse and Metadiscourse

Before exploring the literature relevant to hedging and boosting features, it is important to clarify; as previously mentioned, two main levels of analysis in language: *Discourse* and *metadiscours*e. In simple terms, words are grammatically structured into phrases, clauses and sentences to function meaningfully in various contexts. Similarly, sentences are systematically and rhetorically arranged together to produce a *text* or *discourse*. Discourse is a linguistic unit that comprises more than one sentence structured and arranged systematically to function in different contexts. To understand any discourse, we should examine its smallest elements and its socio-cultural and pragmatic context where it is written. Simply, a linguist carries out a discourse analysis to explore those elements and features that define this discourse. Discourse analysis examines the forms and functions of linguistic features of language in use and their social and cultural properties. Examining discourse features includes also analyzing what linguists (e.g., Hyland, 1999, 1998; Myers, 1989; Salager-Meyer, 1994; Skelton, 1988) categorize as *metadiscourse*. Researchers and linguists commonly distinguish two core components of coherent texts: Propositional content, which conveys factual or informational material, and metadiscursive elements, which guide readers through the text's structure and aid interpretation of its core ideas. Thus, discourse is the

propositional materials, whereas metadiscourse is the non-propositional ones.

Metadiscourse is a prominent linguistic feature frequently used in language and has attracted increasing scholarly interest across diverse theoretical and analytical frameworks, particularly for its role in shaping interactional features within texts (e.g., Atai & Sadr, 2008; Davoodifard, 2006; Falahati, 2004; Hyland, 1999, 1998a; Myers, 1989; Salager-Meyer, 1994; & Skelton, 1988). According to Vande Kopple (1985), "metadiscourse refers to those features which writers include to help readers decode their message, share the writer's views and reflect the particular conventions that are followed in a given culture" (p.97). Hyland (2005b) defines metadiscourse as "the cover term for the self-reflective expressions used to negotiate interactional meanings in a text, assist the writer (or speaker) to express a viewpoint and engage with readers as members of a particular community" (P.98). In this way, a text does not only consist of information but also includes other features that guide the reader and help the writer convey his/her purpose and attitude. According to Vande Kopple and Crismore (1997), primary discourse is primarily concerned with *ideational function*, whereas metadiscourse is related to textual and interpersonal function of the language. Sultan (2011) states that metadiscourse has been analyzed across diverse textual genres, including textbooks, dissertations, advertisements, research articles, and casual conversations, with notable emphasis on news discourse (e.g., Hyland, 1998a, 1998b, 2005a, 2017; Dafouz-Milne 2008). Hyland (2000) argues that writers not only construct discourse to convey objective content but also actively negotiate the validity of their positions, strategically frame arguments, and balance factual assertions with evaluative commentary and certainty with measured caution, which is a dynamic interplay facilitated through metadiscoursal feature.

According to Hyland (2005a), Zelling Hariss (1959) has been the first scholar to propose the concept of metadiscourse, According to Hariss (1959), metadiscourse is introduced "to offer a way of understanding language in use, representing a writer's or speakers' attempts to guide a receiver's perception of a text" (Hyland, 2005a, p.3). To clarify more, metadiscourse as a new concept in the area of discourse analysis, refers to the way speakers and writers address and communicate with their audience. Linguists have been recently interested more often in metadiscourse analysis than discourse analysis of language (e.g., Schiffrin, 1980; Williams, 1981; Van de Kopple, 1985; Crismore et al., 1993; & Hyland, 2005a). Hyland and Tse (2004) have investigated metadiscourse through an interpersonal lens, arguing that all metadiscoursal elements inherently function as interpersonal features, as they explicitly address readers' prior knowledge,

textual familiarity, and cognitive demands. Metadiscourse scholars (e.g., Hyland, 2005a; Vande Kopple & Crismore, 1997; Crismore et al., 1993) have proposed several taxonomies of metadiscourse. Hyland (2005a, p.49) proposes one of the most comprehensive model of metadiscourse. His model, which was developed from previous linguists' models (i.e.,Vande Kopple, 1985 & Crismore et al., 1993), consists of two major categories of metadiscourse: *Interactive* and *interactional*. Interactive metadiscourse structures the text to enhance its coherence, cohesion, and persuasiveness for the audience, whereas interactional metadiscourse functions to engage the reader by guiding him/her through the discourse. The interactional metadiscours involves the writer's direct dialogic interaction, such as commenting on or evaluating their own claims. Interactive features include organizational strategies such as *transitions*, *frame markers*, endophoric references, *evidentials*, and *code glosses*. *Transitions* create relations between main clauses in the text (e.g., in addition, and, but, thus, and so on). *Frame markers* refer to discourse acts, sequences, or stages of parts of the text (e.g., first, next, finally, to conclude, and others). *Endophoric markers* are used to refer to information in other parts of the text (e.g., as noted above, see Fig, in section, and others). *Evidentials* are used to refer to information from other texts (e.g. according to X, Z states, and others). *Code glosses* are used to clarify propositional meanings (e.g., namely, for example, such as, in other words, and others). *Interactional metadiscourse* includes *hedging*, *boosting*, *attitude markers*, *self-mentions*, and *engagement markers*. *Hedging* is used to indicate imprecision and establish a dialogue with the reader (e.g., might, perhaps, possible, about, and so on). *Boosting* is used to emphasize precision or close a dialogue with the reader (e.g., in fact, definitely, obviously, it is clear that, demonstrate, and so on). *Attitude markers* indicate the writer's attitude to the proposition (e.g., unfortunately, hopefully, surprisingly, I agree, and others). *Self-mentions* are an explicit reference to the author in the text (e.g., I, we, my, me, our, and so on). *Engagement markers* explicitly build a relationship between the writer and the reader (you, your, consider, note, you can see that, and so on) (Hyland, 2005a, p.49).

The researcher is precisely interested in exploring two categories of interactional metadiscourse namely hedging and boosting. Hedging and boosting considered by many researchers (e.g., Hyland, 1999, 1998a, 2005a; Myers, 1989; Salager-Meyer, 1994; Skelton, 1988) the most typical realization of interactional metadiscourse. Metadiscourse in general and hedging and boosting in particular have been studied in journalistic discourse namely NEs and proved to

have persuasive effects in newspaper discourse (Dafouz-Milne, 2008; Buitkienė, 2008; Moghadam, 2017).

3.1.2 Concept of Hedging

Hedging, a multifaceted component of interpersonal metadiscourse, has drawn extensive scholarly inquiry. Its functions have been analyzed through frameworks such as politeness theory (Brown & Levinson, 1978, 1987; Leech, 1983), semantic interpretation (Lakoff, 1973), formal logic systems (McCawley, 1981; Zadeh, 1972), and pragmatic explorations of its communicative functions (Hyland, 1995, 1997; Markkanen & Schröder, 2000; Varttala, 1999, 2001; Vassileva, 2001). According to Oxford Dictionary (2016), to hedge against something is "to avoid giving a direct answer to a question or a promising to support a particular idea, etc." Similarly, a hedge against something is "a way of protecting yourself against the loss of something, especially money" (Oxford University Press, Hedge, 2016). Hedging refers to linguistic features that reduce the force of an assertion to indicate uncertainty, politeness, or subjectivity (Hyland, 1998a; Salager-Meyer, 1994). Therefore, whenever writers or speakers of a language hedge their claims or propositions (i.e. main elements of information) in their discourse, they defend themselves against something, for instance, criticism or absolute commitment. Functionally, hedging serves as a linguistic feature to mitigate the force of statements, functioning as a critical component of socially attuned communication by balancing directness with politeness. Hedging functions to mitigate the assertiveness of statements, thereby reducing the potential for *face-threatening acts* (FTAs) in communicative interactions (Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed, 2019. Additionally, hedging has been interchangeably linked with concepts like *mitigation* (Holmes, 1984, p. 346; Hyland, 1998b, p. 10) and *attenuation* (Hu & Cao, 2011, p. 2796). Hyland (1998a) defines hedging as "an item of language which a speaker uses to explicitly qualify his/her lack of commitment to the truth of a proposition he/she utters" (p. 281). According to Hyland (1998a), hedging can be used to indicate either: "(a) a lack of complete commitment to the truth value of an accompanying proposition or (b) a desire not to express that commitment categorically" (p.1). The following example illustrates the use of hedging in English:

(a) *All I know* is that smoking is harmful to your health.

The hedging phrase *All I know* functions to qualify the speaker's epistemic certainty, signaling that the proposition *smoking is harmful* is framed not as an absolute truth but as a claim depends the speaker's subjective knowledge and evaluative capacity. According to Fraser (2007,

p. 201),

> Hedging as a rhetorical strategy is associated with all means that lead to lack of a full commitment. By including a particular term, choosing a particular structure, or imposing a specific prosodic form on the utterance, the speaker signals a lack of a full commitment either to the full category membership of a term or expression in the utterance (content mitigation), or to the intended illocutionary force of the utterance (force mitigation).

Hedging is a linguistic feature that can establish an interaction between the writer and the reader in the text and create a relationship between the writer and the message intended to be expressed. That is to say, whenever a writer hedges his/her propositions, he/she also aims to strengthen his/her relationship with his/her readers since he/she avoids imposing claims or views on them. Moreover, a speaker can state a proposition as fact by inserting a boosting feature (e.g. this medicine *will* help you recover quickly), or he/she can use a hedging feature to avoid complete responsibility when he/she presents a claim (e.g. I *believe* that this medicine *could* help you recover quickly).

3.1.3 Concept of Boosting

Boosting in metadiscourse refers to a linguistic feature used by writers or speakers to express a high level of certainty, commitment, or emphasis in their statements. Unlike hedging, which signals doubt or caution, boosting strengthens claims, making them appear more assertive, authoritative, and persuasive (Hyland, 2005a). Boosting encompasses linguistic features such as *clearly*, *obviously*, *undoubtedly*, *in fact*, and *of course*, which signal the author/speaker's conviction in their propositions. Contrary to hedging features, boosting has received comparatively less scholarly scrutiny (Vassileva, 2001).However, both hedging and boosting are important linguistic features, which writers or speakers use in persuasive texts to indicate both doubt and certainty in their propositions. Boosting and hedging features are categorized as *epistemic modality* (Martin, 2000), which demonstrates a writer or speaker's confidence or lack of confidence in the propositional information that he/she presents (Coates, 2003). To persuade the reader into adopting a certain view and express a degree of confidence, the writer uses boosting features such as *of course*, *clear*, *clearly*, *certainly*, *definitely*, *obviously*, and so on. According to Hyland (1998a), boosting is used to support a writer's statement or argument. Boosting functions to emphasize the writer's conviction in a proposition and persuade the audience by increasing the argument's logical

rigor and persuasive impact. Similarly, writers use boosting to comment impersonally on the validity of their propositions. “Boosters are emphatic features, which allow writers to close down alternatives, avoid conflicting views, and express their certainty in what they say” (Hyland, 2005a, p. 52). As Hyland (2005a) clearly states that, “by closing down possible alternatives, boosters emphasize certainty and construct rapport by marking involvement with the topic and solidarity with an audience, taking a joint position against other voices” (p. 53).

According to Hyland (1998b), boosters or emphatics are defined through their function as the markers that help their users to express opinions, state a suggestion with confidence in their knowledge of the topic, and reduce the likelihood of acknowledging or pursuing alternative possibilities. Various terminologies, such as *certainty markers*, *emphatics*, and *modality markers*, have been proposed to characterize the linguistic expression of confidence in a proposition. Accordingly, scholars have conceptualized a continuum of certainty to delineate the spectrum of assertiveness conveyed by writers, ranging from complete certainty to tentative claims, with varying levels in between (Holmes, 1982; Rubin, 2007). Moreover, Hyland (2008) suggests that boosters might help bring readers to the text or involve them in building some kind of solidarity. Holmes (1982) argues that NEs, functioning as the institutional voice of newspapers, employ pragmatic boosters to assertively articulate the publication’s stance on contemporary issues, thereby reinforcing its editorial authority. Boosting features include: Modal verbs (*must, will, cannot*). Adverbs of certainty (*undoubtedly, clearly, certainly*), emphatic lexical verbs (*demonstrates, proves, confirms*), superlatives and intensifiers (*the most significant, extremely, highly*).

Jalilifar and Alavi-Nai (2012) classifies boosters into:

(1) Propositional boosters, which include intensifiers and personal involvement pronouns (e.g., must, will, clearly, undoubtedly, and so on).

(2) Illocutionary force boosters, which include boosting epistemic commitment (e.g., prove, assert, confirm, considerably, of course, and so on).

(3) Content oriented boosters, which include source tagging and bounding emphatics (the most obvious, the most significant, no doubt, and so on).

(4) Hearer oriented boosters, which aim at seeking solidarity and presupposing verification (it is clearly, as we know, strictly speaking, and so on).

3.1.4 Form and Function of Hedging and Boosting Features

Linguistic form and function are inseparably interconnected, a reciprocal relationship that has been extensively theorized and analyzed in scholarly inquiry. According to Fraser (2010), "the connectedness between the form and function of a hedge is at the heart of investigation in pragmatics" (p.27). Richards and Schmidt (2010) state that form-function relation is "the relationship between the physical characteristics of a thing (i.e. its form) and its role or function" (p.208). For instance, a linguistic form (e.g. modal verbs) can perform a variety of different functions such as hedging, boosting, polite requests, possibility, and so on (Amiryousefi & Rasekh, 2010). To put it differently, every linguistic form is intrinsically tied to a distinct function or meaning within a specific context. *Form* include lexical and grammatical elements (such as main verbs, adjectives, adverbs, nouns, and modal auxiliaries) that serve as fundamental structures in most languages, and *function* refers to the social and pragmatic purpose of using such forms. The question that always raised by scholars: Is there a definite list of invariable forms that always function as hedging and boosting features. For several researchers, providing a definite list of hedging or boosting features feasible to various contexts is next to impossible. Hedging and boosting do not have a one-to-one correspondence between form and function, as their interpretation depends heavily on contextual and discursive variables. A single linguistic structure (e.g., modal verbs, adverbs) may serve as a hedge, a booster, or neither, depending on its communicative context. This functional flexibility complicates attempts to categorize lexico-grammatical forms into fixed pragmatic functions. Furthermore, the diverse discursive contexts in which these features operate necessitate adaptable frameworks to account for their varied realizations across genres and communicative purposes. "Particular items can therefore only be understood as expressions of doubt and certainty by attending to the context in which they occur. Meanings do not reside in the items themselves but are assigned to utterances which contain them" (Fraser, 2010, 223). In other words, since there is no single taxonomy of hedging and boosting that is feasible to analyze all types of speech and writing discourse, researchers often conduct a manual contextual analysis to approach such features and create their own taxonomies to specifically identify occurrences of such linguistic features and deal with their data sets. Researchers may choose to adopt a formal taxonomy (e.g., Hinkel, 2005; Salager-Meyer, 1994, 2010; & Fraser, 2010), where categorization is based on the grammatical classification of each feature, or a functional taxonomy (e.g., Prince et al., 1980, Hyland 1998a, 2005a), where categorization is based on the function of such features and their contextual use.

3.1.4.1 Forms of Hedging and Boosting Features

a) Modality

The first category of hedging and boosting is *modality.* Modality refers to a range of lexical and grammatical forms such as modal verbs, adjectives, adverbs, and nouns that allow speakers and writers to denote degrees of tentativeness, emphasis, likelihood, and projection of future events. These forms are frequently employed to hedge or boost claims, express possibility or probability, and convey predictions or obligations within discourse. According to Hyland (1998b), modality is one principal means by which writers convey hedging that is, expressions of uncertainty or tentative stance and is likely the most pervasive hedging strategy employed by English users. One of the most universally common realizations of modality across languages is the modal verb, which Zhang and Chen (2020) observe to be particularly frequent in news commentary, serving to denote the author's stance toward their claims. Extensive research on English (Hyland 1998a; 1998b) and cross-linguistic research have emphasized that modal verbs regularly indicate epistemic meanings such as doubt, possibility, confidence, and certainty thus functioning as key features of a speaker's or writer's epistemic attitude. Modal verbs such as may, might, should, could, would, can, must, and shall function as self-referential linguistic features that indicate epistemic modality, allowing speakers or writers to soften, strengthen, or otherwise shape the force of their statements. As Varttala (2001) observes, these verbs help authors reinforce their stance within a discourse. Lyons (1977, p.797) further clarifies that, unlike *deontic modality* (which deals with obligation and permission), *epistemic modality* specifically involves the speaker's indication of how firmly they modify the truth of the proposition they express. The writer/speaker uses epistemic modality to convey his or her level of knowledge and beliefs regarding the information presented as shown in the following example:

(a) Beginner readers *may* not even know the phrase meaning.

(b) It was not his war (although he did nothing to stop it), and he *would* like to move on.

(c) He *must* act now to help prevent a repetition.

However, *deontic modality* occurs to convey obligation, possibility, necessity, and permission and reflects the speaker/writer's "attitude towards the desirability (or non-desirability) of certain actions or events" (Lyons, 1977 as cited in Fraser, 2010, p.67). In example (c) above, *must* is used to express deontic modality indicating the necessity of Brown's action in order to stop the war in Iraq. Epistemic modality, therefore, is related to the speaker/writer's knowledge and

beliefs towards the information he/she presents or related to his/her confidence or lack of confidence towards the truth of the proposition expressed. However, deontic modality, Lyons (1977) states, is related to the necessity or possibility of acts performed by morally responsible agents. *Deontic modality* refers to expressions of obligation, duty, volition, and reflects the speaker/writer's attitude toward the desirability (or nondesirability) of certain actions or events. This distinction depends on the function and context within which these modals occur (Al-Ajmi, 2015, p.31). To put it simply, hedging and boosting are closely related to epistemic modality, as they both reflect the speaker's level of knowledge about the proposition or their degree of confidence in what they claim.

Martin-Martin (2008, p.29) refers to hedges and boosters by using the term epistemic modalities. He states that "writers use epistemic modalities to communicate their academic knowledge in a way which permits them to get community acceptance of their academic contributions excluding the risk of Face Threatening Acts." According to Palmer (2006, p.2), "English uses a modal verb to distinguish a judgment about a proposition from a categorical statement" as the following examples show: (a) Mary is at home (factual proposition) (b) Mary *may* be at home (epistemic modal verb, low degree of probability) (c) Mary *must* be at home (epistemic modal verb, high degree of probability). These functions are typically epistemic since, they denote the speaker's assessment of a proposition's truth value , and other *deontic* functions, which involve the meanings of obligation, necessity, ability, or permission of the verbal event. Unlike the Arabic modal system, the system of modal verbs in English is rather complex as most of modal verbs are polysemous. In English, modal verbs such as *can*, *shall*, *will*, *could*, *should*, *would*, *may*, and *must* might serve two main functions or more depending on the context of their use.

Hyland (1994) states that modal adjectives such as *possible*, *probable*, *potential*, *and apparent* serve to convey varying degrees of certainty or uncertainty. Hyland (1998a) argues that modal adjectives as hedging features are used more frequently than other subcategories of modality in RAs because they function to downgrade the writer's commitment towards the claim presented. Varttala (2001, p.125) states that modal adjectives "can be used to indicate tentative, uncertain and not quite precise characteristics of nouns or actions." Modal adverbs such as *probably*, *possibly*, *apparently*, *likely*, *unlikely*, and others are also used at comparable rates with modal adjectives as hedging features to show some degree of tentativeness towards the proposition the writer presents

in the text. They are used to affect the proposition's meaning because of their function as *downgraders* (Hyland, 1998a). Modal nouns are nouns that function similarly to modal adjectives and adverbs as they might modify epistemically the writer's proposition (e.g., likelihood, assumption, claim, estimate, possibility, suggestion, and so on).

b) Epistemic Lexical Verbs

The second category of hedging and boosting is *epistemic lexical verbs*. This category, which includes such verbs as *believe, suggest, indicate, assume, tend to, see, assert, confirm,* and others, indicate various degrees of the writer/speaker's knowledge or cognition (Hyland, 1998a). These verbs serve to modify the speaker's or writer's absolute commitment to the claims they present. They can also indicate a particular degree of doubting or uncertainty presenting a subjective opinion or suggestion rather than a fact (Perkins, 1983, as cited in Hyland, 1994, p.248). Carrio-Pastor (2017) argues that writers are more likely to use these verbs to shape their stance on a topic, to the amplify claims they make in their research, and to reduce the risk of the reader's opposition. *Non-factive reporting verbs* (e.g. suggest, argue, state, and others) are an important subcategory of epistemic lexical verbs, which are used to report other writer's results or describe the author's own research. Another subcategory of such verbs is *tentative cognition verbs* (e.g., hope, think, suspect, realize, and others), which indicate the mental status of the author whose work is being reported. "The information they (i.e. *tentative cognition verbs*) introduce in one way or another based on subjective cognitive activity rather than uncontroversial empirical evidence" (Varttala, 2001, p.122). In other words, *tentative cognition verbs* are used to indicate the writer/speaker's confidant imprecision rather than his/her lack of knowledge.

c) Introductory Phrases/Verbs

Introductory phrases or *verbs* may have a similar function and meaning to epistemic lexical verbs (e.g., to our knowledge, it is our view that, it is worth mentioning, we confirm that, and others) in that they can hedge or boost a proposition. This category may indicate writer/speaker's uncertainty, certainty, imprecision, or precision towards the claim he/she presents (Salager-Meyer, 2010). As a boosting feature, it can function to increase the writer or speaker's confidence or certainty (e.g., it is clear, it is certain, and so on).

d) Adverbs and Adjectives of Degree, Frequency, Quantity or Time (Approximators)

Adverbs of degree, *frequency*, *quantity* or *time* (e.g., approximately, roughly, about, often, occasionally, sometimes, generally, seldom, usually, somewhat, rarely, somehow, frequently,

never, completely, and others), might indicate the indefiniteness or definiteness towards the meaning, entity, or number presented by the writer/speaker. Such adverbs allow writers to hedge against error or objection particularly when precise data are unavailable (Varttala, 2001, p.122). Varttala (2001, p.132) further explains that they soften a statement's impact by avoiding to provide exact figures essentially approximating the verb's force. These adverbs can appear before a verb to lessen its strength (e.g. I *almost* resigned), can give tentative approximations avoiding to provide exact numerical information (e.g. *about* 50 percent), or pre-modify pronouns (e.g. *almost* everyone). Hedging adverbs primarily function to engage readers in a dialogue by avoiding to provide rigid claims or total commitment (Ibrahim, Kadir & Abbas, 2019). Other adverbs of frequency "seek to express only part of the potential force of the item concerned" (e.g., fairly, slightly, considerably, greatly, largely, partly, mostly, relatively, significantly, completely, obviously, and so on) (Ibrahim et al., 2019). Adjectives denoting degree, frequency, quantity, or time (e.g., common, frequent, rare, popular, or typical) can likewise indicate an unspecified level, frequency, or time. In other words, they might indicate tentative quantifications where it is not exactly necessary, known, or possible to quantify entities (Ibrahim et al., 2019). All these types of adjectives help writers "draw attention to the approximate nature of the information presented" (Varttala, 2001, p.125).

e) Conditional Clauses and Clausal Elements

Conditional clauses indicate the circumstances that enable a speaker or writer to modify claims tentatively or non-definitively and avoid providing absolute assertions and categorical commitments (Fraser, 2010). (e.g. If there is no solution to such crisis, this will particularly threaten the lives of hundreds of people). Other forms of conditional clause include *if true*, *if nothing*, *if anything*, and others (e.g. If true, then, the study contradicts the myth that fishing attracts the bravest and strongest men). Hyland (1998a, p.141) categorizes conditional clauses functioning as hedges as *non-lexical hedges*, since the clause rather than a word or expression which affects the truth condition of the proposition. Other clausal elements functioning as hedges or boosters include sentences containing tentative words or concessive conjunctions such as *although*, *though*, *while*, *whereas*, *even though*, *even if*, and others (e.g. although he improved his speaking skills, he spoke very awkwardly in the meeting).

f) Rhetorical Questions

Rhetorical questions convey the speaker's viewpoint without expecting an answer, serving

instead to assert imprecisely and tentatively a claim. Salager-Meyer (2010) states that these questions functioning as hedges are the most effective linguistic features in developing argumentation and establishing a relationship between the writer and reader (e.g. can the president avoid solving the crisis of fuel and housing?).

g) Compound Hedging and Boosting

In addition to previous categories of hedging, Salager-Meyer (1994) proposes another hedging category labeling it as compound hedging. *Compound hedging* refers to multiple categories of hedging occurring together in a proposition. One of the most frequent forms of compound hedges and boosters in English includes:

1- A modal verb combined with a lexical verb functioning as a hedge or booster (e.g., it would appear, it will confirm, a double feature).

2- A lexical verb combined with an adverb or adjective (e.g., it seems probable, it seems likely that, it confirms clearly, or double feature).

3- A lexical verb followed by an adverb or adjective followed by a lexical verb (e.g., it seems reasonable to assume that, a triple feature).

4- A modal verb followed by a lexical verb followed by two adverbs or adjectives (e.g., it would seem somewhat unlikely that, a quadruple feature).

3.1.4.2 Functions of Hedging and Boosting

Several linguists (Hyland, 1994, 1998a, 1998b; Salager-Meyer; 1994, 2010; Skelton, 1988; Fraser 1990, 2010; and others) have identified particular pragmatic functions that hedging and boosting features have in addition to the semantic functions presented previously. Their classifications of these features were based on functional considerations. As linguistic features used in oral or written texts, hedging and boosting vary in their function within different communicative situations. Hyland (2005a) and Hinkel (2009) state that *modal verbs* can perform diverse pragmatic and textual functions indicating aspects such as likelihood, possibility, evidentiality, politeness, strategic vagueness, as well as uncertainty and certainty in discourse. Similarly, hedging and boosting can serve different functions that can change according to the context of propositional situation itself. A speaker can state a proposition as fact by using a booster (e.g. this medicine *will* help you recover quickly), or he/she can use a hedge to distance himself/herself from a claim (e.g. I *believe* that this medicine *could* help you recover quickly. Skelton (1988) argues that hedging might show distance (as cited in Salager-Meyer, 1994). In other

words, hedging allows the writer or speaker to show distance between himself/herself and his/her assertions, enabling him/her their stance especially when there is a possibility their claims might face criticism or rejection within their discourse community(Hyland, 1998b). According to Holmes (1988, p.22), hedging can be considered as a politeness feature that indicate "deference rather than uncertainty". To put it differently, one important pragmatic function of hedging is to indicate the writer/speaker's politeness and respect towards the reader/listener, since by using hedging the speaker/writer avoid imposing views on the listener/reader. Moreover, according to Varttala (1999), hedging can function as an *interpersonal positive politeness* feature, which helps the writer build a strong relationship with the reader and draw the reader to participate in the academic conversation. Halliday and Hasan (1985) argue that every utterance carries not only ideational content but also interpersonal meaning. In other words, hedging is a key interpersonal feature of linguistic utterances. Hyland (1998a; 1998b) claims that hedging can function as *downtoners* and can be divided into four categories, namely: (a) *Compromiser* (e.g., quite, usually, normally, and others); (b) *diminisher* (e.g., partially, slightly, and others); (c) *minimizers* (e.g., rarely, occasionally, and others); and (d) *approximators* (e.g., almost, virtually, & relatively).

Salager-Meyer (1994) provides five main categories of hedging based on their functional objectives:

(a) **Shields** encompass modal verbs and semi-auxiliary verbs that denote possibility (e.g., *may*, *would*, *must*, *will*, *appear*, *seem*), adverbs expressing probability (e.g., *probably* , *likely*), and epistemic verbs (e.g., *suggest*, *speculate*).

(b) **Approximators** include terms or phrases that qualify quantity, degree, frequency, or time, such as *approximately*, *roughly*, *around*, *about*, *somewhat*, *quite*, *often*, and *occasionally*.

(c) **Authors' Insufficiency and Doubt** involve phrases that explicitly signal the writer's uncertainty or personal perspective, such as *I believe*, *to our knowledge*, *it is our view that*, *in our opinion*, *we assume*, or *to the best of our understanding*.

(d) **Emotionally-Charged Expressions** are evaluative words or phrases reflecting the author's subjective reactions such as *extremely difficult*, *surprisingly*, *of particular importance*, *unexpectedly*, or *particularly noteworthy).*

(e) **Compound Hedges** combine multiple hedging devices such as *may suggest*, *would seem likely that*, *it seems reasonable to assume*, or *it would appear somewhat improbable that*.

Moreover, according to Hyland (1998a), hedging can serve two primary functions: The first function indicates a lack of commitment towards the truth of proposition on the part of speaker/writer. The second one serves as a mitigating feature and politeness strategy to reduce the force and the effect of utterances in order to make the listener/reader accept what has claimed in a spoken or written language. Fraser (1975) introduces the term *hedged performative*. He states that certain performative verbs such as *apologize*, *promise*, and *request* when preceded by a specific modal verb could function as hedging features resulting in a mitigated and modified illocutionary force of the speech act as the following example below shows: (a) I *should* apologize for running over your cat. Similarly, according to several linguists (e.g. Hinkel, 1997; Swales, 1990; Swales & Feak, 1994; Salager-Meyer, 1994, 2010), in written discourse, different lexico-grammatical categories of hedging are used to decrease the writer's responsibility towards the truth-value of propositions or claims, indicate hesitation, uncertainty, indirectness, or politeness, and reduce imposing claims on the reader. The following two examples were adopted from Varttala's (2001) model of hedging clarify the point:

1. This drug *may* help.
2. Penguins are *sort of* birds.

The use of hedging features in these two examples *may* and *sort of*, functions to indicate a particular degree of imprecision in the utterances and that the writer/speaker wants to modify his/her commitment regarding the accuracy of what is claimed (Varttala 2001, as cited in Tahririan & Shahzamani, 2009). Similarly, boosting as a metadiscourse feature serves several functions in academic and persuasive writing. According to Hyland (2005b), boosters are features that emphasize certainty and conviction, helping writers strengthen their claims and persuade readers. They indicate the writer's complete commitment to a proposition and enhance credibility and assertiveness in arguments. Boosters such as *clearly*, *undoubtedly*, and *certainly* express confidence, reducing potential ambiguity in communication (Hyland, 2000). Additionally, boosting serves to build a solid relationship with readers by emphasizing common knowledge or widely recognized ideas (Crismore & Farnsworth, 1990). Writers or speakers may use boosting features to harmonize their perspective with the audience, thereby enhancing the persuasiveness of their claims (Hyland, 1998b).

3.1.5 Genre of Newspaper Editorial (NE)

According to Swales (1990), "*genre* refers to language use in a conventionalized

communicative setting in order to give expression to a specific set of communicative goals" (p.122). In other words, genre encompasses established structures or recurring elements within texts, shaped by specific contexts that a discourse community employs to engage in shared communication. These are specified frameworks or conventions recognized by the community to facilitate purposeful interaction and achieve collective goals (Swales, 1990). In constructing a text, the writer is supposed to employ certain features that are conventionally associated with such text constituting the genre that he or she is writing in. Genre can be defined as a category of text shaped by the social and cultural norms and conventions expected by its intended audience. In this definition, text types are defined by the communicative purposes these texts achieve (i.e. NEs as a genre have a particular communicative purpose such as persuasion). Therefore, texts can be categorized into specific genres according to their primary communicative aims and stylistic characteristics. Several scholars (e.g., Swales, 1990; Bhatia, 2004; Ansary & Babaii, 2009) argue that genres inherently possess distinct features such as linguistic, paralinguistic, contextual, or pragmatic elements that enable writers to fulfill the genre's intended purpose. These characteristics, however, may vary across different discourses and text types, even within or between languages.

Newspapers contain different types of articles or *genres* that may have a different pattern of linguistic and discursive properties. These various types of genre according to Bhatia (1993) include: Headlines, news reports, sports reports, newspaper editorials (NEs), news stories, letters, advertisements, and others. Scholars define NEs as a genre of written argumentative discourse that has a persuasive and argumentative purpose, and they are considered as the most influential, rhetorically charged, and discourse-oriented genre in newspaper contexts (Al-Khatib, Wachsmuth, Kiesel, Hagen, & Stein, 2016, p. 3433). In NEs, a writer may state and defend a claim that conveys his or her stance on a controversial topic usually related to the public interest (Al-Khatib et al., 2016). Discourse analysts (e.g., Al-Khatib et al., 2016) identify some general global characteristics of NEs: First, these articles articulate the publication's official stance on a topic and are consistently located in a designated section of the newspaper. Second, they are typically anonymous, with lengths spanning 200 to 1,500 words. Third, newspaper editors (NErs) construct structured arguments aimed at convincing readers to adopt their viewpoint. Fourth, NEs aim to shape public opinion, stimulate critical thinking, and occasionally prompt action regarding specific issues (Al-Khatib et al., 2016). NEs tackle topics that are "considered to be of particular societal

importance at the time of publication" (Le, 2004, p.688), and they represent the official stance of the newspaper. However, they do not only aim to persuade readers to adopt a particular opinion; but they also defend particular ideologies or certain attitudes in the discourse community (Van Dijk, 1992).

Moreover, "there are certain conventions in writing editorials and these conventions might be different cross-culturally" (Ansary & Babaii, 2009, p.2). To put it differently, the typology, structure, rhetorical strategies, and metadiscoursal features of NEs may differ across discourse communities or languages. Ansary and Babaii (2009) regard NEs as a compelling genre for cross-cultural analysis, emphasizing their persuasive nature, public accessibility, and role in reflecting cultural and ideological frameworks. Similarly, Zarza (2016) states that NEs are valuable sites for analyzing strategic language use in persuasion and argumentation, particularly how linguistic features such as hedging and boosting establish a writer-reader interactional relationship and demonstrate perspectives on certain issues. The use of metadiscourse features such as hedging and boosting enables NEs to develop arguments, enhance persuasiveness, present claims with precision, and shape ideologies, particularly within socio-cultural contexts (Van Dijk, 1989, 1992).

1.5.1 Hedging and Boosting in Media Discourse: Newspaper Editorials (NEs)

Within media discourse, hedging functions to harmonize persuasive language with journalistic neutrality (Dafouz-Milne, 2008). In contrast, boosting amplifies assertions by conveying certainty, emphasis, and persuasive force (Hyland, 2005a). Boosting is often used in NEs to defend ideological positions, to shape public opinion, and reinforce credibility (Dafouz-Milne, 2008; Bednarek & Caple, 2017). Boosting features such as *undoubtedly*, *clearly*, and *without a doubt* enhance the persuasive effect of media discourse (Hyland, 2000). In media narratives, boosting is employed to strengthen trustworthiness, elicit emotional reactions, and solidify prevailing perspectives (Martin & White, 2005). The strategic and balanced use of these metadiscourse elements influences how audience interprets news and engages with mediated realities. While hedging may be used to maintain neutrality and credibility, boosting is often employed to assert dominance, persuade the audience, and frame narratives in a particular direction (Bell, 1991). Boosting is particularly prevalent in political and ideological discourse, where media seek to persuade readers (Van Dijk, 2006). As previously mentioned, in order to achieve successful persuasion and argumentation, writers or speakers should use a reasonable number of metadiscourse markers including hedging and boosting in addition to other elements of persuasion

and argumentation. Rodríguez (2008) demonstrates that the argumentative, evaluative, and persuasive nature of opinion discourse (e.g. NEs) requires the use of both facts as well as assessments in presenting such opinions. In other words, NEs require a frequent use of metadiscourse features in order to develop arguments, express the writers' opinion, and persuade the reader (Vande Kopple & Crismore, 1997; Dafouz-Milne, 2008; Khabbazi-Oskouei, 2012).

Hedging and boosting, if used precisely, can support the writer's opinion and build a strong writer-reader relationship. They are argued to be powerful features in persuading the readers and in influencing their attitudes about the subject matter covered in the text (Vande Kopple & Crismore, 1997; Dafouz-Milne, 2008; Khabbazi-Oskouei, 2012; Vold, 2006). Brooke (2016) argues that "persuasive or argumentative genres should elicit more hedging than other genres, as making claims and stating opinions are inherent in formulating an argument" (p.2). In other words, NEs are supposed to contain a more frequent number of hedging and boosting since they are written to persuade the reader and negotiate the truth of the proposition. Moreover, whenever the writer/speaker employs hedging or boosting, he/she presents his claims or views precisely and diplomatically, and thus he/she attempts to build a strong relationship with the reader to achieve persuasive and argumentative purposes. Similarly, since NEs usually focus on national economic, social, and political issues, writers are supposed to be more cautious or precise in presenting their claims; therefore, they mainly can hedge or boost their propositions to avoid any confrontation with their readers (Hyland, 1998a, 1999). NErs may threaten the newspaper's reputation if they are not cautious in presenting their claims or views. To mitigate the effects of such claims, attack, or persuasion, the use of hedging is therefore important in NEs (Nugroho, 2014).

Van de Kopple and Crismore (1997), exploring readers' reactions to hedging, concludes that students read hedged texts more evaluatively than unhedged texts. Dafouz-Milne (2008) argues that "the key to an effectively persuasive text is the artful combination of weakening expressions (i.e. hedges) and strengthening ones (i.e.certainty markers and/or attitudinal markers) with the final intention of producing a discourse that is neither too assertive nor too vague" (p.193). Similarly, when presenting information in the text, the author by using hedging presents this information as opinions instead of facts (Hyland, 2005b; Zarza, 2016), and thus he/she avoids any confrontation with the reader. Buitkienė (2008), investigating language of newspaper discourse, argues that NEs use hedging features more frequently than news stories. He attributes these findings to the communicative function of NEs, which is to persuade the reader, while the function

of news stories to inform him/her. Similarly, an advertisement may use different hedging and boosting features compared to a news story article, since they both have different purposes. Advertisements function to persuade readers to buy a certain product, whereas news stories function to provide information, facts, and events (Al-Rickaby, 2016; Zarza, 2018). To put it differently, NErs tend to use various categories of rhetorical features (e.g., hedging, boosting, and so on) to develop arguments, achieve persuasion, and to influence their readers' opinions (Zarza, 2018). In English-language newspapers, according to Dafouz-Milne (2008) hedging is often used to:

a) Avoid absolute claims: *It seems that the economic policy may have unintended consequences.*

b) Acknowledge alternative perspectives: *Some analysts suggest that this approach could lead to instability.*

c) Mitigate risk in legal or political statements: *There is reason to believe that the new regulations might be effective.*

However, boosting is used to strengthen arguments in NEs, to persuade the reader, and to establish authority (Hyland, 2005a). Dafouz-Milne (2008) reports that boosting is more frequently used in persuasive and ideological texts, particularly in politically charged NEs, which often employ boosting to:

a) Assert strong opinions: *This is undoubtedly the best course of action.*

c) Reject opposing views: *There is no question that this policy is flawed.*

c) Emphasize urgency or importance: *We must act now to prevent further crisis.*

Hyland argues that hedging and boosting in newspaper discourse "work to balance objective information, subjective evaluation and interpersonal negotiation, and this can be a powerful persuasive factor in gaining acceptance for claims" (1998a, p. 353). Moreover, research reports that hedging and boosting are used differently in Arabic journalistic discourse determined by cultural and rhetorical traditions (Al-Khatib & Salem, 2011; Najjar, 1990). According to Salager-Meyer (1994), the ENEs tend to prefer indirectness and deference to authority. However, the ANEs are likely to prefer directness and explicit argumentation. Arabic media often hedge a claim or proposition as a politeness strategy to avoid direct confrontation (Al-Khatib & Salem, 2011) and tend to use stronger rhetorical features and repetition as boosting features to enhance persuasion (Najjar, 1990). Unlike English discourse, Arabic discourse often appeal to emotion and collective values, reinforcing community-based rhetoric (Al-Khatib & Salem, 2011). In other

words, Arabic discourse, as affected by the collectivistic values of Arabic community, tend to use more boosting features and less hedging ones.

3.1.6 Hedging and Boosting in Modern Standard Arabic (MSA)

3.1.6.1 Approaches and Views

There is a notable lack of research investigating hedging and boosting features in Arabic, particularly in Modern Standard Arabic (MSA). This is probably can be explained that these features have only recently been recognized as phenomena within Arabic linguistics and discourse analytic approaches (Al-Kholani, 2010; Al-Semeiri, 2018). In other words, while extensive research has explored hedging and boosting in English, limited attention has been given to examining their structure, usage, and prevalence in Arabic. Hedging and boosting are significantly unexplored in previous research on Arabic rhetoric and discourse analysis. However, concepts such as *particles*, *connectives*, and *discourse markers* (DMs) have been extensively studied either in research in MSA or in other Arabic varieties (Al-Semeiri, 2018). Al-Kholani (2010) states that *pragmatic markers* (PMs), which constitute hedging, boosting, and other markers, have been approached differently in the literature of Arabic linguistics and discourse analysis approaches. However, the Arabic concept *hūrūf* (particles/حروف) has been used to label discourse markers such as hedging, boosting, and other features. Furthermore, hedging and has not been approached in Arabic as it has in English, and their structures, use, and understanding are obviously different from English. There have been, to the best of the researcher's knowledge, very little research focusing on hedging and boosting in Arabic (e.g., Safi, 1988; Khuwaileh, 2006; Al-Kholani, 2010; Abbadi, 2014; Al-Semeiri, 2018).

Research on Arabic discourse have predominantly focused on applying comparative frameworks from English hedging and boosting to analyze analogous pragmatic functions in Arabic structures. According to Abbas' (2011) findings, hedging occurred in every 77 words in English academic discourse while they appeared once every 100 words in Arabic academic one. Al-Kholani (2010) states that traditional Arab linguists, such as Safi (1988), Abbadi (2014), and Al-Jurjani (1984), focused their investigations narrowly at the sentence level in analyzing linguistic and metadiscursive elements. In fact, Arab linguists were not interested in the study of discourse markers, but they were concerned with the concept of *particles*, which were the source forms of many markers and were studied extensively in their research. Similarly, these scholars offered detailed accounts of such linguistic elements (i.e., particles), classifying them as a

grammatical category operating strictly within sentence-level parameters. In Arabic grammar, *particles* are usually referred to as *hūrūf* (i.e. the plural of *harf*, particle حرف/حروف), which were categorized later as *hūrūfū al-mā'ani* (particles of meanings/حروف المعاني).

Arabic and English have fundamentally distinct linguistic systems, as they originate from separate language families. Accordingly, we can find many hedging or boosting features and structures exist in Arabic discourse but do not exist in English one or vice versa. While English is an Indo-European language, Arabic as a Semitic language is characterized by linguistic features and structures different from those of English. For instance, the Arabic linguistic system does not have a similar modal verbal system equivalent to the English one; and similarly, the English linguistic system does not have *hedging particles* such as *qad structure* (may/would/قد), *similar-to-verb particles* such as *wa ka'anna* (seem as if/كأنّ), and *rubbama particle* (may/maybe/ربّما). It is supposed that native Arabic speakers often compensate for the lack of a modal verb system in Modern Standard Arabic by employing particles and lexico-grammatical constructions. Conversely, English speakers address gaps in certain structural features through the utilization of diverse modal verb subcategories.

However, given the presence of linguistic universals across languages, it can be found noticeable similarities between the two languages in terms of meaning, structure, and function of certain features. In the present research, in order to categorize and identify Arabic hedging and boosting features, the researcher adopts and modifies an English taxonomy of such features as an analytical framework for the Arabic corpus. Since no taxonomy of Arabic hedging and boosting has been provided, the researcher attempts to establish some similarities and difference by comparing the use of hedging and boosting in both English and MSA in a specific genre. According to several linguists (e.g., Al-Jurjani, 1984; Safi, 1988; Al-Kholani, 2010; & others), hedging and boosting structures of both languages are obviously different. However, there are some similarities in form and function of such features between Arabic and English (Al-Semeiri, 2018). Arab linguists specifically categorize hedging and boosting as *stance markers* or *epistemic modalities* (e.g., Al-Jurjani,1984; Safi,1988; Al-Kholani, 2010; Al-Semeiri, 2018; and others). Moreover, although some research on *Arabic modality* in general has been done, very little research has been conducted on epistemic modality in Arabic. For Arab linguistists, hedging, boosting, and *stance* are primarily realized through epistemic lexical verbs, adverbial or prepositional phrases, conditional clauses, and auxiliary/semi-auxiliary modal constructions (Al-

Semeiri, 2018). Al-Harbi (2002) has sought to develop a framework for epistemic modality in Modern Standard Arabic (MSA), despite that in MSA there is no modal verb system. Al-Semeiri (2018) argues that specific verbs, adverbials, and nominal constructions in MSA parallel English modal structures as they indicate possibility, probability, or certainty, thereby serving hedging and boosting functions within epistemic contexts. In other words, MSA, much like English, appears to depend extensively on epistemic markers such as modal or semi-modal verbs, nominal constructions, and adverbial phrases to modify propositional force in discourse.

According to several linguists (e.g., Connor, 1996; Sa'adeddin, 1989; El-Arousy, 2004; and others), Arab writers prefer direct and assertive structures, i.e. use a more frequent number of boosting features and use a less frequent number of hedging features. However, English writers tend to use tentative structures and hedging features more frequently. For instance, Connor (1996) and Sa'adeddin (1989) report a number of studies that describes Arabic rhetorical and stylistic structures as amplified and overassertive. According to Holes (2004), Arabic language employs diverse grammatical and lexical mechanisms to denote modality, including epistemic distinctions, aligning closely with how modal functions are realized in English. However, despite the fact that both Arabic and English tend to use modality as an effective feature to hedge and boost their propositions; it seems that the two languages use various different structures to indicate epistemic modality. Palmer (2001) argues that "mood and modality are intimately bound" (p. 423) in MSA because modality can be realized through inflectional marking of verbs (i.e. morphological markers). For instance, the prefix *sa* can be attached to a verb to indicate intention and futurity in addition to its hedging or boosting functions. Moreover, when the *particle qad* precedes a present verb, "it generally implies the modality of doubt, uncertainty, [and] possibility" (Kinberg & Versteegh, 2001, p. 123). However, while verbs, nouns, and adjectives are regarded as primary categories for mitigating or strengthening assertions in Modern Standard Arabic (MSA), standard grammatical frameworks of MSA do not formally acknowledge modality as a discrete category (El-Hassan, 1990, p. 164). Scholars have nonetheless identified lexical or syntactic constructions in MSA including specific verbs, phrases, and grammatical patterns, which function similarly to English modal verbs in indicating epistemic or deontic functions (Mitchell & El-Hasan, 1994).

For instance, Arabic particles such as *rubbama*, adverbials (*prepositional phrases)*, *semi-verbal particle* of *la'alla* (wish it would/ لعلّ), *particle qad*, the modal verb *yūmkin* (might/يمكن), and others can function in their epistemic meanings as hedging or boosting features. The diverse

range of hedging and boosting categories in Modern Standard Arabic (MSA) arises from its lack of a grammaticalized modal system, contrasting with English, where modality is structured in grammatical forms. Therefore, a variety of lexico-grammatical structures are used to indicate the meaning and function of a single English modal auxiliary or other epistemic structures. What is important to establish here is whether modality in MSA is a lexical or grammatical category. According to Mejdell (2006), MSA has less *grammaticalized* structures of modal distinction. MSA, however, use a range of lexico-grammatical particles and structural structures to denote modality, functioning as a pragmatic rather than morphosyntactic feature. Al-Semeiri (2018) argues that modality in Arabic operates as a primarily semantic rather than grammatically structured category, with Arabic varieties relying more heavily on lexical markers to mitigate, intensify, or qualify propositions. Conversely, Holes (2004) observes that Arabic modality, like its English counterpart, is similar to English in encompassing categories such as possibility, obligation, and ability, which are further categorized into deontic (obligation/permission) and epistemic (certainty/probability) modalities. Moreover, Biber (2004) and Biber, Conrad, and Leech (2002), who explored modality in ENEs and ANEs, classify modality into truth and obligation. According to them, modals, which indicate necessity such as *must* and *should* in English, also indicate different levels of certainty in MSA such as the modals *yatawajabu* (يتوجّب /must/should) and *yajibu* (يجب/should). Moreover, the *morphemes* or *particles sa* (س/will) and *sawfa* (will/سوف) indicate prediction or futurity in Arabic as the modals *will* and *would* indicate prediction and futurity in English.

Similarly, Abdalla (2018) demonstrates that the verb *yumkin* (may/يمكن) is primarily employed to indicate qualified commitment (non-categorical assertion) and direct explicitness, while qad and rubbama (maybe/ربّما) function to denote partial engagement or indirect claim in discourse. That is, they indicate the possibility of biased attitude, which is either intensified *takthīr* (i.e. increased possibility) or *downplaye*d *taqlīl* (i.e. reduced possibility) depending on the socio-cultural contexts of their use (p.2003). Similarly, according to El-Hassan (1990, p. 164), the Arabic *particle rubbama* (may be/ربّما), which consists of two fragments *rubba* (ربّ) + *ma* (ما) is probably the nearest equivalent to the English modal may or might. However, its usage is governed by specific syntactic and discourse constraints. Structurally, it may precede verbal clauses (headed by a finite verb) or nominal clauses introduced by the complementizer ann (أنّ). The following examples show the use of rubbama:

(a) *rubbama* yakūn al- mūdīr fi-al-bait (ربمّا يكون المدير في البيت/ the manger maybe is at home).

(b) *rubbama* anna al mūdīr fi-al-bait (ربمّا يكون المدير في البيت/ the manger maybe is at home).

The modal particle *qad* (قد) can also be equivalent to *may* or *might* indicating a particular degree of uncertainty or epistemic modality specifically when it precedes a present form of the verb, for example:

(a) *qad yakūn* al mūdīr fi-al- bait (قد يكون المدير في البيت / the manager may be at home).

Boosting in MSA can also be realized by the *modal particle lā būdda ‘ann* (لابدّ/wish it would) which combines the *particle la* (لا) for negation and a modal noun *būdda* followed by an embedded sentence (S) usually introduced by the complementizer *ann* (أن).This structure is used to indicate prediction, uncertainty, and expectation towards a particular action or claim as the following example shows: (a) *la būdda* annhū sa-yanjaḥ fi-al-imtiḥān (He will pass the exam لا بدّ أنه سينجح في الامتحان/). The following table shows some forms of Arabic semi-modal verbs and their equivalents in English:

Table 3.1 Modality in MSA

Romanized Arabic Modals	English Modal Equivalent	Arabic Equivalent Expressions
yumkin ‘ann, yastiṫ’ ‘ann	can/may/might	قد/ يمكن أن/ يستطيع أن
yajibū ‘ann, yatawajabū ‘ann, lā būdda min-’ana	must/should	يجب أن / يتوّجب أن/ لا بدّ
sawfa, sa	shall/will/ would	سوف/سا
yanbaghi ‘ann	should/must	ينبغي
Qad	would/might/may	قد

Table 3.1 shows some distinctive Arabic *semi-modal verbs* and their equivalent expressions in English. For instance, modals such as can, could, may and might are similar to the modal Arabic equivalent *yumkin ‘ann* (يمكن أن /may/might); and they are analogous in meaning and function to the these modals in their epistemic meaning of possibility or probability. The *semi-verb* or *semi- auxiliary* structure *yumkin* (might/may/يمكن) in MSA indicates possibility and ability. Similarly, the particle *qad* means and functions as similar as these modals in their probability, possibility, and predictability. Moreover, the Arabic *particles sawfa* (سوف/will/would) and *sa* (س/will/would) when they precede a present verb, they might have the same meaning or function as the modal *shall*, *should*, *will*, and *would* in their epistemic meaning of prediction, probability, or futurity. It is important to note that not all Arabic expressions are verbs. Some of them are *particles* such as *sawfa* and *qad*, which are attached to verbs to modulate a proposition or mitigate

its force act, while others preceding a verb, are categorized as *semi-verbs* or *semi-auxiliary* verbs like *yumkin* (might/may/يمكن), *lā būdda ‘an* (it must/لابد), *yastiti’u*, (can/يستطيع), *yajibu* (must/يجب), and *yanbaghi* (should/ينّبغي). In most cases, the Arabic semi-modal verb is followed by the *accusative particle ann* (أن). This Arabic particle is always followed by the infinitive form of the verb, a structure that is also found in the case of the English grammar:
modal verb + to + infinitive or *modal verb + bare infinitive.*

3.1.6.2 Form and Function of Arabic Hedging and Boosting Features

One distinctive structure indicating hedging is the *particle qad* (قد) followed by an *imperfective present* form of the verb, which can denote uncertainty or epistemic modality. The particle qad does not have a precise meaning by itself, it cannot stand alone, and it precedes a present or past verb. According to Abdalla (2018, p.2004), when qad precedes the past form of the verb (perfective), qad meaning or function indicates *taḥqīq* (emphasis/actualization/تحقيق). However, when qad precedes the present form of the verb (imperfective); its meaning or function indicates *taqrīb* or *taqlīl* (approximation, reduced possibility, and diminution/تقليل/تقريب); and it functions to reduce the force of the verb. According to Abdalla (2018), Arab writers or speakers use qad to lessen the probability of the future threat or to reduce the threat into a warning. In other words, Arab writers or speakers tend to use qad to hedge utterances, indicate epistemic uncertainty, show judgment of possibility, reduce the possible threat, and proactively welcome alternative critiques (Badawi, Carter & Gully, 2004; Abdalla, 2018). For instance, the Arabic structure qad *‘akūn* (I might be/قد أكون), functioning as a hedge, consists of two segments: Qad (قد) and the present verb *‘akūn* (أكون/ I might be). Mansour (2013) argues that both *rubbama* (ربّما) and qad can indicate a higher degree of possibility or probability than the *semi-verb yumkin* (يمكن). Exploring the use of hedging and boosting in English and Arabic research articles, Al-Otaibi (2015) investigated if hedging features function similarly in other languages such as Arabic as they do in English. Al-Otaibi (2015) provided the following examples:

(a) *rubbama* naḥnu nantaṭir mūstaqbalan ‘aswa’ (Perhaps, we are awaiting worse future/ ربّما ننتظر مستقبلا أسوئ).

(b) *‘a’taqid* ‘annaha ḥaraban laisat ‘adīlah (I believe that this is not a fair war/ أعتقد أنّها حرب غير عادلة).

(c) *qad tastāmir* al-ḥarb li-mūdat ‘ūsbū’aiīn (The war may last for two weeks/ قد تستمر الحرب لمدة أسبوعين).

As shown in examples (a), (b), and (c), inserting the hedging feature into the sentences helps the speaker/writer mitigate his/her claims in the propositions. Al-Otaibi (2015) argues that qad does not have a similar equivalent in English and its closer equivalent is may or might. According to Al-Otaibi (2015), while qad was the most frequently used hedging category by the Arab researchers, the modal verb may was the most frequently used hedging category by the English ones. Moreover, according Al-Otaibi (2015), regarding the interactional metadiscourse resources, the results showed that English texts were more cautious by using more hedging features than Arabic ones. Arabic discourse were more assertive by using boosting features. These interactional occurrences were not only less frequent in the Arabic texts but also were less varied. For example, the only hedging expression used in the Arabic texts was qad; while there were various categories of hedging features used in the English texts (e.g., seem, may, might, could, and likely). Al-Otaibi (2015) argues that Arab writers' reliance on *qad* as their primary hedging feature stems from their conscious understanding of its function and use. In MSA, qad is viewed as a comprehensive linguistic feature, rendering other hedging elements unnecessary or repetitive. Notably, this particle can also amplify the certainty of a proposition, thereby acting as a boosting feature. Al-Otaibi (2015) further emphasizes that socio-cultural norms inherent to a language significantly determine both the form and communicative function of metadiscourse feature. For example, while the Arabic hedge qad and the present verb tense convey uncertainty, they simultaneously imply stronger authorial commitment compared to the English modal may, which denotes lower responsibility. Consequently, socio-cultural contexts play a pivotal role in determining the level of commitment conveyed through hedging and boosting features in both languages (Al-Otaibi, 2015).

Moreover, some features or structures in MSA can indicate a high degree of commitment or certainty in a particular context and a low degree of commitment or certainty in other contexts (Al-Semeiri, 2018). Both *qad* and *rubbama*, which serve as counterparts to the English modal may, can express varying levels (low, moderate, or high) of commitment or possibility depending on the context or communicative purpose. Similarly, *la'lla*—whether expressing desirable or undesirable possibility may also indicate a spectrum of commitment levels (from strong to weak). However, *wa kaʾanna* (seem as if/ وكأنّ) only indicates a high degree of certainty or commitment (Abdalla, 2018). Moreover, MSA uses *sa* + the present form of the verb (e.g. *sa-yakūn bi-wisī'ina* (بوسعنا سيكون/we would be able to) to indicate certainty, full commitment, and future possibility.

Therefore, this structure functions as a boosting feature. In other words, the particle *sa* (س) when it precedes the present form of verb *yakūn* (يكون /be); it denotes futurity or prediction similar to *will* construction in English (Al-Semeiri, 2018). In in MSA the *particle rubbama* (ربمّا /maybe) is an important hedging feature, which has been categorized by Arab linguists as a *prepositional modal particle* of probability. It consists of two fragments: *Rubba* (a preposition/ربّ) and *ma* (ما), and both of these fragments constitute a single *particle*, which means maybe or perhaps. It is used in MSA to mitigate a proposition or avoid full responsibility on the part of the writer/speaker in a discourse (Al-Semeiri, 2018). Abdalla (2018) states that rubbama should not necessarily always indicate a high possibility modal. It occurs more frequently as a reduced possibility and less frequently as an increased possibility. In other words, rubbama can indicate a high or low degree of commitment or probability depending on the contextual and communicative situations of its use.

In addition to the previous structures used in Arabic discourse, the researcher has observed other hedging and boosting structures employed in Arabic books of linguistics, grammar, and discourse analysis. Other lexical or grammatical structures indicating modality, hedging, and boosting include *epistemic lexical verbs*, *adverbials* or *approximators* (i.e. *prepositional phrases*), *adjectives*, *similar-to-verbs particles*, and *nouns*. The researcher categorizes some possible instances of modality, hedging, and boosting in MSA and their English equivalents. The following table clarifies these instances:

Table 3.2 Some Arabic Hedging and Boosting Features in MSA

Romanized Arabic Hedging Features	**English Equivalents**	**Arabic Equivalent Expressions**	**Romanized Arabic Boosting Features**	**English Equivalents**	**Arabic Equivalent Features**
min-al-mūḥtamal, min-al-mūmkin, min-al-mūtawāqa', min-al-mūftarḍ, and others	probable, probably	من المحتمل، من الممكن، من المتوقع، من المفترض،	Tamaman, min-al-wāḍiḥ, Kūllīan,	Definitely, clearly, completely	تماما، من الواضح، كليا،
Yajūz	could, would	يجوز	Yajibū	Must, shall	يجب، يتوجّب
Yanbaghi	Should, shall	ينبغي	La yūmkin	Cannot	لا يمكن
yabdū, yabdū ka,kaman	seem, seem as if, appear	يبدو، يبدو كا، يبدو كمن	yū'akid, yūāḍiḥ	Confirm, clarify	يؤكد، يوضّح
ya'taqid, ya'tabir, yaẓin	think, believe	يعتقد /يعتبر/يظن			
wa ka'anna, wa ka'anna ma	seem as/ appear as if	وكأنّ/وكأنّما			

As shown in table 2.3, MSA employs the structure of *adverbials* (*prepositional phrases*) to hedge or to boost its propositions. Adverbials include expressions such as *min-al-mūḥtamal* (probably/من المحتمل), *min-al-mūmkin* (possibly/ من الممكن), *min-al-mūtawāqa'* (expectedly/من المتوقع), *min-al-mūftarḍ* (supposedly/من المفترض), min-al-wāḍiḥ (clearly/ من الواضح) and others which are very common structures in MSA and have a similar function to English adverbials. Moreover, like English, MSA also employs *epistemic lexical verbs* to hedge or to boost its propositions. These verbs are embedded in a sentence clause usually modifying another sentence clause. These verbs include *yajūz* (could/would/يجوز), *ya'taqid* (believe/يعتقد), *ya'tabir* (consider/يعتبر), *yaẓinn* (think/ يظن), *yanbaghi* (should/must/ ينبغ), and *yabdū*, *yabdū ka*/*kaman* (seem/seem as if يبدو/يبدوك/يبدو), and yūāḍiḥ (clarify يوضّح). The following example shows the use of epistemic lexical verbs in MSA:

(a) *'aẓūn* 'annahū lan yā'ti (أظن أنه يأتي لن يأتي/ I think that he would not come).

b) min-al-wāḍiḥ 'annahū lan yā'ti (من الواضح أنّه لن يأتي/clearly, he will not come).

Another important hedging structure in MSA is the *similar-to-verb particle wa ka'anna* or wa *ka'anna ma* (seem/appear/كأنّ/وكأنّما), which functions to indicate a high degree of imprecision, a high degree of irresponsibility, or al-zānn (الظن/believing/guessing) on the part of the speaker/writer when it is used to hedge a claim. Moreover, *la'alla* (wish it would/لعلّ) is another *similar-to-verb particle* used in MSA to indicate *taraji* (ترجّي/wishful uncertainty/wishfulness) or weak expectation. According to Abdalla (2018, p.2004), *la'alla* does not function as similar as the particle *wa ka'anna* but its meaning or function of probability is "permeated with inclination, i.e. possibility that is either desirable (hoped/loved) or undesirable (feared/hated)." According to Abdalla (2018, p.2004), these particles are "modal particles of desirable probability and usuality" as the following example shows:

(a) *wa ka'annahū* mūshikun ala al-sqūṫ (وكأنّه موشك على السقوط /It seems that he is about to fall).

Conditional clauses are also an important structure used in MSA to hedge a proposition. Conditional clauses are clauses which consist of one of the following conditional particles*: Idha* (if/إذا), *law* (if/لو), *lawla* (unless/لولا), and *inn* (if/إن). Another hedging structure in MSA is *rhetorical questions*. In MSA, *rhetorical questions* are questions that start with question words such as *mann* (who/من), *li-mādha* (why/لماذا), *hal* (do/does/is/هل), *ayna* (where/أين), and others. These questions are not posed to be answered but to indicate the writer/speaker's interrogative and tentative opinion.

3.2 Previous Research

3.2.1 Hedging and boosting across Languages, Genres, and Disciplines

Differences and preferences in terms of use of hedging and boosting features across languages and cultures have been investigated by various researchers. Much research has compared how such rhetorical interpersonal features were used in English and in other languages, such as Bulgarian (Vassileva, 2001), Persian (Zarei & Mansoori, 2011), French and Norwegian (Vold, 2006), Spanish (Martín-Martín, 2008), Arabic (Sultan, 2011; Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed, 2019; Abbadi, 2014), German (Kreutz & Harres, 1997), and Chinese (Hu & Cao, 2011). Although there is much research that investigated the use of hedging and boosting in English and other languages in NEs (e.g., Buitkiene, 2008; Dafouz-Milne, 2008; Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed, 2019; Zarza, 2018; Al-Subhi, 2023), this research seems to be limited. The scanty amount of research conducted in this area has shown that there are some noticeable differences and similarities in terms use of such features across languages, genres, and disciplines.

For instance, Zarza (2018) investigated the pattern of rhetorical moves and the use of hedging and boosting in 120 American ENEs and 120 Malaysian newspaper editorials (MNEs). To this end, 240 NEs published in the New York Times (NYT) and New Straits Times (NST) were explored in both their macro- and micro-levels. Findings showed that both types of NEs preferred the use of hedging rather than boosting in their texts. Furthermore, the findings showed that hedging in the American ENEs were less frequently used than in their Malaysian counterparts, while boosting in the American ENEs were more frequently used than in the MNEs. According to Zarza's (2018) findings, the MNEs were more tentative in presenting their views or claims than the American ENEs, who seemed to be more assertive and certain in presenting their claims.

Similarly, Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed (2019) conducted a comparative analysis of hedging and boosting features in English and Jordanian Arabic economic news articles (NEs), aiming to identify cross-linguistic patterns in their frequency and functional usage. Drawing on Salager-Meyer's (1997) and Hyland's (2005a) frameworks, the researchers compiled a corpus of 60 NEs (30 English and 30 Arabic) published between 2016 and 2017 in two Anglo-American and two Jordanian newspapers. Their analysis revealed that the ENEs employed hedging features (e.g., modal verbs, approximators) more frequently, while ANEs tended to use boosting features (e.g., emphatics). These differences were attributed to sociocultural and linguistic factors shaping communicative norms. Specifically, *modal verbs* were a very frequent hedging category in the

ENEs, whereas *lexical verbs* and *approximators* were very frequently used in the ANEs. Similarly, *amplifiers* were a frequent category of boosting in the ENEs, while emphatics prevailed in the ANEs.

Dheskali (2017) explored the use of hedging and boosting in Albanian, British, and Italian online news articles in Europe (NEs). The aim of this comparative research was to investigate the usage of hedging and boosting in Albanian, British and Italian online news articles on the refugee crisis. The researcher compared categories and subcategories of author-related and proposition-related hedging *(e.g., believe, possibly, approximately)* and boosters (e.g. *show*, *certainly*, *completely*) as well as relevant interrelated aspects such as their positioning, orientation, manifestation, and prosody of moralization. The research was based on compatible small corpora of Albanian, British and Italian online articles from well-known media sources that included genres such as news reports and NEs. The results showed that hedging and boosting have similar frequencies in the British and Albanian corpora, but hedging was more frequent than boosting in the Italian corpus. The researcher concluded that journalists from Britain and Albania struck a balance between outright affirmation and cautious or partial endorsement of the claim, while Italian journalists adopted a more cautious and hesitant tone in their texts.

Furthermore, Al-Subhi (2023) explored the use of interactional metadiscourse and phraseology in NEs during the Russia-Ukraine war in a comparative analysis of the language of NEs that were published during the war. The research was based on samples taken from leading newspapers in the USA and the UAE. The corpus consists of 24 NEs amounting to 16,673 words written in English. Hyland's (2005b) interactional model of metadiscourse was used as an analytical framework. Data analysis revealed significant similarities between editorials from the USA and the UAE regarding the use of multiple linguistic features. Additionally, *stance markers* were found to substantially outnumber *engagement markers* in both sets of texts. The researcher further highlighted diverse usage of collocations, modal language, and idiomatic expressions. It concluded that NEs function as argumentative discourse, characterized by persuasive elements such as hedging, boosting, attitude markers, and similar rhetorical features.

Sanjaya (2013) analyzed a group of English and Indonesian research articles in two disciplines (i.e. applied linguistics and chemistry) in order to explore the frequency of usage of hedging and boosting. To this purpose, a corpus of 104 research articles from the two languages and disciplines were investigated quantitatively with the help of corpus-linguistic methods. The

findings of the research revealed that the overall English research articles were more tentative than the Indonesian articles as the English research articles used a more frequent number of hedging, and the Indonesian research articles used a more frequent number of boosting.

Yazdania, Sharifib, and Elyassic (2014) studied the use of hedging and boosting in 11 September English Front Page News Articles (i.e. NEs). The research aimed to find the function of interpersonal metadiscourse markers such as hedging and boosting in these articles. Accordingly, 27 front pages of widely read newspapers in the US were selected randomly from around 50 news about 9/11 events. Quantitative and qualitative methods were applied to answer the research questions and to identify the use of hedging and boosting features in the corpus. The findings showed that hedging was the most frequently used metadiscourse marker in English front page news articles. *Probability adverbs* were the most frequently used hedging subcategory, whereas *verbs* were the most frequent subcategory of boosting used to describe writers' certainty. The researchers concluded that journalists preferred to be conservative by using indirect strategies (i.e. hedging features) like adverbs and adjective on controversial issues like 9/11 events.

3.3 Summary

This chapter provided a theoretical background for the concepts of hedging and boosting, their evolution, their emergence, their forms, and functions. The present chapter also reviewed some important approaches and perspectives that tackled hedging and boosting features. Moreover, the present chapter gave a brief account of the concept of genre defining how generic approaches dealt with hedging and boosting and different categories of texts. In addition, this chapter presented some perspectives and approaches of the two features in MSA. Finally, it provided some empirical previous research, and how it investigated hedging and boosting across languages, discourses, and genres. Next chapter presents the data analysis, the descriptive and inferential statistical findings, and the discussion of findings of the present research.

Chapter Four

Data Analysis and Findings

4.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the findings of the quantitative and qualitative analysis, and a discussion related to each research question is provided in details. The first section of the chapter presents the descriptive findings in relation to the frequency of hedging and boosting features in the English and Arabic corpora. Afterwards, a qualitative functional analysis and interpretations of functions of such features in the English corpus as compared to the Arabic one is presented. Following this, referential findings drawn from the previous descriptive findings are given. The chapter concludes with a discussion of how these quantitative and qualitative analyses relate to the theoretical framework and the research questions that were posed in chapter one.

4.2 Data Analysis

As mentioned earlier in the introduction, the main objective of the present research was to determine whether the socio-cultural context (language) where the current NEs situated affected the frequency, form, and function of hedging and boosting in these NEs. To achieve this objective, two sets of NEs written in two different languages (Modern Standard English (MSE) & Modern Standard Arabic (MSA)) were compared in terms of their use of hedging and boosting features. In the present research, there was one independent variable and one dependent variable. The independent variable was the linguistic or socio-cultural context where the NEs were written. This independent variable was supposed to affect the dependent variable, which was the form, frequency, function of hedging and boosting features in the two sets of corpora. Table 4.1 shows the size of the two entire corpora:

Table 4.1 Distribution of Length of the NEs in words by Language

Corpus	Total No. of NEs	Total No. of Words	Mean Length of a NE per words	Minimum Length	Maximum Length	Standard Deviation (SD)
ENEs	20	15,692	784.6	498	1360	272.67
ANEs	20	14,052	702.6	406	1045	182.62
Total	40	29,744	743.6	406	1360	233.13

As previously mentioned, the whole two corpora (English and Arabic), comprising 40 NEs, 20 ANEs and 40 ENEs, amounted to 29,744 words. The English corpus contained 15,692 words, whereas the Arabic corpus contained 14,052 words. As shown in table 4.1 above, the mean length (ML) and standard deviation (SD) of the lengths of both the ANEs and ENEs in the two sub-corpora in the present research were as follows: The ENEs (ML = 784.6 words, Max. = 1,360 words, Min. = 498 words, SD = 272.67 words) and the ANEs (ML = 702.6 words, Max. = 1,045 words, Min. = 406 words, SD = 182.62 words). Thus, on average the ENEs were longer than the ANEs. Moreover, it is noteworthy that both the ANErs and ENErs deviated from the mean length (i.e. 272.67 words in the ENEs and 182.62 in the ANEs). The total standard deviation of lengths of both the ENEs and ANEs was 233.13 words. In fact, ENErs wrote longer articles compared to their Arab counterparts.

4.3 Descriptive Findings

To reiterate, the analysis of the selected NEs was based on Fraser's (2010, pp.23-24) analytical model and Hyland's (1996) definition of hedging and Hyland's (2005a) definition of boosting. Therefore, occurrences of hedging and boosting in both corpora were classified and coded within these two models. In addition to these identified categories, other categories; which did not exist in Fraser's classification; were found and incorporated to hedging and boosting categories in both the Arabic and English corpora. By presenting table 4.2 and 4.3, the researcher attempts to answer the research questions: What is the frequency of occurrence of hedging and boosting in the ENEs (English corpus)? And what is the overall frequency of occurrence of hedging and boosting in the ANEs (Arabic corpus)? The descriptive statistics of usage of the hedging and boosting features in the two corpora illustrated in table 4.2 and 4.3:

Table 4.2 Frequency of Hedging in the ANEs and ENEs per 1,000 Words (PTW)

Corpus	Total No. of Words	Raw Frequency of Hedging Features	Mean Frequency (MF) per Thousand Word (PTW)	Max. Category	Min. Category
ENEs	15,692	768	48.94	9.49	0.25
ANEs	14,052	**479**	34.08	6.12	0.14
Total	29,744	1247	41.92		

Table 4.3 Frequency of Boosting in the ANEs and ENEs per 1,000 Words (PTW)

Corpus	Total No. of Words	Raw Frequency of boosting Features	Mean Frequency (MF) per Thousand Word (PTW)	Max. Category	Min. Category
ENEs	15,692	169	10.56	4.39	0.19
ANEs	14,052	182	12.95	4.34	0.49
Total	29,744	351	11.80		

As table 4.2 shows, the ENErs used totally 768 hedging features, while the ANErs used 479 hedging features. On average, the ENErs used 48.94 tokens of hedging PTW, whereas the ANErs used 34.08 tokens of the feature PTW. Apparently, these findings demonstrate that hedging were used more frequently in the ENEs compared to the ANEs. These findings are similar to Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed's (2019) findings of the use of hedging in ENEs and ANEs. These researchers found that the ENEs were more heavily hedged than the Arabic ones. In fact, the ENErs, in the present research, hedged their propositions approximately twice more often than their Arab counterparts. The overall ENEs and ANEs contained 1247 instances of hedging occurring in 41.92 tokens PTW in the whole two corpora. Moreover, the most frequent category of hedging in the English corpus was *modal verbs* recording 4.39 tokens PTW, whereas the most frequent category in the Arabic corpus was *epistemic lexical verbs* recording 6.12 tokens PTW. Similarly, the least category of hedging used in the English corpus was *modal nouns* recording 0.25 tokens PTW, while the least frequent category in the Arabic corpus was *metalinguistic comments* recording 0.14 tokens PTW. Table 4.3 illustrates that the ENErs used totally 166 tokens of boosting. On average, the ENEs contained 10.57 tokens of the feature PTW. However, the ANErs used 182 tokens of boosting, i.e. ANEs contained 12.95 tokens of the feature PTW. In other words, the ANErs boosted their propositions more often than their English counterparts did. Moreover, the most frequent category of boosting in the English corpus was *modal verbs* recording 4.39 tokens PTW, whereas the most frequent category of boosting in the Arabic corpus was *adverbs of degree, time,* and *frequency* recording 4.34 tokens PTW. Similarly, the least category of boosting used in the English corpus was *metalinguistic comments* recording 0.19 tokens PTW, while the least frequent category in the Arabic corpus was *indefinite/impersonal pronouns* recording 0.49 tokens PTW. The overall ENEs and ANEs contained 351 tokens of boosting recording 11.80 tokens PTW in the whole two corpora.

Table 4.4 Frequency of Hedging and Boosting in the ANEs and ENEs per NE

Corpus	Mean Frequency of Hedging per NE	Max. Frequency	Min. Frequency	Corpus	Mean Frequency of Boosting per NE	Max. Frequency	Min. Frequency
ENEs	38.4	69	16	ENEs	8.3	16	2
ANEs	23.85	45	10	ANEs	9.1	23	3

Similarly, as table 4.4 shows, on average, every ENE contained 38.4 hedges per NE, and on average, every ANE contained 23.85 hedges per NE. Moreover, one ENE consisted of 69 hedges maximally, while one ANE contained maximally 45 hedges. On the other hand, one ENE contained minimally 16 hedges, and one ANE contained minimally only 10 hedges. Similarly, as table 4.4 showed, on average, every ENE contained 8.3 boosters per NE, and on average, every ANE contained 9.1 boosters per NE. Moreover, one ENE consisted of 16 boosters maximally, while one ANE contained maximally 23 boosters. On the other hand, one ENE contained minimally 2 boosters per NE, and one ANE contained minimally 3 boosters per NE. It is clear from the minimum values that all the NEs in the two corpora contained hedging and boosting. Moreover, the difference in the two mean frequencies of hedging (48.94 PTW for ENEs & 33.94 PTW for ANEs) found in the two corpora under research can be explained in terms of the differing lengths of NEs included in the two corpora. It is reasonable to argue that the longer the text the greater the chances that it contains such features at a greater frequency rate. Obviously, it seems that the ENErs used more hedging features in their texts. This may suggest that compared to their Arabic colleagues, the ENErs were much more cautious and tentative in presenting their claims or journalistic information as they hedged their claims more frequently. However, the ANErs boosted their claims or propositions more frequently than the ENErs (10.57 PTW for ENEs & 12.95 PTW for ANEs) despite the fact that the ENEs were longer than the ANEs. This is clear evidence that the length of text is not the only factor that affect the use of two features.

4.3.1 Frequency and Categories of Hedging in the English Corpus

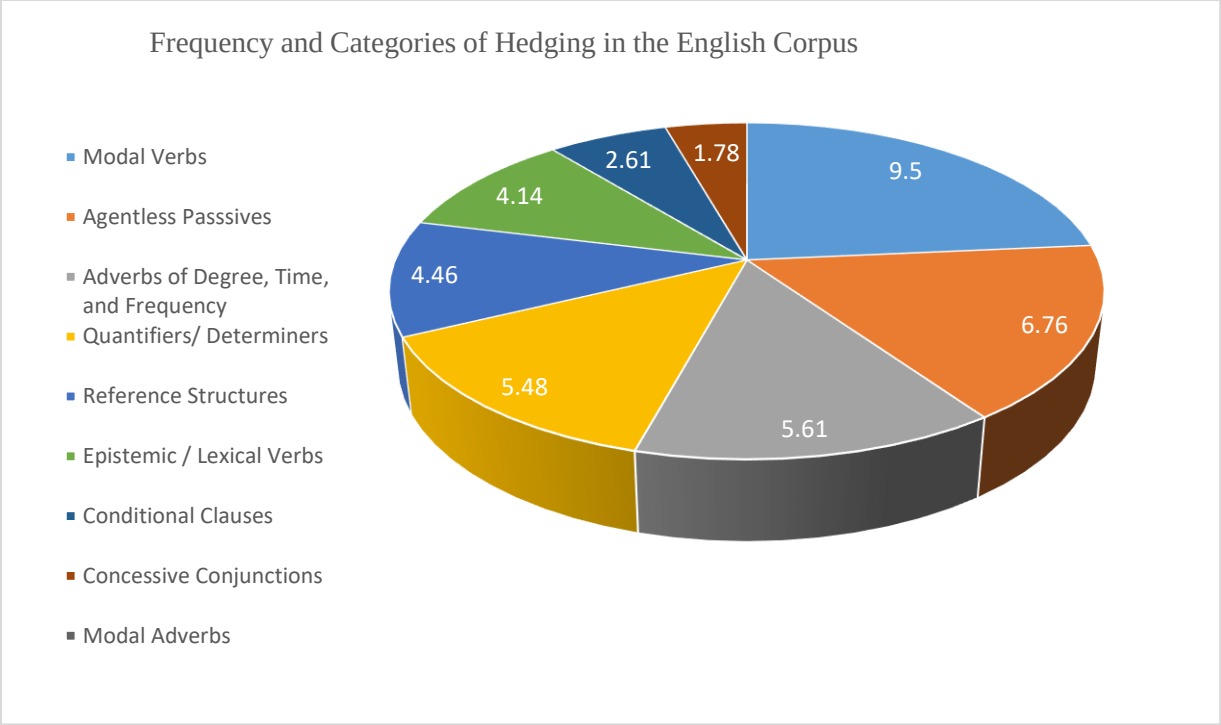
By providing table 4.5, the researcher attempts to answer the research questions: What is the overall frequency of occurrence of hedging and boosting in the ENEs (English corpus)? And what are the linguistic forms or categories of hedging and boosting used in the English and Arabic corpus? The analysis of the English corpus shows that the ENErs used 19 categories of hedging to mitigate their propositions. Table 4.5 presents the overall raw frequency and the mean frequency

PTW of each category of hedging in the entire English corpus:

Table 4.5 Frequency and Categories of Hedging in the English Corpus

Category of Hedging		Raw Frequency (RF) of Hedging	Mean Frequency (MF) PTW
1	**Modal Verbs**	149	9.50
	Can	24	1.53
	Could	39	2.49
	May	17	1.08
	Might	5	0.32
	Would	43	2.74
	Should	11	0.70
	Ought to	3	0.19
	Need to	7	0.45
2	**Adverbs of Degree, Time, and Frequency**	88	5.61
3	**Agentless Passive**	106	6.76
4	**Quantifiers/ Determiners**	86	5.48
5	**Epistemic / Lexical Verbs**	65	4.14
6	**Reference Structures**	70	4.46
7	**Indefinite /Impersonal Pronouns**	18	1.15
8	**Conditional Clauses**	41	2.61
9	**Modal Adverbs**	20	1.27
10	**Nouns**	12	0.76
11	**Rhetorical Questions**	19	1.21
12	**Concessive Conjunctions**	28	1.78
13	**Introductory Phrases /Verbs**	9	0.57
14	**Adjectives**	15	0.96
15	**Compound Hedging**	8	0.51
	Double	6	0.41
	Treble	2	0.14
16	**Metalinguistic Comments**	12	0.76
17	**Modal Adjectives**	8	0.51
18	**Conditional Subordinators**	10	0.64
19	**Modal Nouns**	4	0.25
Total		768	48.94

Figure 4.1 Frequency and Categories of Hedging in the English Corpus PTW



4.3.1.1 Modal Verbs

As table 4.5 and figure 4.1 illustrate, *modal verbs*, which are associated with epistemic meanings and possibility, were the most frequent category of hedging in the English corpus. These verbs occurred in 149 instances and recorded 9.50 tokens PTW in the overall English corpus. This finding matches other findings where modal verbs were the most prototypical realization of hedging and the most occurring category (e.g., Tahririan & Shahzamani, 2009; Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed, 2019). For instance, Tahririan and Shahzamani (2009), who studied the use of hedging features in ENEs and Persian newspaper editorials (PNEs), found that modal verbs occurred in 292 instances in the whole English corpus and in 121 instances in the Persian corpus. Modal verbs are generally used to indicate various degrees of the writer/speaker's certainty, epistemic meaning, possibility, tentativeness, and probability. In the English corpus, 8 subcategories of modal verbs occurring at different rates were observed as table 4.5 showed. As shown in table 4.5, the most frequently used modal verbs in the English corpus were *would*, *could*, *can*, *may should*, and *need to* occurring respectively as follows:

4.3.1.1.1 Would

Hardjanto (2016) argues that *would* can be used as a hypothetical expression to indicate a higher degree of tentativeness. In the English corpus as shown in figure 4.1, would was the most

frequently used modal verbs occurring in 43 instances and recording 2.74 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. This finding supports the findings of Sedaghat et al. (2015) of the use of hedging in the ENEs and PNEs. Sedaghat et al., (2015) found that would was the most frequent modal verbs in the English corpus occurring in 114 instances and accounting for 38.04% out of the total number of hedging in the English corpus. The following example is extracted from the English corpus shows the use of *would*:

(1) Spain's prime minister, Pedro Sánchez, **would** be doing the right thing…

4.3.1.1.2 Could

The second most frequently used modal verb in the English corpus was *could*. Hardjanto (2016) explains that could is used to indicate epistemic or tentative possibility. In the English corpus, could occurred in 39 instances and recorded 2.49 tokens PTW in the whole corpus. The following example shows the use of could in the English corpus:

(2) But the White House **could** easily do far more to intervene to stop the slaughter.

4.3.1.1.3 Can

Can indicate various degrees of future possibility, probability, likelihood, tentative assumption, or assessment. Both can and could can indicate possibility in the future, but the use of can denotes slightly a more definite possibility. The modal can ranked third among English modal verbs occurring in 24 instances and recording 1.53 tokens PTW in the entire corpus. However, Rabab'ah (2013) found that can recorded the highest frequency (371 instances) among *modal verbs* in English education and nursing articles. The following example taken from the corpus shows the use of *can*:

(3) Unless some way **can** be found to capture the emissions from power plants…

4.3.1.1.4 May

The fourth most frequent *modal verb* used in the English corpus was *may*. May in its epistemic function can be used to indicate future possibility and probability. This modal occurred in 17 instances in the English corpus and recorded 1.08 tokens PTW in the corpus. However, this finding does not support Sanjaya's (2013) findings of use of hedging in English and Indonesian research articles. Sanjaya found that may was the most frequently used modal in the English corpus. The following example from the corpus shows the use of may:

(4) It **may** well be that the Israeli military has advised the cabinet accordingly.

4.3.1.1.5 Should

The modal verb *should* in its epistemic or hedging use can indicate speculation and reduce the strength of the claim. Should ranked fifth among modal verbs in the English corpus occurring in 11 instances and recorded 0.70 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. The following example taken from the corpus shows the use of should:

(5) Afghanistan's future: withdrawal **should** not mean abandonment.

4.3.1.1.6 Other Modal Verbs

The third least frequently used modal verbs identified in the English corpus were *need to*, *might*, and *ought to*. Might is usually used to indicate probability and epistemic meaning. It occurred in 5 instances and recorded 0.32 tokens PTW in the entire English corpus. *Need to* and *ought to* occurred very rarely in their epistemic or hedging functions. They occurred in the English corpus as follows: *Need to* (RF =5, MF = 0.10) and *ought to* (RF=7, MF = 0.14). The following example illustrates the use of the modal verb *ought to* in the English corpus:

(6) That **ought to** worry Europeans…

4.3.1.2 Agentless Passives

Agentless passives are used by speakers or writers to mitigate a proposition and avoid any categorical commitment to a claim. They ranked second among hedging categories in the English corpus occurring in 106 instances and recording 6.76 tokens PTW in the overall English corpus. This category can indicate an indirect reporting of speech acts (Fraser, 2010). The use of agentless passives in the English corpus is illustrated in the following example:

(7) Hundreds of Palestinians **were wounded** while more than 20 Israeli police officers suffered injuries.

4.3.1.3 Adverbs of Frequency, Degree, Time, or Quantity

The third most frequent category in the English corpus was *adverbs of frequency*, *degree*, or *time*. This category consists of all adverbs that indicate an approximate degree of verbal actions to avoid providing exact figures or entities. Salager-Meyer (1994) labels this category as *approximators* since it can replace exact numbers and give approximate information to the data. Salager-Meyer (2011) argues that approximators are used when we are not sure about the exactness of certain figures or when the speaker does not have enough knowledge in order to be precise and accurate. As table 4.5 and figure 4.1, these adverbs occurred in 88 instances and recorded 5.61 tokens PTW in the entire English corpus. This supports the findings of Rabab'ah and Abu Rumman (2015), who found that such adverbs were the second most frequently used hedging category in the speech of King of Jordan, King Abdullah in English. Table 4.6 showed the most frequently

used subcategories of these adverbs in the English corpus:

Table 4.6 Frequency of Adverbs of Frequency, Degree, or Time in the English Corpus

Adverbs of Frequency, Degree, or Time	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
Almost	13	0.82
At least	11	0.70
About	10	0.63
Often	9	0.57
Roughly	8	0.51
Always	6	0.38
Rather	5	0.31
Sometimes	3	0.19
Usually	3	0.19
Mostly	2	0.12
Other Adverbs	18	1.14
Total	88	5.61

One of the most heavily used adverb was *almost* occurring in 13 instances in the entire English corpus and recording 0.82 tokens PTW. The adverb *at least* ranked second occurring in 11 instances and recording 0.70 tokens PTW. *About* ranked in the third position occurring in 10 instances and recording 0.63 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. The adverb *often* ranked fourth occurring in 9 instances and recording 0.57tokens PTW. Similarly, Rabab'ah (2013) found that often occurred in 92 instances recording the highest frequency among *adverbs of frequency* in English nursing and education academic articles. As table 4.6 showed, other more adverbs occurred at approximately comparable rates as follows: *Roughly* (RF = 8, MF = 0.51), *always* (RF = 6, MF = 0.38), and *rather* (RF =*5*, MF = *0.31*). Less frequently used adverbs were *sometimes* (RF = 3, MF = 0.19), *usually* (RF = 3, MF = 0.19), and *mostly* (RF = 2, MF = 0.12). In addition, there was a subcategory of adverbs labeled as *other adverbs* containing various subcategories of adverbs such as *particularly*, *quite*, *partly*, *barely*, *generally* and others. This subcategory occurred in 18 instances and recording 1.14 tokens PTW in the English corpus. The following example from the English corpus shows the use of these adverbs:

(10) The ink on the coalition agreement was **barely** dry when Mr. Netanyahu showed that he intends to go down fighting.

4.3.1.4 Quantifiers/Determiners

The fourth most frequent hedging category in the English corpus was *quantifiers* or *determiners* occurring in 86 instances and recording 5.48 tokens PTW in the English corpus. In

the English corpus, 10 subcategories of quantifiers or determiners were observed as shown in table 4.7:

Table 4.7 Frequency of Quantifiers/Determiners in the English Corpus

Quantifiers or Determiners	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
Some	14	0.89
Many	12	0.76
Much	12	0.76
Most	11	0.70
A little / Little	10	0.63
A lot	9	0.57
A few/few	7	0.44
Any	5	0.31
More	4	0.25
A bit	2	0.12
Total	86	5.48

As illustrated in table 4.7, the most frequently used quantifier or determiner was *some* occurring in 14 instances and recording 0.89 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. *Many* and *much* were used at comparable rates ranking second among English quantifiers occurred in 12 instances and recording 0.76 tokens PTW. *Most* ranked third occurring in 11 instances and recording 0.70 tokens PTW. *A little/little, a lot, a few/few, any,* and *more,* ranked fourth among the quantifiers/determiners used in the English corpus occurring as follows: A little/little (RF = 10, MF = 0.63), a lot (RF = 9, MF = 0.57), a few/few (RF = 7, MF = 0.44), any (RF =5, MF = 0.31), and more (RF = 4, MF = 0.25). The least frequently used quantifiers/determiners was a bit occurring as follows: (RF =2, MF= 0.12). The following example extracted from the corpus shows the use of these quantifiers:

(11) **Most** peace initiatives run into the sand…

4.3.1.5 Reference Structures

The fifth most frequently used hedging category in the English corpus was *reference structures.* This category occurred in 70 instances and recorded 4.46 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. This finding supports Villanueva's (2014) findings of the use of hedging in English and Philippine NEs. Villanueva (2014) found that reference structures accounted for 50 % out of the total number of hedging features used in the ENEs and Pilipino NEs. In the present research, most occurrences of English reference structures were in the form of verbs reporting or referencing an official figure, person, experts, or sources. Several other instances of reference structures were

introduced by the phrase *according to*, which was very frequent in the English corpus as shown in the following example:

(12) Last month, *according to the Wall Street Journal*, Mr. Biden decided against slowing the withdrawal from the main U.S. air base in the country.

4.3.1.6 Epistemic Lexical Verbs

The sixth most frequently used English category of hedging was *epistemic lexical verbs*. Salager-Meyer (2011) demonstrates that *epistemic lexical verbs* are speech act verbs used to perform acts such as doubting and evaluating. They are tentative strategies used by the writer/speaker to report the other researchers' studies or represent tentative reports of his/her own work (Varttala, 2001). They indicate that speakers or writers' state of knowledge is not absolute, but it is based on assessments or beliefs. These verbs occurred in 65 instances and recorded 4.14 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. This does not support Rabab'ah's (2013) findings, who found that epistemic lexical verbs recorded the highest mean scores (24.06 %) in English education and nursing articles. In the English corpus, 10 major subcategories of epistemic lexical verbs were identified as the following table shows:

Table 4.8 Frequency of Epistemic Lexical Verbs in the English Corpus

Epistemic Lexical Verbs	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
Seem	16	1.02
Appear	12	0.76
Look	9	0.57
Consider	7	0.44
See	6	0.38
Suppose	4	0.25
Believe	2	0.12
Assume	2	0.12
Indicate	2	0.12
Other Epistemic Lexical Verbs	5	0.31
Total	65	4.14

As table 4.8 shows, verbs such as *seem*, *appear*, and *look* were the most frequently used among English epistemic lexical verbs occurring as follows: Seem (RF = 16, MF =1.02), appear (RF = 12, MF = 0.76), and look (RF = 9, MF = 0.57). Epistemic lexical verbs such as *consider*, *see*, and *suppose* ranked second occurring as follows: Consider (RF=7, MF = 0.44), see (RF= 6, MF = 0.38), and suppose (RF =4, MF = 0.25). However, epistemic lexical verbs such as *believe*, *assume*, and *indicate* ranked third occurring as follows: Believe (RF = 2, MF = 0.12), assume (RF=

2, MF = 0.12), and indicate (RF =2, MF = 0.12). It is noteworthy that the subcategory labeled as *other epistemic lexical verbs* containing other verbs were the least frequently used verbs occurring in 5 instances and recording 0.31 tokens PTW. The following example from the corpus shows the use of these verbs in the English corpus:

(13) But the winds **seem** favorable, at least for some type of revived agreement.

4.3.1.7 Conditional Clauses

The use of *conditional clauses* in their epistemic or hedging meaning usually might denote conditional probability of a particular action in the future or a hypothetical conditionality in a proposition. Similarly, only conditional clauses indicating future conditionality could function as hedging features. According to Zarza (2018), NErs use *if clauses* to show a lack of definiteness of future prediction. According to Jabbar (2019), conditional clauses might indicate a hypothetical situation and denote the writer's epistemic stance. Conditional clauses were a frequent category in the English corpus occurring in 41 instances and recording 2.61 tokens PTW in the English corpus. The following example shows the use of conditional clauses in the English corpus:

(14) The Israelis, in particular, will respond to political pressure **if** it is exerted with sufficient skill and firmness.

4.3.1.8 Concessive Conjunctions

Concessive conjunctions ranked eighth among hedging categories in the English corpus occurring in 28 instances and recording 1.78 tokens PTW in the entire English corpus. Concessive conjunctions are words or phrases that indicate that the speaker/writer presents his/her opinions tentatively and cohesively. *Although* and *though/even though* were the most frequently used concessive conjunctions in the English corpus occurring as follows: Although (RF = 14, MF = 0.89) and though/even though (RF = 10, MF = 0.63). *Despite of/ despite that*, *nevertheless*, and *albeit* were less frequently used occurring in 4 instances and recording 0.25 tokens PTW. The following example shows the use of concessive conjunctions in the English corpus:

15) **Despite** evidence that Iran was complying with its obligations, Trump withdrew from the agreement…

4.3.1.9 Modal Adverbs

Modal adverbs functioning as hedging features ranked ninth occurring in 20 instances and recording 1.27 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. Nine major subcategories of modal adverbs were observed in the English corpus as table 4.9 showed:

Table 4.9 Frequency of Modal Adverbs in the English Corpus

Modal Adverbs	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
Likely/Unlikely	5	0.31
Maybe/Perhaps	4	0.25
Probably	3	0.19
Possibly	3	0.19
Ostensibly/Apparently	2	0.12
Unexpectedly/Expectedly	2	0.12
Supposedly	1	0.06
Total	20	1.27

Table 4.9 shows that adverbs such as *likely/unlikely* and *maybe/perhaps* were the most frequently used modal adverbs in the English corpus occurring as follows: Likely/unlikely (RF =5, MF =0.31), and maybe/perhaps (RF = 4, MF = 0.25). Modal adverbs such as *probably* and *possibly* ranked second occurring as follows: Probably (RF=3, MF = 0.19), possibly (RF = 3, MF = 0.19). Similarly, Rabab'ah (2013) found that *probably* and *possibly* occurred in 292 instances recording the highest frequency among modal adverbs in English nursing and education academic articles. However, adverbs such as *ostensibly/apparently*, *unexpectedly/expectedly*, and *supposedly* were the least frequent modal adverbs occurring as follows: Ostensibly/apparently (RF =2, MF = 0.12), unexpectedly /expectedly (RF = 2, MF = 0.12), and supposedly (RF =1, MF = 0.06). The following example from the English corpus illustrates the use of such adverbs:

(16) Mr. Johnson to make the Northern Ireland protocol work and is **likely** to repeat that message in Cornwall.

4.3.1.10 Rhetorical Questions

Rhetorical questions as hedging features typically function to establish a more dialogic interaction between the writer and reader in newspaper discourse, thus the writer's arguments or views approved by his/her reader (Khabbazi-Oskouei, 2012). The writer/speaker does not seek an answer for his/her rhetorical question, but rather he/she actually tries to present his/her views/claims tentatively and indirectly. Rhetorical questions were less frequently used in the English corpus than other previous categories occurring in 19 instances and recording 0.21 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. The following example shows the use of rhetorical questions in the English corpus:

(17) **Why** Cuba's youth are revolting now against the island's dictators?

4.3.1.11 Indefinite /Impersonal Pronouns

One less frequently used hedging feature in the English corpus was *indefinite/impersonal*

pronouns occurring in 18 instances and recording 1.15 tokens PTW in the whole corpus. As shown in table 4.10, 8 major subcategories of indefinite/impersonal pronouns were observed in the English corpus:

Table 4.10 Frequency of Indefinite/Impersonal Pronouns in the English corpus

Indefinite /Impersonal Pronouns	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
Some	5	0.31
Many	4	0.25
Much	3	0.19
One	3	0.19
A little/Little/ A few/ Few/ A lot	2	0.12
Most	1	0.06
Total	18	1.15

As table 4.10 shows, pronouns such as *some, many, much*, and *one* were the most frequently occurring indefinite/impersonal pronouns in the English corpus occurring as follows: Some (RF = 5, MF= 0.31), many (RF= 4, MF= 0.25), much (RF= 3, MF= 0.19), and one (RF = 3, MF= 0.19). Less frequently occurring pronouns were *a little/little/a few/few/a lot*, and *most* occurring as follows: A little/little/a few/few/a lot (RF = 2, MF = 0.12) and most (RF = 1, MF = 0.06). The following example from the English corpus illustrates the use of indefinite/impersonal pronouns:

(17) Mr. Trump has long sought — a grander bargain than President Barack Obama got, **one** that would address...

4.3.1.12 Adjectives

Some *adjectives* are used in English to indicate the writer/speaker's uncertainty or tentativeness. Hedging adjectives were less frequently used features in the English corpus occurring in 15 instances and recording 0.96 tokens PTW in the whole corpus. In the English corpus, 4 subcategories of hedging adjectives were observed as shown in table 4.12:

Table 4.11 ***Frequency of Adjectives in the English Corpus***

Adjectives	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
Uncertain/Particular	5	0.31
Obvious	4	0.25
Approximate/Pending/Incipient	3	0.19
Other adjectives	3	0.19
Total	15	0.96

As table 4.11 shows, *uncertain/particular* were the most frequently used adjectives

occurring in 5 instances and recording 0.31 tokens PTW. However, *obvious* ranked second among hedging adjectives occurring in 4 instances and recording 0.25 tokens PTW. Adjectives such as *approximate/pending/incipient* were less frequently used occurring as follows: Approximate/ pending/incipient (RF=3, MF=0.19). Adjectives, labeled as *other adjectives*, occurred in 3 instances and recorded 0.19 tokens PTW. Example (18) from the English corpus shows the use of such adjectives:

(18) The **obvious** explanation is that this is a recovery from an unprecedented recession…

4.3.1.13 Metalinguistic Comments

Metalinguistic comments are words, phrases, or interjections, irrelevant to the main proposition, used by the writer/speaker to hedge his/her views or claims in a discourse. In fact, this category is used to guide the listener/reader to better interpret the views presented (Fraser, 2010). *Metalinguistic comments* occurred in 12 instances recording 0.76 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. Hamood (2015) found that metalinguistic comments were the most frequent category in WhatsApp group discussions between Arab and Malaysian English learners. Metalinguistic comments such as *by the way, to be fair, if at all, in any case, in one sense,* and *most importantly* were very frequent in the English corpus. The following example shows the use of metalinguistic comments in the English corpus:

(19) **By the way**, the Biden administration has no interest right now in being forced to react to those headlines.

4.3.1.11 Other Categories of Hedging in English Corpus:

4.3.1.11.1 Nouns

Nouns functioning as hedging features were less frequently used occurring in 12 instances and recording 1.76 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. *Assumption* occurred in 5 instances and recorded 0.31 tokens PTW, and *claim* occurred in 4 instances and recorded 0.25 tokens PTW. *Indication*, *uncertainty*, and *assessment* were less frequently used, each one of them, occurring in 1 instance and recording 0.06 tokens PTW. The following example clarifies the use of such nouns as hedging features in the English corpus:

(20) But they do show that the **assumption** everything has already failed is exaggerated.

4.3.1.11.2 Conditional Subordinators

Conditional subordinators are words such as *as long as, so long as, assuming that, given that*, and others, which connect two sentences and indicate that one proposition is conditioned by

another to avoid any absolute responsibility. Conditional subordinators occurred in 10 instances recoding 0.64 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. Among conditional subordinators, *as long as* recorded the highest frequency occurring in 5 instances and recording 0.31 tokens PTW. The following example from the English corpus shows the use of conditional subordinators:

(21) But **as long as** Israeli politics remains on a knife-edge, the opportunity will be hard to seize.

4.3.1.11.3 Introductory Phrases

Introductory phrases are adjective, noun, or verb phrases positioned at the beginning of a sentence to modify or mitigate another sentence proposition. According to Salager-Meyer (2011), introductory phrases, such as *we know*, *we believe*, *to our knowledge*, and others can indicate "the authors' personal doubt and direct involvement" (p.7). According to Rabab'ah and Abu Rumman (2015), *introductory phrases* are used by the speaker/writer to indicate that his/her statements are his/her personal points of view rather than facts. Introductory phrases can indicate that the writer/speaker wants to engage the reader/listener in his/her views and thus show awareness to the reader/listener's opinions (Rabab'ah & Abu Rumman, 2015). Introductory phrases were less frequently used occurring in 9 instances and recording 0.57 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. The following example illustrates the use of introductory phrases in the English corpus:

(22) **There's some talk** in the Pentagon of seeking authorization to launch airstrikes from outside Afghanistan…

4.3.1.11.4 Compound Hedging

Combining two or more hedging features, known as *compound hedging*, is common in English language. Compound hedging was a less frequently used category than other categories corpus occurring in 8 instances and recording 0.50 tokens PTW in the entire English corpus. *Double hedging* and *treble hedging* were frequently used in the English corpus. Double hedging occurring in 5 instances and recording 0.31 tokens PTW. However, treble hedging was rarely used occurring in only 3 instances in the entire English corpus and recording 0.19 tokens PTW. The following example from the English corpus illustrates the use of compound hedging:

(23) An agreement to revive the nuclear deal with Iran **appears possible** as the United States…

4.3.1.11.5 Modal Adjectives and Modal Nouns

Modal adjectives (e.g., possible, impossible, plausible, potential, predictable, apparent…) are hedging features used to mitigate a proposition and indicate that the information presented is possible or probable rather than absolute. Varttala (2001) argues that *modal adjectives* are

adjectives that reduce the strength of the claim and are used to indicate the writer/speaker's possibility, probability, or uncertainty of a claim. Modal adjective were very rarely used occurring in 8 instances and recording 0.50 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. This finding supports Khoshsima, Talati-Baghsiahi, and Moafian's (2016) findings, who found that modal adjectives were the least frequent hedging category in all three corpora of linguistics research articles (i.e. Anglo-American writers, Iranian writers in English, and Iranian writers in Persian). The following example shows the use of modal adjectives as hedging features in the corpus:

(24) The evictions have been described by a UN rights body as a **possible** war crime.

The least frequently used hedging category in the English corpus was *modal nouns*. Modal nouns are nouns that indicate a probable or possible state of the proposition presented (e.g., *possibility, impossibility, likelihood, unlikelihood, predictability, unpredictability, expectation*). Modal nouns occurred in only 4 instances and recorded 0.21 tokens PTW in the entire English corpus. The following example clarifies the use of these nouns in the English corpus:

(25) Mr. Trump raised just that **possibility** last month, at a signing ceremony for yet another round of sanctions against Iran's leaders.

4.3.2 Frequency and Categories of Boosting in the English Corpus

By providing table 4.12, the researcher attempts to answer research questions: What is the frequency of occurrence of hedging and boosting in the ENEs (English corpus)? Moreover, what are the linguistic forms or categories of hedging and boosting used in the English and Arabic corpus? The analysis of the English corpus shows that the ENErs used 10 categories of boosting to boost their propositions or claims. Table 4.12 presents the raw and mean frequency PTW of each category of boosting in the entire English corpus:

Table 4.12 ***Frequency and Categories of boosting in the English Corpus***

Category of Boosting		Raw Frequency of Boosting in Overall ENEs	Mean Frequency PTW in Overall ENEs
1	**Modal Verbs**	69	4.40
	Will	41	2.61
	Must	18	1.15
	Cannot/Can't	5	0.32
	Have to	3	0.19
	Should not	2	0.13

2	**Adverbs of Degree, Time, and Frequency**	49	3.12
3	**Quantifiers/ Determiners**	15	0.96
4	**Epistemic / Lexical Verbs**	5	0.32
5	**Indefinite /Impersonal Pronouns**	7	0.45
6	**Nouns**	4	0.25
7	**Introductory Phrases /Verbs**	4	0.25
8	**Adjectives**	9	0.57
9	**Compound Boosting**	4	0.25
10	**Metalinguistic Comments**	3	0.19
Total		169	10.56

4.3.2.1 Modal Verbs

Modal verbs were the first most frequent category of boosting in the English corpus occurring in 69 instances and recording 4.40 tokens of boosting PTW in the whole corpus. Modal verbs such as *will*, *must*, *shall*, and *cannot* function to indicate necessity, certainty, or obligation. According to Palmer (1990), they assert the speaker's confidence in the truth of a proposition and often indicate authority or conviction. Speakers or writers use modal verbs as boosting features to assert their authority or expertise (Hyland, 1998a). *Will* was a very frequently used boosting feature occurring in 41 instances and recording 2.61 tokens PTW in the English corpus. *Must* was the second most frequently used boosting feature. It occurred in 18 instances and recorded 1.15 tokens PTW. *Cannot*, *have to*, and *should not* were less frequently used boosting features. They occurred as follows: Cannot (RF=5, MF=0.32), have to (RF=3, MF=0.19), and should not (RF= 2, MF= 0.13). The following example from the English corpus illustrates the use of modal verbs as a boosting feature:

(26) It **will** take time for the gentle diplomatic proddings from the United Nations…to be taken seriously.

4.3.2.2 Adverbs of Degree, Time, and Frequency

Adverbs of degree, *time*, and *frequency* were the second most frequently occurring boosting category in the English corpus. They occurred in 49 instances and recorded 3.12 tokens PTW in the whole corpus. These averbs amplify the force of a statement. Hyland (2005b) labels them *intensifiers.* According to him, they increase the strength of a claim, making it more emphatic and

convincing. As shown in Table 4.13, 6 subcategories of these adverbs were observed in the corpus:

Table 4.13 Frequency of Adverbs of Frequency, Degree, or Time in the English Corpus

Adverbs of Frequency, Degree, or Time	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
Indeed /at all/of course	16	1.02
Surely/certainly	10	0.64
Really/exactly	8	0.51
Never/ever	7	0.45
Largely/strongly/clearly/deeply/fully	5	0.32
Definitely/indefinitely/decisively	3	0.19
Total	49	3.12

Table 4.13 shows that adverbs such as *indeed /at all/of course* functioning as boosting features were frequently used occurring in 16 instances and recording 1.02 tokens PTW. Other adverbs were less frequently used occurring as follows: *Surely/certainly* (RF=10, MF=0.64), *really/exactly* (RF=8, MF= 0.51), *never/ever* (RF= 7, MF= 0.45), *largely/strongly/clearly/deeply/fully* (RF=5, MF= 0.32), and *definitely/indefinitely/decisively* (RF= 3, MF= 0.19). The following example from the English shows the use of these adverbs:

(27) But America is **certainly** leaving. "Afghans are going to have to decide their future," Biden said on June 25…

4.3.2.3 Quantifiers/Determiners

Quantifiers or *determiners* functioning as boosting features ranked third among boosting categories used in the English corpus. They occurred in 15 instances and recorded 0.96 tokens PTW. These boosting features are used to indicate a complete modification of the category of nouns. The quantifiers *any* and *all* were the most frequently used boosting subcategories in the English corpus. The following example from the English corpus illustrates the use of this category:

(28) His rise is bad news for **all** Iranians, especially members of religious minorities.

4.3.2.4 Adjectives

Adjectives were the fourth most frequent category of boosting occurring in 9 instances and recording 0.57 adjectives PTW in the whole English corpus. Hyland (2005b) states that adjectives, similar to verbs, function as *intensifiers* to increase the strength of a claim making it more emphatic and convincing. *Obvious*, *considerable*, *significant*, *large*, and *remarkable* were the only boosting adjectives used in the English corpus. The following example from the English corpus illustrates the use of such adjectives:

(29) The most **obvious** and important point is that a dangerously naïve consensus has emerged in Israel…

4.3.2.5 Indefinite/Impersonal Pronouns

Indefinite or *impersonal pronouns* were the fifth most used category of boosting. They occurred in 7 instances and recorded 0.45 pronouns PTW in the entire English corpus. *Much*, *anything*, *anyone*, *everything*, and *anymore* were the only indefinite boosting pronouns used in the whole English corpus. The following example shows the use of such pronouns in the English corpus:

(30) **Much** also depends on what Hamas chooses to do.

4.3.2.6 Epistemic Lexical Verbs

The sixth most frequently used boosting feature was *epistemic lexical verbs*, which are used to amplify or boost a statement or claim. They occurred in 5 instances and recorded 0.32 verbs PTW in the whole English corpus. *Prove*, *assert*, and *confirm* were the only epistemic lexical verbs used as boosting features in the English corpus as shown in the following example:

(31) As President Biden has **asserted**, the Afghan government bears the major responsibility.

4.3.2.7 Other Categories of Boosting

There were other boosting categories less frequently used such as *introductory phrases/verbs*, *compound boosting*, *nouns*, and *metalinguistic comments*. Introductory phrases/verbs occurred in only 4 instances and recorded 0.25 tokens PTW in the whole English corpus. The following example illustrates the use of introductory phrases/verbs as boosting features in the English corpus:

(30)…**it's precisely that** geniality that raises the ire of Raisi and his spiteful Islamist worldview.

Moreover, in the English corpus, *compound boosting* was a less frequently used category. It refers to combining two boosting to amplify a claim or proposition. Compound boosting occurred in 4 instances and recorded 0.25 tokens PTW. Two types of compound boosting were used in the English corpus: Double and treble boosting. The following example shows the use of compound boosting in the English corpus:

(31) That future **will** almost **certainly** not include an offer from Madrid…

Nouns functioning as boosting features were scarcely used in the English corpus. They occurred in 4 instances and recorded 0.25 nouns PTW in the whole corpus. *No doubt* and *fact* were the only boosting subcategories of nouns occurring in the English corpus. Example (32) below shows the use of such nouns in the English corpus:

(32)…Mr Biden is happy to pass the role of mediator passively to China, which seems keen to assert its power in the interests of peace (and, **no doubt**, of China).

Metalinguistic Comments were the least frequently used category of boosting occurring in only 3 instances and recording 0.19 tokens PTW in the whole corpus. The following example shows one instance of use of metalinguistic comments in the English corpus:

(33) Unless, **of course**, López Obrador is not really looking ahead…

4.3.3 Frequency and Categories of Hedging Features in the Arabic Corpus

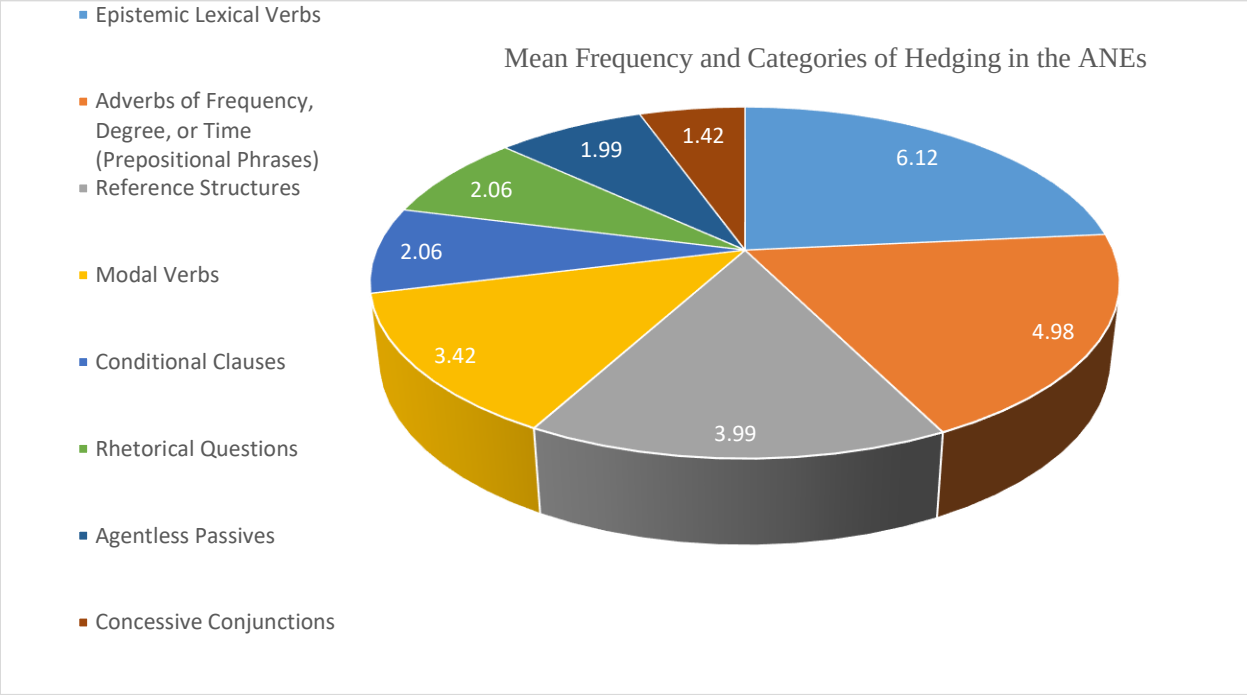
By providing figure 4.2 and table 4.14, the researcher attempts to answer the two research questions: What is the frequency of occurrence of hedging and boosting in the ANEs (Arabic corpus)? Moreover, what are the linguistic forms or categories of hedging and boosting used in the English and Arabic corpora? Unlike the ENErs, the analysis of the Arabic corpus showed that the ANErs used 20 categories of hedging to mitigate their claims. However, the ANErs used limitedly less varied subcategories of hedging. Similarly, Samaie et al. (2014) found that the PNEs used less varied subcategories of hedging than the ENEs. In the present research, the ENErs employed 143 subcategories of hedging features, whereas the ANErs used 102 subcategories. Table 4.14 and figure 4.2 present the overall raw and mean frequency for every category of hedging in the entire Arabic corpus:

Table 4.14 Frequency and Categories of Hedging in the ANEs

Category of Hedging Features 14,052		**Raw Frequency**	**Mean Frequency PTW**
1	**Adverbs of Frequency, Degree, or Time (Prepositional Phrases)**	70	4.98
2	**Modal Verbs**	48	3.42
3	**Epistemic Lexical Verbs**	86	6.12
4	**Quantifiers/Determiners**	22	1.57
5	**Reference Structures**	56	3.99
6	**Conditional Clauses**	29	2.06
7	**Impersonal/Indefinite Pronouns**	11	0.78
8	**Rhetorical Questions**	29	2.06
9	**Qad Structure**	12	0.85
10	**Nouns**	5	0.36
11	**Agentless Passives**	28	1.99
12	**Similar- to-verb Particles**	7	0.50
13	**Rubbama Particle**	14	1.00
14	**Modal Adverbs**	12	0.85
15	**Conditional subordinators**	5	0.36
16	**Concessive Conjunctions**	20	1.42
17	**Introductory Phrases/Verbs**	3	0.21

18	**Modal Nouns**	9	0.64
19	**Modal Adjectives**	11	0.78
20	**Metalinguistic Comments**	2	0.21
Total		479	34.08

Figure 4.2 Frequency and Categories of Hedging in the ANEs



4.3.3.1 Epistemic Lexical Verbs

Epistemic lexical verbs ranked first among hedging categories in the Arabic corpus occurring in 86 instances and recording 6.12 tokens PTW. Abbadi (2014), in a study of argumentative strategies used by ENErs and ANErs, found that the ANEs contained a more frequent number of epistemic lexical verbs than the ENEs. Furthermore, this does not support Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed's (2019) findings, who found that epistemic lexical verbs were the second most frequently used category in the ANEs with a percentage of 19.6%. As illustrated in table 4.15, 10 subcategories of epistemic lexical verbs were identified in the Arabic corpus:

Table 4.15 Frequency of Epistemic Lexical Verbs in the Arabic Corpus

Epistemic Lexical Verbs	English Equivalents	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
yū'ād (يعدّ), ya'tābir (يعتبر)	Consider	16	1.14
Yabdu،yaẓhar (يبدو/يظهر)	seem/appear	14	1.00

ya’takid (يعتقد)، yaẓin(يظن)، yaftariḍ(يفترض)	think/believe/consider	13	0.93
yatawaqqa’(يتوقّع)، yūqddir (يقدّر)	estimate/expect	12	0.85
Yushīr، yuẓhīr، yuḍiḥ (يشير/يظهر/يوضح)	Show/demonstrate/indicate	10	0.71
yūqārib(يقارب), yatārāwaḥ (يتراوح)	almost/about/reach	8	0.57
yāqtariḥ, yadā’a (يدّعي/يقترح)	suggest/claim	6	0.43
yūrajjiḥ(يرجّح)	almost/likely	3	0.21
yara (يرى)	observe/ see	3	0.21
ya’ani (يعني)	mean	1	0.07
Total		**86**	**6.12**

As table 4.14 shows, epistemic lexical verbs such *yū’ād/ya’tābir*(consider), *yabdu*/yaẓhar (seem/appear), and *ya’taqid/yaẓinn/yaftariḍ* (think/believe/suppose) were the most frequent epistemic lexical verbs occurring as follows: Yū’ād/ya’tābir (consider) (RF = 16, MF =1.14), yabdu/yaẓhār (seem/appear)(RF =14, MF=1.00), and ya’taqid/yaẓin/yaftariḍ(think/believe/ suppose)(RF =13, MF=0.93). However, verbs such as *yatawaqqa’/yūqaddir* (estimate/expect), *yūshīr/yūẓhir/yūḍih* (show/demonstrate/indicate), and *yūqarib/yatarawaḥ* (almost/about/reach) ranked second occurring as follows: Yatawaqqa’/yūkddir (estimate/expect) (RF = 12, MF=0.85), yūshīr/yūẓhir/yūḍiḥ (show/ demonstrate/indicate)(RF=10, MF=0.71), and yūqārib/yatarawaḥ (almost/about/reach)(RF = 8, MF = 0.57). The least frequently used epistemic lexical verbs were *yāqtariḥ/yadā’a* (suggest/claim), *yūrajjiḥ* (almost/likely), *yara* (see), and *ya’ani* (mean) occurring as follows: Yāqtariḥ/yadā’a (suggest/claim)(RF =6, MF = 0.43), yūrajiḥ (almost/likely) (RF = 3, MF =0.21), yara (see) (RF =3 , MF = 0.21), and ya’ni (mean)(RF = 1, MF =0.07). The following example shows the use of epistemic lexical verbs in the Arabic corpus:

Although this **seems** to break the stalemate between all parties, nothing is really hopeful…	(33) رغم ما **يبدو** أنه وصول لجميع الأطراف إلى «نهاية السكّة» فلا شيء حقيقيا يدعو للتفاؤل... (seem/yabdu)

4.3.3.2 Adverbs of Frequency, Time, or Degree (Propositional Phrases)

Adverbs of frequency, *time*, or *degree*, *(*also prepositional phrases or approximators) ranked second among categories of hedging in the Arabic corpus occurring in 70 instances and recording 4.98 tokens PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. Similarly, Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed (2019) found that approximators of degree, quantity, and frequency were the most frequently used hedging category in the economic ANEs. To indicate imprecision or limitation on the applicability of their arguments, Arabic writers mostly used the adverbs of frequency such as *‘ādatan* (usally/ عادةً), *aḥāynan* (somtimes/ أحياناً), and others (Andrusenko, 2015). Moreover, Al-Zarieni et al. (2019)

found that approximators were one of the most commonly used hedging categories in Arabic abstracts written by Arab native drafters. As shown in table 4.16, 7 subcategories of adverbs of frequency, time, or degree were observed in the Arabic corpus:

Table 4.16 Frequency of Adverbs of Frequency, Time, or Degree in the Arabic corpus

Adverbs of Frequency, Time, or Degree	English Equivalents	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
aḥyanan, fī- bā'aḍi al- 'aḥyān (في بعض الاحيان/أحياناً)	Sometimes	**13**	**0.92**
nādīran, minn- nadir, bil- kād (من النادر / بالكاد/ نادرا)	Rarely/barely	**12**	**0.85**
ghaliban (غالباً)، 'ala 'āghlab (على الأغلب) 'ūmuman (عموماً)	generally/often	**10**	**0.71**
taqrīban (تقريباً), naḥwa (نحو)	about/almost	**9**	**0.64**
nisbīyan (نسبياً), tadrījyan (تدريجياً)	gradually/relatively	**6**	**0.42**
mīraran wa tikrāran (مراراً و تكراراً) tārātan (تارةً)	every now and then/sometimes	**5**	**0.35**
ila ḥaden mā (الى حد ما), ila ḥaden mū'ain (إلى حد معين)	to some degree/to some extent	**4**	**0.28**
bī- naḥwin (بنحو)/ bī- ḥawali (بحوالي)	to some degree/ almost/about	**4**	**0.28**
'ala 'āqa (على الأقل)، 'ala māda (على المدى)	at least/on level	**3**	**0.21**
min-al- mānṭīqi (من المنطقي)	Reasonably/logically	**2**	**0.12**
li- or ila naḥwin (لنحو/الى نحو) li- dārāja (لدرجة)	to some extent/ almost/to particular degree	**2**	**0.12**
Total		**70**	**4.98**

Among adverbs of frequency, time, or degree in the Arabic corpus, *'aḥyanan/fī- bā'aḍi al- 'aḥyān* (sometimes) ranked first occurring in 13 instances and recording 0.92 tokens PTW. However, adverbs such as *nādīran/minn-al-nadir, bil-kād* (rarely/barely), *ghaliban/'ala 'āghlab* (often), and *'ūmūman* (generally) ranked second occurring as follows: Nādīran/minn-al-nadir/bil-kād (rarely/barely)(RF=12 , MF= 0.85), ghaliban/'ala 'āghlab (often) (RF= 10 , MF= 0.71), and 'ūmūman (generally) (RF= 10 , MF= 0.71). *Takrīban* (almost)/*nahwa* (about), and *nisbīyan* (relatively) /*tadrījayan* (gradually) were the second most frequently used adverbs in the Arabic corpus occurring as follows: Taqrīban (almost)/naḥwa (about) (RF =9, MF = 0.64), and nisbīyan (relatively)/tadrījayan (gradually) (RF =6, MF =0.42). Adverbs such as *mīrāran wa tikrīran* (every now and then)/*tāratan* (sometimes), *ila ḥaden mā* (to some extent), *ila ḥaden mū'ain* (to some degree), and *bī- naḥwin/bī- ḥawali* (about/almost) were a less frequent subcategory of hedging occurring as follows: Mīrāran wa tikrīran (every now and then)/tāratan (sometimes) (RF = 5, MF =0.35), *ila ḥaden mā* (to some extent)/*ila ḥaden mū'ain* (to some degree/to some degree) (RF= 4,

MF= 0.28), and *bī- naḥwin/bī- ḥawali* (about/almost) (RF=4, MF=0.28). However, adverbs such as *’ala ‘āqa/’ala māda* (at least/on level), min-al- mānṭīqi (logically), *li- or ila naḥwin*(to some extent/almost), and *li- dārāja* were the least used subcategory occurring as follows: ’ala ‘āqa/’ala māda (at least/on level) (RF=3, MF=0.21), min-al- mānṭīqi (logically) (RF= 2, MF=0.12), li- or ila naḥwin(to some extent/ almost)/li- dārāja (to a particular degree) (RF=2, MF=012).The following example shows the use of such adverbs in the Arabic corpus:

By completely constructing the financial structure in its all pillars, economy **gradually** moves from stagnancy...	(34) وباكتمال المنظومة الاقتصادية بكل دعائمها، السكون ...يتحول الاقتصاد تدريجيًا من وضعية (tadrijyan/gradually)

4.3.3.3 Reference Structures

Reference structures ranked third among Arabic hedging categories occurring in 56 instances and recording 3.99 tokens PTW in the entire Arabic corpus. Similar to the English corpus, the most frequently used subcategory of *reference structures* was references starting with the expression *wifqan li* (according to/وفقاً) occurring in 33 instances and recording 2.34 tokens PTW. The following example from the corpus shows the use of reference structures:

‘‘China would be 17 % out of the world gross domestic product”, **according** to Leen Chirenge...	(35) ستمثل الصين 17 في المئة من الناتج المحلي الإجمالي العالمي، وذلك **وفقاً** لنيل شيرينج... (according to/wifqan li)

4.3.3.4 Modal Verbs

According to Obeidat (1998), Arabic *modal verbs* mitigate the content of the whole sentence, which they introduce and function as sentence modifiers. Modal verbs functioning as hedging features were the fourth most frequent category occurring in 48 instances and recording 3.42 tokens PTW in the entire Arabic corpus. It was clearly observed that the ENErs tended to use modal verbs more frequently than the ANErs. This finding does not support the findings of Sedaghat et al. (2015) of the use of modal verbs in the PNEs and ENEs. These researchers found that the PNErs tended to use *modal verbs* more frequently than the ENErs as hedging features. As shown in table 4.17, 4 subcategories of modal verbs were observed in the Arabic corpus:

Table 4.17 Frequency of Modal Verbs in the Arabic Corpus

Modal Verbs	English Equivalents	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
yūmkin/yastaṭi’ (يمكن/يستطيع)	may/would/could	23	1.63
yakād (يكاد)	about/could be	12	0.85
bāta/aḍḥa(بات/أضحى)	may become/can be	8	0.56

yajūz/la yajūz (يجوز/لا يجوز)	would be/could be/would/	5	0.35
Total		48	3.42

As table 4.17 show, modal verbs such as *yūmkin*/yastaṭi' (may/would/could) were the first most frequent modal verbs occurring in 23 instances and recording 1.63 tokens PTW in the Arabic corpus. Modal verbs such as *yakād* (about/could be) and *bāta/aḍḥa* (can be/may become) were the second most frequently used verbs occurring as follows: Yakād (about/ could be) (RF = 12, MF = 0.85) and bāta/aḍḥa (can be/may become) (RF =8, MF =0.56). *Yajūz* and *la yajūz* (would be/could be/cannot be) were least frequently used modal verbs occurring in 5 instances and recording 0.35 PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. The following example from the Arabic corpus shows the use of *modal verbs:*

The contest between Russia and China over a number of files **could** lead into a conflict…	(36) بأن التنافس بين روسيا والصين في عدد من الملفات **يمكن** أن يتحول تدريجياً إلى صراع...(yūmkin/could/would)

4.3.3.5 Conditional Clauses

Conditional clauses were the fifth most frequently used hedging category occurring in 29 instance and recording 2.06 tokens PTW in the entire Arabic corpus. Conditional clauses usually beginning with conditional particles such as *idha* (if/إذا), *law* (if/لو), *lawla* (unless/لولا), and *inn* (if/إن) were very frequently used in the Arabic corpus. The following example illustrates the use of conditional clauses in the Arabic corpus:

If we do not admit that, the effect of consequences will be global and on future generation.	(37) و**إذا** لم نعترف بذلك، فإن أثر التداعيات سيكون عالمياً ولأجيال مقبلة. (idha/if)

4.3.3.6 Rhetorical Questions

In MSA, *rhetorical questions* usually contain a question words such as *mann* (who/من), *li-mādha* (why/لماذا), *hal* (do/does/is…/هل), *aina* (where/أين), and others. Rhetorical questions were used at comparable rates with conditional clauses. They ranked fifth among hedging category in the Arabic corpus occurring in 29 instances and recording 2.06 tokens PTW. The following example from the corpus shows the use of rhetorical questions in the Arabic corpus:

Is it real to declare that everybody should realize what globalized starvation?	(38) **هل** من حقيقة لا بد من إعلانها حتى يدرك الجميع ماورائيات الجوع المعوّلم؟

4.3.3.7 Agentless Passives

Agentless passives ranked sixth among categories of hedging occurring in 28 instances, recording 1.99 tokens PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. The following example from the Arabic corpus shows the use of agentless passives:

The USA seemed as if it **has been surprised** by the event, or as if it did not prepare itself, as it should be…	(39) الولايات المتحدة بدت وكأنها **فوجئت** بالحدث، أو كأنها لم تتحضر له كما يجب ... (has been surprised/ fūji ‘at)

4.3.3.8 Quantifiers/Determiners

Quantifiers or *determiners* were the seventh most frequent category of hedging in the Arabic corpus. They occurred in 22 instances in the entire corpus and recorded 1.57 tokens PTW in this corpus. As shown in table 4.18, eight subcategories of quantifiers or determiners were identified in the Arabic corpus:

Table 4.18 Frequency of Quantifiers/Determiners in the Arabic Corpus

Quantifiers/Determiners	English Equivalents	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
bā’aḍ(بعض) , biḍa’(بضع)	some/a part of	6	0.43
mazīd (مزيد), qalīl (قليل)	more/much/a little/a few	5	0.36
’adīd (عديد),’idda (عدّة),’adad (عدد)	many/several/number	4	0.28
mū’aiẓam (معظم), ‘aghlabīa (أغلبية)	most/majority	4	0.28
‘akthār (أكثر) ،‘aqal(أقل)، ‘aghlab (أغلب)	less/most	3	0.21
‘aḥad (أحد)	one of	1	0.07
Total		22	1.57

Table 4.19 showed that *bā’aḍ/biḍa’* (some /a part of) and *mazīd/qalīl* (more/much/a little/a few) were the most frequent subcategories of quantifiers/determiners occurring as follows: Bā’aḍ/ biḍa’ (some /part) (RF =6, MF =0.43), and mazīd/qalīl (more/much/a little/a few)(RF =5, MF =0.36). However, quantifiers such as *’ad īd/’ida/’adad* (a lot of/many/several), *mūa’izam /‘aghlaba* (most/majority), and ‘*aqal/‘aghlab* (less/most) ranked second among the Arabic quantifiers occurring as follows: ‘adīd/ ‘ida/‘adad (a lot of/many/several)(RF =4 , MF = 0.28), mū’izam/al-‘aghlabīa/aghlabīa (most/majority)(RF=4, MF=0.28), and ‘aqal/ ‘aghlab (less/ most) (RF = 3, MF =0.21). The quantifier ‘*aḥad* (one of) was the least frequent quantifier occurring as follows: ‘aḥad (one of) (RF =1, MF = 0.7). The following example from the Arabic corpus illustrates the use of quantifiers/determiners**:**

Turkey's policies towards **several** member countries in the NATO…exceed the limit of provocation…	(40) فإن سياسات تركيا تجاه **عدد** من الدول الأعضاء في الناتو... تجاوزت حد الاستفزاز … (‘adad/several)

4.3.3.9 Concessive Conjunctions

Concessive conjunctions were the eighth most frequently used hedging feature in the Arabic corpus occurring in 20 instances and recording 1.42 tokens PTW in the whole corpus. Most structures of Arabic concessive conjunctions in the corpus included sentences containing *rūghma ‘an* or *ala rūghmi ‘an* (although/رغم أن/على الرغم أن).This supports Abbadi's (2014) findings, who found that *ala rūghma ‘an* and *‘bil- rūghmi min* (although) were the most frequent concessive expressions employed in the ANEs. The following example from the corpus shows the use of such category:

Although this seems to break the stalemate between all parties, nothing is really hopeful…	(41) **رغم** ما يبدو أنه وصول لجميع الأطراف إلى نهاية السكّة فلا شيء حقيقيا يدعو للتفاؤل... (rghma/although)

4.3.2.10 Rubbama Particle

Rubbama linguistically consists of two particles: *Rubba* (would/ربّ) is a preposition and *ma* (ما). It indicates a high level of probability or uncertainty. Rubbama structure (maybe/perhaps /ربّما) functioning as a hedging feature ranked ninth among categories of hedging in the Arabic corpus occurring in 14 instances and recording 1.00 tokens PTW in the whole corpus. The following example from the Arabic corpus shows the use of *rubbama* as a hedging feature:

The Israeli **might** think to exploit limited time as well until Iranian presidency election ends…	(42) و**ربّما** يفكر الصهيونيّ باستغلال الوقت الضيق أيضاً إلى حين انتهاء الانتخابات الرئاسية الإيرانية … (maybe/might/rubbama)

4.3.3.15 Qad Structure

Qad structure functioning as a hedging feature usually consists of the imperfective present form of verb *al-mūḍara’* (present/المضارع) preceded by the particle qad (e.g. *qad yakūn*/it would be/قد يكون). According to Abdalla (2018, p.2004), when qad precedes the present form of the verb (imperfect); its meaning or function indicates *taqrīb* or *taqlīl* (approximation/reduced possibility/ diminution/تقليل/تقريب); and it functions to reduce the force of the verb. Qad structure was the tenth most frequently used hedging category in the Arabic corpus occurring in 12 instances and recording 0.85 tokens PTW. The following example from the corpus shows the use of qad structure:

Washington sees that the pressure it has put on Russia for many years would enforce the latter to do some resignation…	(43) وترى واشنطن أن الضغط الذي مارسته على روسيا طوال سنوات **قد يدفع** الأخيرة إلى تقديم تنازلات... (qad/might/could)

4.3.3.16 Modal Adverbs

One less frequently used hedging category in the Arabic corpus was *modal adverbs* ranking eleventh. Modal adverb**s** were used at comparable rates with qad structure occurring in 12 instances and recording 0.85 tokens PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. According to table 4.19, 6 subcategories of modal adverbs functioning as hedging features were observed in the Arabic corpus:

Table 4.19 Frequency of Modal Adverbs in the Arabic Corpus

Modal Adverbs	English Equivalents	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
Mūmkinan (ممكناً)، min-al-mūmikin (من الممكن)	Possibly	3	0.21
min-al-mūḥtamal (من المحتمل)	Probably	3	0.21
min-al- mūtawqa’(من المتوقّع)	Expectedly	2	0.14
mūrājjaḥan (مرجّحاً)، min-al- mūrajjaḥ (من المرجّح)	potentially	2	0.14
Iftīrāḍīan (افتراضياً) min-al-mūftaraḍ(من المفترض)	supposedly/ presumably	1	0.07
ẓāhirīan (ظاهرياً)	Apparently	1	0.07
Total		12	0.85

As shown in table 4.19, modal adverbs such as *mūmkinan/min-al-mūmikin* (possibly) and *min-al-mūḥtamal* (probably) were the most frequent modal adverbs occurring as follows: Mūmkinan/min-al-mūmikin (possibly) (RF=3, MF=0.21), and min-al-mūḥtamal (probably) (RF=3, MF=0.21). Adverbs such as *min-al-mūtawqa’* (expectedly), and *mūrājjaḥan/min-al-mūrajjaḥ* (potentially) were less frequent used occurring as follows: Min-al-mūtawqa’ (expectedly) (MF= 2, MF= 0.14), and mūrājjaḥan/min-al-mūrajjaḥ (potentially) (MF= 2, MF= 0.14). However, adverbs such as *Iftīrāḍīan/min-al-mūftaraḍ* (supposedly/presumably) and *ẓāhirīan* (apparently) were scarcely used occurring as follows: Iftīrāḍīan/min-al-mūftaraḍ (supposedly/presumably) were (MF= 1, MF= 0.07) and ẓāhirīan (apparently) (MF= 1, MF= 0.07). The following example from the corpus illustrates the use of modal adverbs:

It would not be possible, if there was not a substantial barrier between china and Russia…	(44) ولم يكن هذا **ممكناً** لولا وجود سَدٍّ منيع بين الصين وروسيا... (possibly/mūmkinan)

4.3.3.17 Impersonal/Indefinite Pronouns

Impersonal or *indefinite pronouns*, as shown in table 4.14, were the twelfth most frequent category occurring in 11 instances and recording 0.70 tokens PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. As table 4.21, 6 subcategories of impersonal/indefinite pronouns were observed in the Arabic corpus:

Table 4.20 Frequency of Impersonal/Indefinite Pronouns in the Arabic Corpus

Impersonal/Indefinite Pronouns	English Equivalents	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
ba'aḍ/al- ba'aḍ (بعض/البعض)	Some	3	0.21
shai' ma (شيء ما)/makān ma (مكان ما)	something/somewhere	2	0.14
al- 'adīd/'ad īd (العديد/عديد)	many/much	2	0.14
mū'izam (معظم) / 'aghlābīa/al- 'aghlābīa (أغلبية/الغالبية)	a few/a little	2	0.14
al- qalīl /qalīl (القليل/قليل)	majority/most	1	0.07
'aḥad/aḥd ma (أحد/أحد ما)	Somebody	1	0.07
Total		11	0.70

Among impersonal/indefinite pronouns, *ba'aḍ/al-ba'aḍ* (some), *shaya'ma* (something)/ *makan ma* (somewhere), *al-'adīd/'adīd* (many), and *mūa'izam* (most)/ *'aghālbīa/al-'aghlābīa* (majority/most) ranked first occurring as follows: Ba'aḍ/al- ba'aḍ (some) (RF = 3, MF = 0.21), shai' ma (something)/makan ma (somewhere)(RF =2, MF =0.14), al-'adīd/'ad īd (many) (RF =2, MF = 0.14), and mū'izam (most)/ 'aghlābīa/al-'aghlābīa (majority/most) (RF=2, MF = 0.14). However *al-qalīl/qalīl* (a few/a little) and *'aḥad/'aḥd ma* (somebody/someone) were less frequently used occurring as follows: Al-qalīl/qalīl (a few/a little) (RF = 1, MF = 0.07), and 'aḥad/aḥd ma (somebody/someone) (RF = 1, MF = 0.07). The following example from the Arabic corpus shows the use of impersonal/indefinite pronouns:

It may be hilarious that Biden warned his counterparts that without doing **something**, china would gobble our food…	(45) المثير للضحك أن بايدن حذر أقرانه في القمة أنه من دون فعل **شيء ما**، فإن الصين» ستلتهم غداءنا... (something/shai' ma)

4.3.3.18 Modal Adjectives

Modal adjectives functioning as hedging features were the thirteenth most frequent category in the Arabic corpus occurring in 11 instances in the whole corpus and recording 0.78 tokens PTW in this corpus. Adjectives such as *mūmkinan* (possible/ممكناً) and *mūḥtamalan* (probable/محتملاً) were the most frequent subcategory of modal adjectives occurring in 6 instances and recording 0.42 tokens PTW. An adjective such *mūftāraḍan* (supposedly/مفترضاً) was less frequently used occurring in 3 instances and recording 0.21 PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. However, an adjective such as *mūtawaqqa'an* (probable/expected/متوقّع) was the least frequent

occurring in only 2 instances and recording 0.14 tokens PTW. The following example shows the use of modal adjectives in the Arabic corpus:

Moscow and China are careful to prove in all **possible** ways about the steadiness and transparence of their relationship.	(46) موسكو والصين حريصتان بأن يبرهنا بكل الأشكال **الممكنة** على ثبات وشفافية علاقتهما… (possible/mūmkina)

4.3.3.19 Modal Nouns

The fourteenth most frequently used hedging category was *modal nouns* occurring in 9 instances and recording 0.64 tokens PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. In this corpus, 3 subcategories of *modal nouns* were identified: *Imkanīa* (possibility/إمكانية), *iḥtīmālīa* (probability/احتمالية), and *tawaqqu'* (expectation/توقع). Modal nouns such as imkānīa (possibility/إمكانية) and iḥtīmāl (probability/احتمال) occurred in 6 instances recording 0.42 tokens PTW. However, the noun *tawaqqu'* (expectation/توقع) was less frequent in the corpus occurring in only 3 instances and recording 0.21 tokens PTW. The following example from the Arabic corpus shows the use of modal nouns:

It is difficult to dismiss the **possibility**, which said that…	(47) ويصعب أخيراً استبعاد **الاحتمال** القائل بأن... (probability/iḥtīmālīa)

4.3.3.20 Similar-to-Verb Particles

To reiterate, Arab linguists labeled some particles as *similar-to-verb particles*. These particles according to them have a function similar to verbs. Some of these particles are employed to mitigate a particular proposition thus function as hedging features in Arabic language (AL-Semeiri, Shunmugam, & Kadhim, 2018). Similar-to-verb particles ranked fifteenth among hedging categories occurring in 7 instances and recording 0.50 tokens PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. In the Arabic corpus, 2 subcategories of similar-to-verb particles were observed. First, *ka'anna* (as if/وكأنّ), which according to Arab semanticists, is used as a *tashbīh particle* (likening particle/ أداة تشبيه); was frequent in the Arabic corpus occurring as follows: (RF=5, MF= 0.35). *Lā'alla* (لعلّ/hopefully may) is semantically used as a *tārajji particle* (a particle of wishing desirability or wishfulness/ترجّي) occurring as follows: (RF=2, MF=0.14). The following example from the corpus shows the use of similar-to-verb particles:

The USA seemed **as if** it has been surprised by the event, or as if it did not prepare itself, as it should be…	(48) الولايات المتحدة بدت **وكأنّها** فوجئت بالحدث، أو كأنها لم تتحضر له كما يجب ... (as if/ka'anna)

4.3.3. 21 Other Hedging Features

There were less frequently used categories of hedging in the Arabic corpus such as *nouns*, *conditional subordinators*, *introductory phrases/verbs*, and *metalinguistic comments* occurring respectively as follows:

Nouns functioning as hedging features were less frequently used in the Arabic corpus occurring in 5 instances and recording 0.36 tokens PTW in the corpus. Nouns such as *taqdīr* (estimation/تقدير), *tafsīr* (interpretation/تفسير), *mū'ashir* (مؤشّر/indication) and *mū'atabir/i'tībār* (معتبر/اعتبار/consideration/considering) were the only nouns used as hedging features. The following example from the Arabic corpus shows the use of hedging nouns:

Thus, there are **indications** that Israeli intelligence was involved in the prior attacks.	(49) وهكذا توجد **مؤشّرات** على تورّط المخابرات الإسرائيلية في الاعتداءات الأخيرة. (indication/mū'ashir)

Conditional subordinators were a less frequently used category occurring in 5 instances and recording 0.36 tokens PTW in the entire Arabic corpus. Structures of Arabic conditional subordinators include sentences containing *ṭālāma* (as long as/طالما), *ḥālāma* (as soon as/حالما), *klūlama* (whenever/كلما), and *mahma* (whatsoever/مهما). The following example from the corpus shows the use of conditional subordinators:

Whenever it desired to remove its name from the list of terrorists, it found itself supported by the USA…	(50) **عندما** سعت إلى رفع اسمها من قائمة الإرهاب، وجدت نفسها مدعومة أميركياً... (klūlama/whenever)

Introductory phrases were less likely to be used among hedging categories occurring in 3 instances and recording 0.21 PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. Similar to English, Arabic introductory sentences usually contain two clauses: An introductory clause usually consists of an introductory phrase (verbs, adjectives, or nouns) introducing and modifying (hedging) a second clause. The following example from the Arabic corpus clarifies the use of introductory phrases:

We should not mistake supposing that Biden-Ardoghal's summit would completely mean a Turkish-American conciliation.	(51) **لكن علينا ألّا نخطئ في افتراض** أنّ قمّة بايدن أردوغان ستعني حتماً بداية مصالحة تركيّة-أمريكية.

Metalinguistic comments as hedging features were the least category used occurring in only

2 instances and recording 0.14 tokens PTW in the entire Arabic corpus. The following example from the corpus shows the use of this feature:

European risk-taking is also horrible, as Europe needs, **simply**, the Russian gas…	(52) أنّ المخاطرة الأوربية كبيرة أيضاً لأنّ أوروبا بحاجة، **بكل بساطة**، للغاز الروسي … (bi-kūl basaṭa/simply)

4.3.4 Frequency and Categories of Boosting Features in the Arabic Corpus

By providing table 4.21, the researcher attempts to answer research questions: What is the overall frequency of occurrence of hedging and boosting in the ANEs (Arabic corpus)? And what are the linguistic forms or categories of hedging and boosting used in the English and Arabic corpus? The analysis of the Arabic corpus shows that the ANErs used 7 categories of boosting in their NEs to boost their propositions or claims. Table 4.21 presents the overall raw and mean frequency PTW of each category of boosting in the entire Arabic corpus:

Table 4.21 Frequency and Categories of Boosting in the ANEs

Category of Boosting Features		Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
1	**Adverbs of Frequency, Degree, or Time (Prepositional Phrases)**	61	4.34
2	**Modal Verbs**	59	4.20
3	**Epistemic Lexical Verbs**	8	0.57
4	**Quantifiers/Determiners**	12	0.85
5	**Impersonal/Indefinite Pronouns**	7	0.50
6	**Nouns**	8	0.57
7	**Adjectives**	27	1.92
Total		182	12.95

4.3.4.1 Adverbs of Frequency, Degree, or Time (Prepositional Phrases)

Unlike English corpus, *adverbs of frequency, degree,* or *time* were the first most frequent category of boosting occurring in 61 instances and recording 4.34 tokens PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. Similar to English languages, in Arabic, these adverbs emphasize the certainty or intensity of a claim making the argument more persuasive (Hyland, 2005b; Al-Otaibi, 2018).

Table 4.22 Frequency of Adverbs of Frequency, Time, or Degree in the Arabic corpus

Adverbs of Frequency, Degree, or Time	English Equivalents	Raw Frequency	Mean Frequency
bil-ta'kīd (بالتأكيد), bil-fī'l(بالفعل)، bil-ṭāba'(بالطبع)	definitely/certainly/of course	14	0.99
ḥaqann (حقاً)، ḥatmann (حتماً)، taḥdīdann (تحديداً)	really/necessarily/definitely	12	0.85

min-l-wāḍeḥ (من الواضح)، bi-wūdūḥ (بوضوح)،wāḍiḥann (واضحاً)	clearly/obviously	11	0.78
Fi-l-ḥaqīqa (في الحقيقة), fi-l-wāqa' (في الواقع)	in fact/actually	9	0.64
Ila- ḥadenn (إلى حد)، ila-darāja (الى درجة), bi-dūnshak (بدون شك)	to certain extent/to certain degree/doubtlessly	8	0.56
'ābadann (أبدا), bi-kāthīr (بكثير), bi-l-kāmel (بالكامل)	never/completely/absolutely	7	0.49
Total		61	4.34

As shown in table 4.22, 6 subcategories of adverbs of frequency or time were observed in the Arabic corpus. Adverbs such as *bil-ta'kīd* (definitely), *bil-fi'l*, (certainly), and *bil-ṭāba'*(of course) were very frequent subcategory occurring in 14 instances and recording 0.99 tokens PTW. However, adverbs such as *ḥaqqann* (really), *ḥatmann* (necessarily), and *taḥdīdann* (definitely) ranked second occurring in 12 instances and recording 0.85 tokens PTW. Similarly, adverbs such as *min-l-wāḍeḥ/ bi-wūdūḥ* (clearly), *wāḍiḥann* (obviously) were less frequently used occurring in 11 instances and recording 0.78 tokens PTW. Moreover, adverbs such as *fi-l-ḥaqīqa* (in fact), and *fi-l-wāqa'* (actually) ranked fourth occurring in 9 instances and recording 0.64 tokens PTW. Adverbs such as *ila-ḥadenn* (to certain extent), *ila-darāja* (to certain degree), and *bi-dūn-shak* (doubtlessly) ranked fifth occurring in 8 instances and recording 0.56 tokens PTW. Adverbs such as *'ābadann* (at all), bi-kāthīr (completely), bi-l-kāmel (absolutely) were the least frequent subcategory occurring in 7 instances and recording 0.49 tokens PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. The following example from the corpus shows the use of adverbs of frequency, degree, or time:

Obviously, the heightened escalation in Chinese-American relations will be a characteristic of the Joe Biden administration…	(53) **من الواضح** أن التوتّر المتصاعد في العلاقات الصينية الأميركية سيكون سِمَة عهد إدارة جو بايدن… (min-l-wāḍeḥ/obviously)

4.3.4.2 Modal Verbs

Modal verbs ranked second among categories of boosting in the Arabic corpus occurring in 59 instances and recording 4.20 tokens PTW. Modal verbs like other boosting features enhance the forcefulness of statements. One most frequently used structure to amplify verbs, and thus function as a boosting feature is the use of particles such as *sa* (will/سا), *sawfa* (going to/سوف), and *lann* (will not/لن) preceded by a present tense verb. This structure was very frequent in the Arabic corpus occurring in 32 instances and recording 2.27 tokens PTW. However, the modal verb *la yūmkin* (must not/cannot/يمكن) was a less frequently used category of boosting occurring in 13

instances and recording 0.92 tokens. Moreover, modal verbs such *yajibu* (must/should/يجب) and yatwajbu (must/have to /يتوجّب) ranked third occurring in 8 instances and recording 0.56 PTW. The least frequent subcategory of modal verbs functioning as boosting features was *la yastāṭīa'* (cannot/لايستطيع) occurring in 6 instances and recording 0.42 PTW in the entire Arabic corpus. The following example from the corpus illustrates the use of modal verbs:

China **will** represent 17 percent of global GDP…	**(54) ستمثل** الصين 17 في المئة من الناتج المحلي الإجمالي العالمي… (satūmathil/ will represent)

4.3.4.3 Adjectives

Adjectives functioning as boosting features ranked third among categories of boosting in the Arabic corpus. These adjectives occurred in 27 instances and recorded 1.92 tokens PTW. Adjectives such as *kabīr/akbar* (كبير/أكبر/great/greater) and *bārez/abbrāz* (prominent/بارز/أبرز) were the most frequent adjectives occurring in 16 instances and recording 1.13 tokens PTW. However, adjectives such as *kāmel* (كامل/complete), *mū'akad* (certain/مؤكد) and *wādeh* (clear/obvious/واضح) were less frequently used occurring in 8 instances and recording 0.56 tokens PTW. Moreover, adjectives such as *bālegh* (severe/بالغ) and *ā'ali* (terrible/هائل) were the least frequent subcategory occurring in only 3 instances and recording 0.21 tokens PTW in the whole Arabic corpus. The following example from the corpus shows the use of such adjectives:

There is a **clear** consensus that the sixth round of Vienna negotiations aimed at reviving the 2015 agreement...	(55) ثمة إجماع **واضح** على أن الجولة السادسة من مفاوضات فيينا الهادفة إلى إحياء اتفاق 2015… (wādeh/clear)

4.3.4.4 Quantifiers/Determiners

Quantifiers or *determiners* were the fourth most frequently used boosting feature in the Arabic corpus occurring in 12 and recording 0.85 tokens PTW. *Ayy* (any/أيّ)، *kūll* (all/كلّ)، and *kathīr/akthar* (more/a lot of/كثير/أكثر) were the only quantifiers or determiners used as boosting features in the Arabic corpus occurring as follows: Ayy (any)(RF=5, MF=0.35)، kūll (all) (RF=4, MF=0.28)، and kathīr/akthar (more/a lot of) (RF=3, MF=0.21). The following example from the corpus shows the use of such features:

We should not place too **many** bets on the upcoming meeting…	(56) فلا يجب أنْ نحمّل اللقاء المرتقب **الكثير** من الرهانات… kathīr (a lot of)

4.3.4.5 Other Categories of boosting

There were less frequently used categories of boosting occurring in the Arabic corpus as follows:

Epistemic lexical verbs ranked fifth among categories of boosting occurring in 8 instances and recording 0.57 tokens PTW. *Yū'akid* (emphasize/ يؤكّد) and *yāzīd* (exceed/يزيد) were the only epistemic lexical verbs used in the whole Arabic corpus occurring as follows: Yū'akid (emphasize) (RF=6, MF=0.42) and yāzīd (exceed) (RF=2, MF=0.14). The following example from the corpus shows the use of such verbs:

In the aforementioned recent talks between the Russian President and his Chinese counterpart, Xi Jinping **emphasized** the Treaty of Good Neighborliness and Friendship…	(57) في المحادثات الأخيرة سابقة الذكر بين الرئيس الروسي ونظيره الصيني، **أكدّ** شي جين بينغ أن معاهدة حسن الجوار للصداقة... (Yū'akid/emphasize)

Nouns as boosting features were used at a comparable rate with epistemic lexical verbs occurring in 8 instances and recording 0.57 tokens PTW. *Lā shaka'a* (no doubt/ لاشكّ) and *lā būdd* (by conviction/لابدّ) were the only nouns used in the Arabic corpus as boosting features. The following example from the corpus shows the use of such nouns:

It is also known here that there is **no doubt** that matters are extremely complex, not with regard to the Palestinian issue...	(58) وكذلك فإن المعروف هنا أنه **لا شك** في أن الأمور شديدة التعقيد ليس بالنسبة للقضية الفلسطينية... (lā shaka'a /no doubt)

Impersonal or *indefinite pronouns* were the least frequently used category of boosting in the Arabic corpus occurring in 7 instances and recording 0.50 tokens PTW. *Jamī'an* (all/everyone/جميعاً)، *lā aḥād* (nobody/لا أحد)، and *kathīrūn* (many people/كثيرون) were the only used Impersonal or indefinite pronouns in the Arabic corpus. The following example from the corpus shows the use of such pronouns:

Everyone notices that China and Russia will constitute the two major powers in this equation…	(59) ويلاحظ **الجميع** أن الصين وروسيا ستشكلان في هذه المعادلة القوتين الكبريين... (Jamī'an/everyone)

4.4 Functional Analysis of Hedging and Boosting in both the English and Arabic Corpora

The following section attempts to answer the research question: What are the pragmatic functions of hedging and boosting in the ENEs and ANEs? As previously mentioned, linguists and pragmatists (e.g., Skelton, 1988; Hyland, 1994, 1998a; Salager-Meyer, 1994, 2011; Varttala, 2001; Fraser, 2010) demonstrated that hedging and boosting can accomplish, in addition to their semantic

functions, several pragmatic functions according to the socio-cultural contexts or communicative situations where they occur. In other words, hedging and boosting can serve different functions, which may change according to the context of propositional situation itself.

4.4.1 Functions of hedging in the English and Arabic Corpora:

The pragmatic functions of hedging can be summarized and clarified in relation to both the Arabic and English categories of hedging in the two sets of corpora as follows:

4.4.1.1 Modifying Claims and Showing Imprecision

Obviously, the use of various categories of hedging in both the ENEs and ANEs such as *modal verbs*, *adverbs* of *frequency, degree, or time*, *agentless passives* , *epistemic lexical verbs*, and others was mainly to mitigate claims and to show some kind of uncertainty or confident imprecision when the precise information was not available or intentionally avoided. It seems that both the ENErs and ANErs used such hedging features to modify their propositions, present their claims as opinions rather than facts, and thus avoid being fully committed to the claims they presented (Hyland, 1994, 1998a; Salager-Meyer, 1994, 2011; Skelton, 1988; Varttala, 2001; Fraser, 2010). This can be illustrated in the following examples:

(60) *Stability in the Middle East* ***might*** *be a pipe dream…*	
(61) Most peace initiatives run into the sand…	
The contest between Russia and China over a number of files **could** lead into a conflict…	(62) *بأن التنافس بين روسيا والصين في عدد من الملفات* ***يمكن*** *أن يتحول تدريجياً إلى صراع*... (yumkin/could/would)

Example (60) shows that the ENEr used *might* as a hedging feature to express some degree of doubt and uncertainty about the political situation in the Arab countries and to mitigate his/her claim when he/she predicted the future and stability in the Middle East. Moreover, some hedging features can be used with numerical expressions or countable entities in order to show imprecision, uncertainty, indefiniteness, or lack of commitment on the part of NErs to the exactness of the expressed proposition as shown in example (61). In example (61), the ENEr could mention exactly the number of the initiatives that failed to achieve their purposes, but it seems that he or she wanted to mitigate his/her claim through using the quantifiers *most* allowing the reader to be free to estimate the number of initiatives that *run into the sand*. In other words, *most* was used in example (61) to indicate a kind of indefiniteness or imprecision when the precise information was not available or purposely avoided. Similarly, in example (62), it can be noted that the ANEr used the modal verb *yumkin* (could/يمكن) to add a sense of uncertainty; to soften the claim expressed; and

to reduce the strength of claim of what might happen concerning the future of relationships between Russia and China. Without the use of *might* in the English corpus and *yumkin* (could/ يمكن) in the Arabic one, the propositions would be too direct or too assertive.

4.4.1.2 Avoiding Categorical Commitment

Hedging might be very effective means used by the writer to avoid complete responsibility and lessen the reader's misinterpretation or rejection. In addition to modifying a proposition, it seems that both the ENErs and ANErs used several hedging features such as *modal verbs*, *adverbs*, *agentless passive*, *reference structures*, and *qad structure* to indicate a lack of full commitment to their claims and thus avoid categorical responsibility as shown in examples (63) and (64):

Obviously, since the beginning, this submariner would be the greatest and fastest deterrence…	(63) **ومن الواضح** في الختام أن هذه الغواصة ستشكل أكبر قوة ردع سريع... (waḍiḥ/obviously min-al-)
(64) If you're under 50, you **probably** don't remember when Japan was going to take over the world.	

As example (63) shows, by using the adverb (prepositional phrase) *min-al-waḍiḥ* (من الواضح/obviously), the ANEr obviously avoided being fully committed to his/her claim *the submariner would be the greatest and fastest deterrence*, in case he/she might provide untrue analysis about future events in the world. Similarly, as shown in (64), by incorporating the modal adverb *probably* to hedge his/her proposition, the ENEr seemed to avoid being categorically committed or responsible for his/her claim or state of knowledge when he/she discussed Japan's domination of the world with his/her reader attempting to be objective or distanced himself/herself from the claim (Buitkienė, 2008).

4.4.1.3 Achieving Politeness and Showing Modesty

As mentioned earlier, hedging, as a rhetorical and metadiscursive strategy, is used to create an interpersonal interaction between the writer and the reader in a discourse (Hyland, 2005a, 2017). According to Holmes (1988, p.22), hedging indicates "deference rather than uncertainty." To put it differently, hedging is a politeness strategy, which the writer/speaker uses to save the reader/listener's negative face or minimize the face-threating acts implicitly by avoiding imposing views on the reader/listener. In other words, when the writer/speaker gives the reader/listener the freedom to judge for himself/herself; and whenever the writer/speaker does not impose facts or claims on the reader/listener by using hedging; he/she supposedly saves the negative or positive face of his/her readers/listeners (i.e. avoids FTAs) and shows his/her modesty toward the reader or the state of knowledge (Brown and Levinson, 1978, 1987). Apparently, it seems that ENErs and

ANErs in the present research employed hedging in their texts to demonstrate that what they presented was limited or subjective, to avoid any direct imposition on their readers, to achieve linguistic politeness, and thus to show modesty towards the reader or the claim presented as illustrated in the following examples:

(65) One effect of this rule **would** be to hasten the transition from fossil fuels.	
People's Protection and their human capital are everybody's responsibility; if we do not admit that, the effect of consequences will be global...	(66) فحماية الناس ورأس مالهم البشري مسؤولية الجميع، **وإذا** لم نعترف بذلك، فإن أثر التداعيات سيكون عالمياً ولأجيال مقبلة.(idha/if)
Finally, the world needs to exert much more efforts and more research in the domain of investment…	(67) أخيراً العالم بحاجة إلى بذل **مزيد** من العمل **ومزيد** من البحوث في مجال الاستثمار… (more/mazīd)

As example (65) shows, the ENEr apparently used the modal verb *would* to mitigate his/her proposition, indicate the probability of his/her claims, strengthen his/her interpersonal relation with the reader, and thus avoid any confrontation with the reader in case that his/her claim *one effect of this rule would be to hasten the transition from fossil fuels* would be false. The ENEr seemed to use *would* to suggest a hypothetical statement while presenting a less definite claim about the future changes in the use of fossil fuels. Consequently, the ENEr mitigated his/her proposition to be polite and to be accepted because this claim might contradict his/her readers' views. Similarly, it also seems that the ANEr in example (66) was very considerate and tentative in presenting his/her claims; and therefore, he/she hedged (i.e. by a conditional clause) his/her proposition. In other words, the ANEr used the *conditional clause* to present his/her position tentatively and to present the information about the issue of water cautiously, avoiding any confrontation with his/her readers. Moreover, the ANEr wanted to present his/her claim *the effect of consequences will be global* in a more polite and diplomatic way by using the *conditional clause* in order to persuade his/her readers that the effect of these consequences were serious, so he or she should do something. Moreover, example (77) shows that the ANEr used the quantifier *mazīd* (more/مزيد) to approximate the expected or probable number of efforts and researches in the domain of investment and thus avoid being too direct or impolite. To put it differently, it appears that the ANEr wanted to lessen the threat of being rejected and save his or her reader's face when he asked politely the world governments to exert more efforts in the domain of investment.

4.4.1.4 Establishing Reputation and Avoiding Direct Criticism

In the present research, it seems that both the ENErs and ANErs incorporated hedging in their texts to protect themselves against being criticized by their readership especially when

predicting future events or consequences in the world or to reduce the risk of opposition of readers (Carrio-Pastor, 2017). Obviously, these editors employed hedging to build a national, international, and social reputation for their newspapers and most importantly to achieve journalistic or business acceptance and success. According to Jensen (2008), "journalists were viewed as more trustworthy (a) when news coverage of cancer research was hedged" (p. 347). In other words, when an editor uses hedging, he/she will be more truthful, precise, and reputable (Rabab'ah & Abu Rumman, 2015) as shown in the following examples:

(68) But the winds **seem** favorable, **at least** for **some** type of revived agreement.	
(69) The jump in US annual consumer price inflation to 4.2 per cent **reported**…was a shock.	
"China would be 17 percent out of the world gross domestic product", **according to** Leen Chirenge…	(70) ستمثل الصين 17 في المئة من الناتج المحلي الإجمالي العالمي، وذلك **وفقاً** لني شيرينج … (according to/wifqan li)

By inserting the epistemic lexical verb *seem,* the determiner *some,* and the adverb of degree *at least* in his/her sentence in examples (68), (69), and (70), the ENEr or ANEr appeared to be more precise or truthful in presenting his/her arguments or claims, and thus he/she avoided being criticized or proven deceptive in case there would be no chances for *some type of revived agreement* between the USA and Iran. Similarly, example (69) demonstrates that the ENEr showed some degree of imprecision about future circumstances and wanted to avoid being fully responsible or disreputable; so he/she employed the agentless passive *reported* in case the reported statement *the jump in US annual consumer price inflation to 4.2 per cent last week was a shock* would be untrue in the future. Furthermore, as shown in example (70), the ANEr presented his/her claim cautiously by using the reference structure *wifqan li* (وفقا لي/according to) to avoid any probable criticism or refutation against his/her newspaper if *China will not be 17 % out of the world gross domestic product* in the future.

4.4.1.5 Engaging and Interacting with the Reader

As interpersonal metadiscursive feature, hedging plays an important role in strengthening an interpersonal relationship between the writer and the reader when they are employed in a discourse. In fact, whenever the writer gives the reader the freedom to judge for himself/herself, negotiate, and interpret the state of knowledge or claims the writer presents, he/she is very concerned to establish a better interaction with the reader (Hyland, 2005a; Jabbar, 2019). According to Khabbazi-Oskouei (2012), writers may use *rhetorical questions* as hedging features to establish a more dialogic interaction with their readers and thus gain acceptance for their

arguments or claims. Some hedging features such as *introductory phrases, epistemic lexical verbs, rhetorical questions, metalinguistic comments* and others were typically used by both the ENErs and ANErs in the present research to involve the reader in a dialogic interaction and share with him/her their opinions about issues in the world as shown in the following examples:

(71) So how does its innovative power look today?	
We should not mistake supposing that Biden-Ardoghal's summit would completely mean a Turkish-American conciliation.	(72) **لكن علينا ألّا نخطئ في افتراض** أنّ قمّة بايدن أردوغان ستعني حتماً بداية مصالحة تركيّة-أمريكية.

As example (71) shows, when posing the *rhetorical question*, the ENEr did not want his/her reader to answer his/her question, but he/she wanted to request the reader's involvement and interaction in order for his/her reader to participate in decision making and to share with him/her his/her views regarding the innovative power, international policies, and political relationships. Similarly, as example (72) shows, by modifying his/her proposition using the introductory phrase *alyyana anl la nukhta' fi- iftirāḍ* (we must not be mistaken to suppose/علينا ألا نخطئ في افتراض), the ANEr intended to strengthen his/her relationship and interaction with his/her reader in order for him/her to share with him/her the view that Biden-Ardoghal's summit would completely mean a Turkish-American conciliation.

4.4.1.6 Presenting Claims as Opinions

The presence of hedging in a discourse might indicate that the information or claim the writer presents is his/her subjective or personal opinion rather than a fact (Hyland, 2005a; Carrio-Pastor, 2017). Moreover, since the genre of NEs is usually labeled as opinion articles, it seems that the use of hedging in an NE is very necessary to persuade and interact with the reader as they are used to enforce an opinion rather than a fact. Apparently, both the ENErs and ANErs in the present research employed hedging to present their claims as their personal views or their newspaper's opinions rather than factual information as shown in the following examples from the corpora:

(73) It would be fair to conclude that inflation expectations are moving up.	
Washington sees that the pressure it has put on Russia for many years would enforce it to do some resignation…	(74) وترى واشنطن أن الضغط الذي مارسته على روسيا طوال سنوات **قد يدفع** الأخيرة إلى تقديم تنازلات… (qad yadfa'/ would enforce)

As example (73) illustrates, the ENEr modified his/her proposition by using the introductory phrase *it would be fair to conclude that* to declare that what he/she argued was his

personal views regarding *expectations of rising in inflation* rather than a factual piece of information. Similarly, as shown in example (74), the ANEr hedged his/her proposition by using the *structure of qad* (may/would/قد) to present his/her statement *Washington's pressure on Russia would enforce it to do some resignation* as his subjective and personal interpretation of Washington-Moscow relationships; so the reader was free to accept or refuse this statement. In other words, hedging a proposition in both the English and Arabic corpora allowed the reader to judge for himself and to give him/her the freedom to decide the validity of information, the truth of claim, or the exact number of an entity.

4.4.1.7 Developing Argumentation and Achieving Persuasion

To reiterate, hedging features, if they are appropriately used, can be effective features in producing persuasive writing, supporting the writer's opinion, and building a strong writer-reader relationship (Hyland, 2004, 2005a). Moreover, hedging as a rhetorical strategy can play an important role as it might affect how strongly readers accept the truth of the information presented in a discourse. Taking precautions against presenting categorical statements (i.e. hedging a proposition) allows writers to refute possible counter-arguments, and thus, strengthens their arguments (Hyland, 1998b). Hedging, as a rhetorical linguistic feature, can be powerful in persuading the readers and influencing their attitudes towards the subject matter covered in the text (Vande Kopple & Crismore, 1997; Dafouz-Milne, 2008; Zarza, 2016). To put it differently, whenever writers hedge their state of knowledge, they intend to develop a better interaction with their readers for the purpose of affecting or persuading them to do some actions. In other words, writers use hedging not only for mitigation, but also for convincing and influencing their readers to do further actions as shown in the following examples from the corpora:

(75) I'm a bit surprised, **by the way**, to learn that Japan and Singapore have so much of the market...	
Maybe the Israeli also thinks of exploiting the short time until the end of the Iranian presidential elections...	**(76) وربما** يفكر الصهيونيّ باستغلال الوقت الضيق أيضاً إلى حين انتهاء الانتخابات الرئاسية الإيرانية (rubbama/maybe)

As example (75) shows, the ENEr seemed to use the metalinguistic comments *by the way* not only to modify his claim or avoid direct involvement but also to convince his/her readers to believe that his/her discussion and expectation regarding Japan and Singapore's dominance of global economies and markets were reliable and true; and thus he achieved persuasion. Similarly, in example (76), it appears that the ANEr hedged his/her proposition using the particle *rubbama* (maybe/ربما), in addition to other objectives, to persuade his/her readers to adopt his views

specifically when he/she presented claims or facts that might contradict the reader's interests concerning the exploitation of *Israelis the time until the end of the Iranian presidential elections*.

4.4.2 Functions of Boosting the ENEs and ANEs

4.4.2.1 Developing Argumentation and Achieving Persuasion

It seems that both ENErs and ANErs used boosting category to present claims as *definitive* and *incontrovertible* and to make his/her arguments more persuasive and his/her position more powerful. Apparently, the ENErs and ANErs, by inserting boosting features in their texts, appealed to their readers' emotions, and consequently influence their readers' opinions. In other words, boosting is an effective feature used to create a persuasive tone by emphasizing the strength and validity of the writer's claims (Crismore et al., 1993; Hyland, 2005) as shown in the following example:

(77) Iran **will** hold a presidential election in June to replace incumbent President Hassan Rouhani, who **cannot** run for a third consecutive term.

In example (77), the ENEr apparently used the modal verbs *will* and *cannot* to appeal to his/her reader's sentimentality, to reinforce his/her claim, and thus to achieve persuasion. It seems that the ENEr wanted to persuade their readers emotionally and emphatically that his/her claim that *Iran will hold a presidential election* in June and the current president *Hassan Rouhani cannot run for a third consecutive term* is extremely true.

4.4.2.2 Establishing Authority and Expertise

By using boosting, writers can establish their expertise, emphasize their certainty, assert their confidence, and enhance the validity of their claim and credibility (Hyland, 2005b). In other words, boosting functions to position the writer as an authoritative figure and truthful person (Varttala, 2001) as shown in following example:

It seems **clearly** that US President Joseph Biden is publicly determined to resolve the Turkish issue, which he considers urgent...	(78) بدا **واضحاً** أن الرئيس الأميركي جوزيف بايدن عازم علناً على حل مسألة تركيا التي يعتبرها ملحة... (clearly/ wāḍiḥann)

In example (78), it seems the ANEr used the adverbs *wāḍiḥann* (clearly) as a boosting feature to enhance his/her position, to establish his/her expertise, and enhance the validity of his/her claim and credibility. He/she wanted to say that the claim that *the US President Biden is publicly determined to resolve the Turkish issue is* undoubtedly true and thus position himself/herself as an

authoritative and truthful person.

4.4.2.3 Engaging the Reader

One more important function boosting achieves is to engage the reader with the writer in a dialogic interaction. Boosting use helps the writer draw the reader's attention by making statements more emphatic and compelling (Brown & Levinson, 1987). In other words, boosting function to create a sense that the information and claim the writer presents are important to consider and believe, therefore, the reader should participate with the writer in his/her claim and decision making as shown in the following example:

(79) As the deputy assistant secretary for Israeli and Palestinian affairs at the US State Department, he **no doubt** knows his stuff but, reaching for a historical parallel, he is no Henry Kissinger.

As example (79) shows, the ENEr seems that he/she used the boosting noun *no doubt* to catch his/her reader's attention, so he/she will be engaged with the writer in claiming that *the deputy secretary for Israeli and Palestinian affairs* no doubt *knows his stuff but he is no Henry Kissinger* is true and important to consider and believe.

4.4.2.4 Indicating Conviction

Boosting is a rhetorical feature that strengthens a claim by using emphatic language or intensifiers, thereby conveying the speaker's conviction and strong belief in their statement (Hyland, 2005b). In other words, boosting helps the writer to express his/her strong belief in his/her argument, which can enhance the reader's confidence. Moreover, boosting features indicate the writer's full commitment to his/her stance or claim (Brown & Levinson, 1987). The following example clarifies this point:

The warning of danger came from the Secretary-General of the Tunisian General Labour Union himself, whose statements are **beyond doubt**...	(80) جاء الإنذار بالخطر من الأمين العام للاتحاد التونسي للشغل شخصياً، الذي **لا تكتنف الشكوك** مصداقية تصريح (la taktanef al-shūkūk/it goes without doubt)

It seems that the ANErs used the boosting epistemic lexical verb *la taktanef al-shūkūk* (it goes without doubt) to express his/her conviction fully, and thus he/she wanted to engage his/her reader in these beliefs and convictions. In other words, the ANErs wanted to persuade his/her reader that the belief that the Tunisian Secretary-General's warning of danger was completely doubtless.

4.4.2.5 Obeying Cultural Norms and Models:

One important factor, which affects the use of hedging and boosting, is the cultural norms and models that prevail in a particular discourse community. According to Al-Otaibi (2018), in some cultures like Arabic, using boosting is necessary, as these cultures prefer assertive styles and confident expressions. In other words, the frequent use of boosting by the ANErs reflects cultural values of assertiveness and moral certainty, and the more frequent use of hedging by the ENErs reflects cultural values of tentativeness and moral uncertainty as shown in the following example:

In this equation, China and Russia **will constitute** the two major powers that **will limit** the expansion of the influence of old colonialism.	(81) أن الصين وروسيا **ستشكلان** في هذه المعادلة القوتين الكبريين اللتين **ستحدان**...من اتساع نفوذ الاستعمار القديم... (satāḥūdan/will limit) (satūshkilān/constitute)

As shown in example (81), the ANEr tended to use two modal verbs in the same sentence to amplify or boost his/her claim and position. The frequent use of boosting features by the ANEr is associated with his/her cultural models and values to which he/she belongs. The ANEr's cultural models seem to prefer the direct and emphatic presentation of claims or positions (Gee, 2011, 2012). It seems that the frequent use of modal verbs by the ANErs conveys his/her obedience of assertive cultural values.

4.4 Inferential Findings

The findings of the present research revealed that, in the English and Arabic corpora, there were some similarities and differences in terms of form, frequency, and function of hedging and boosting. The similarities in terms of form and function may suggest that these rhetorical and metadiscursive resources are an integral part of persuasive or argumentative genres such as NEs and common to all languages of the world. However, differences in the distribution or preference of these features can be explained in terms of cross-linguistic, cross-cultural, and pragmatic *peculiarities* of these languages (Al-Rickaby, 2016). To reiterate, according to the descriptive findings mentioned earlier in this chapter, the overall ENEs contained 768 instances of hedging, while the overall ANEs contained 479 instances of this feature. On average, the ENErs used 48.94 tokens of hedging PTW, whereas the ANErs used 33.94 tokens PTW. In other words, hedging features were used more frequently in the ENEs compared to the ANEs. Similarly, the ENErs used totally 166 instances of boosting. On average, the ENEs contained 10.57 tokens of boosting PTW. However, the ANErs used 182 instances of boosting, i.e., on average, the ANEs contained 12.95 tokens of boosting PTW. In other words, the ANErs boosted their propositions more often than their English counterparts did. Similarly, the ENErs hedged their propositions approximately twice

more often than their Arab counterparts. In other words, the ENErs were more tentative or cautious when they presented their opinions or claims in their texts than the ANErs. However, the ANErs were more assertive and direct in presenting their claims as they used a more frequent number of boosting.

Moreover, the most frequent category of hedging in the English corpus was *modal verbs* recording 9.50 tokens PTW, whereas the most frequent category of hedging in the Arabic corpus was *epistemic lexical verbs* recording 6.12 tokens PTW. Similarly, the least frequently used category of hedging in the English corpus was *modal nouns* recording 0.21 tokens PTW, while the least frequent category of hedging in the Arabic corpus was *metalinguistic comments* recording 0.14 tokens PTW. Moreover, the most frequent category of boosting in the English corpus was *modal verbs* recording 4.40 tokens PTW, whereas the most frequent category of boosting in the Arabic corpus was *adverbs of frequency, degree,* or *time* recording 4.34 tokens PTW. Similarly, the least frequently used category of boosting in the English corpus was *metalinguistic comments* recording 0.19 tokens PTW, while the least frequent category of boosting in the Arabic corpus was *impersonal* or *indefinite pronouns* recording 0.50 tokens PTW. Similarly, the ENErs used 19 categories and 143 subcategories of hedging to mitigate their claims; and they used 10 categories and 66 subcategories to boost their claims. However, the ANErs used 20 categories and 126 subcategories of hedging to mitigate their propositions or claims; and they used 7 categories and 43 subcategories of boosting to boost their claims. These findings indicate that the ENErs showed greater variability in terms of usage of hedging and boosting as they used more varied subcategories of those two features than their Arab colleagues did. This was similar to Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed's (2019) findings, who found, in a comparative study of ENEs and ANEs in terms of use of hedging and boosting, that the ENErs hedged their texts more heavily and with a variety of features than the ANErs did, who used a more frequent number of boosting. According to these researchers' findings, the ANEs in general were less frequently hedged than the English ones and the types of subcategories used in them were fewer compared to their English counterparts.

Moreover, on average, every ENE contained 38.4 hedges per NE, and on average, every ANE contained 23.85 hedges per NE. Moreover, one ENE consisted of 69 hedges maximally, while one ANE contained 45 hedges maximally. On the other hand, one ENE contained 16 hedges minimally, and one ANE contained only 10 hedges minimally. Similarly, on average, every ENE contained 8.3 boosters per NE, and on average, every ANE contained 9.1 boosters per NE.

Moreover, one ENE consisted of 16 boosters maximally, while one ANE contained 23 boosters maximally. On the other hand, one ENE contained 2 boosters per NE minimally, and one ANE contained 3 boosters per NE minimally. It is clear from the minimum values that all the NEs in the two corpora contained hedging and boosting. Moreover, the difference in the two mean frequencies of hedging (48.94 PTW for ENEs & 33.94 PTW for ANEs) found in the two corpora under research can be explained in terms of the differing lengths of NEs included in the two corpora. It is reasonable to argue that the longer the text the greater the chances that it contains such features at a greater frequency rate. This seems that the ENErs used more hedging features in their texts, as they were longer than their Arabic counterparts. Apparently, this may suggest that compared to their Arabic colleagues, the ENErs were much more cautious in presenting their claims as they hedged their claims more frequently; and therefore, the ENErs were more cautious or tentative in presenting their claims or journalistic information. However, the ANErs boosted their propositions more frequently than the ENErs (10.57 PTW for ENEs & 12.95 PTW for ANEs) despite the fact that ENEs were longer than ANEs. This is clear evidence that the length of text is not the only factor that affect the use of two features. Next section, the researcher will clarify what factors that influence the use of the two features.

As observed earlier, the NErs with different socio-cultural backgrounds preferred to use several different lexico-grammatical categories of hedging and boosting in their texts. In the English corpus, the six most frequently used hedging categories were modal verbs (RF = 149, MF = 9.50), agentless passives (RF = 106, MF =6.76), adverbs of degree, time, or frequency (RF = 88, MF =5.61), quantifiers/determiners (RF =86, MF = 5.48), reference structures (RF = 70, MF =4.46), and epistemic lexical verbs (RF = 65, MF =4.14) occurring respectively. In the English corpus, the six most frequently used boosting categories were modal verbs (RF=69, MF=4.40), adverbs of degree, time, and frequency (RF=49, MF= 3.12), quantifiers/ determiners (RF= 15, MF= 0.96), adjectives (RF= 9, MF= 0.57), indefinite/impersonal pronouns (RF= 7, MF= 0.45), epistemic lexical verbs (RF= 5, MF= 0.32) occurring respectively. However, the rates and distribution of categories and subcategories of hedging and boosting in the Arabic corpus were different from the English one. To put it differently, the six most frequent categories of hedging in the Arabic corpus were epistemic lexical verbs (RF = 86, MF = 6.12), adverbs of degree, time, or frequency (RF = 70, MF = 4.98), reference structures (RF = 56 , MF = 3.99), modal verbs (RF = 48, MF = 3), conditional clauses (RF = 29 , MF =2.06), and rhetorical questions (RF =29, MF =

2.06) occurring respectively. The six most frequent categories of boosting in the Arabic corpus were adverbs of degree, time, or frequency (RF = 61, MF =4.34), modal verbs (RF=59, MF=4.20), adjectives (RF= 27, MF=1.92), quantifiers/determiners (RF=12, MF=0.85), epistemic lexical verbs (RF =8, MF=0.57), and nouns (RF=8, MF=0.57) occurring respectively. Moreover, several categories of hedging and boosting occurring in the Arabic corpus were non-existent in the English corpus and vice versa as shown in table 4.23:

Table 4.23 Inferential Findings

Category		**English Corpus**		**Arabic Corpus**	
		Mean Frequency of Hedging	**Mean Frequency of Boosting**	**Mean Frequency of Hedging**	**Mean Frequency of Boosting**
1	Modal Verbs	9.50	4.40	3.42	4.20
2	Adverbs of Degree, Time, and Frequency	5.61	3.12	4.98	4.34
3	Agentless Passives	6.76	X	1.99	X
4	Quantifiers/ Determiners	5.48	0.96	1.57	0.85
5	Epistemic Lexical Verbs	4.14	0.32	6.12	0.57
6	Reference Structures	4.46	X	3.99	X
7	Indefinite /Impersonal Pronouns	1.15	0.45	0.78	0.50
8	Conditional Clauses	2.61	X	2.06	X
9	Modal Adverbs	1.27	X	0.85	X
10	Nouns	0.76	0.25	0.36	0.57
11	Rhetorical Questions	1.21	X	2.06	X
12	Concessive Conjunctions	1.78	X	1.42	X
13	Introductory Phrases/Verbs	0.57	0.25	0.21	X
14	Adjectives	0.96	0.57	X	1.92
15	Compound Feature	0.51	0.25	X	X
16	Metalinguistic Comments	0.76	0.19	0.21	X
17	Modal Adjectives	0.51	X	0.78	X
18	Conditional Subordinators	0.64	X	0.36	X
19	Modal Nouns	0.25	X	0.64	X
20	Qad Structure	X	X	0.85	X
21	Similar- to-verb Particles	X	X	0.50	X
22	Rubbama Particle	X	X	1.00	X
Total		48.94	10.56	34.08	12.95

As table 4.23 illustrates, adjectives and compound hedging as major categories of boosting in the English corpus, were not observed in the Arabic corpus altogether. Similarly, as prominent categories of hedging in the Arabic corpus, qad structure, similar-to-verb particles, and rubbama particle were non-existent categories in the English corpus. Similarly, while introductory phrases/verbs and metalinguistic comments exist as major categories of boosting in the English

corpus, they were not observed in the Arabic one. Moreover, through comparing the use of hedging in the two subcorpora of NEs (ENEs & ANEs), we can observe that there are comparatively significant differences in terms of use of such feature. To put it simply, ENErs used 48.94 tokens of hedging PTW, whereas ANErs used 34.08 tokens PTW. This suggests that ENErs, in the present research were more tentative and cautious when they presented their claims or state of knowledge than their Arab counterparts. However, there are no relatively significant differences between ENErs and ANErs in terms of use of boosting, i.e. ENErs used 10.56 tokens of boosting and ANErs used 12.95 tokens of the feature. This suggests that both groups of NErs follow a similar cultural model and cultural norms when they use boosting, whereas their cultural model or behavior differ when they use boosting (Gee, 2011, 2012). Furthermore, the findings of qualitative analysis of function of hedging demonstrated that both the ENErs and ANErs employed these features to accomplish several pragmatic, rhetorical, and metadiscursive purposes in the present two corpora. The functional analysis of hedging categories showed that the ENErs and ANErs utilized different categories of hedging to modify their claims, indicate imprecision, avoid categorical commitment or complete responsibility, achieve politeness, and indicate modesty. Similarly, both the ENErs and ANErs seemed to use hedging to establish journalistic reputation, avoid direct criticism, involve and interact with the reader, present their claims as opinions rather than facts, and finally, develop argumentation and achieve persuasion. Moreover, both the ENErs and ANErs seemed to use boosting to develop argumentation and achieving Persuasion, establishing authority, engaging the reader, stablishing conviction, and obeying cultural norms and models. Factors and reasons of similarities and differences between the two linguistic groups in terms of use of hedging and boosting will be discuss in the discussion section.

4.5 Discussion

This section proceeds to discuss the descriptive and inferential findings of the research in the light of the theoretical framework adopted in the research, the relation of quantitative findings to qualitative analysis, and the relation of the findings of the present research to the findings of previous research. One main objective of the present research was to examine or compare the use (i.e., frequency, form, and function) of hedging and boosting features in two major sets of corpora (i.e. English and Arabic corpora) in the genre of NEs in their socio-cultural contexts. Having provided some points of similarities and differences in terms of usage of such two features, we should answer the last research question: What are the reasons of differences or preferences in

terms of usage of hedging and boosting features if there were any between the ENErs and ANErs? These differences and similarities regarding the use of such two features, which were observed in the previous section, can be reviewed through providing the following sub-questions and explicitly or implicitly attempting to answer them:

Why did the ENErs hedge their propositions or claims twice more often than their Arab counterparts? On the other hand, why are there significance differences in terms of frequency of hedging between the two major English and Arabic corpora or between the three sub-genres of NEs? Moreover, why ANErs amplify (boost) their claims more often than their English counterparts? To reiterate, the theoretical framework of the current research is based on Gee's theory of socio-cultural model of linguistic features (1999, 2008, 2011, & 2012). One important aspect of Gee's linguistic theory is the notion of *situated meaning*, *cultural model*, and *discourse*. Briefly, the *situated meaning* of an expression is that meaning determined by the socio-cultural specific context where the expression is used or uttered; and this context is associated with a specific *cultural models* followed by language writers or speakers. As previously illustrated, hedging features were comparatively very frequently used by both the ENErs and ANErs to mitigate their arguments or claims in the present data. The overall English corpus contained hedging features at a much higher frequency (RF = 768, MF = 48.94) than the Arabic one (RF= 479, MF=34.08). However, the ANEs contained a relatively more frequent number of boosting features (i.e. occurring in 182 instances and recording 12.95 tokens PTW) than their English counterparts (i.e. occurring in169 instances and recording 10.56 tokens PTW). In other words, the statements or claims presented by the AENrs were much more categorical or assertive compared to the statements presented by their English counterparts. These findings were particularly similar to Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed's (2019) findings of the use of hedging and boosting in ENEs and ANEs. According to these researchers' findings, the ENErs used hedging significantly more frequently than their Arab counterparts did. Similarly, through exploring the similarities and differences between English and Indonesian research articles, Sanjaya (2013) found that overall English research articles were more tentative than Indonesian articles as English articles contained a more frequent number of hedging and Indonesian articles contained a more frequent number of boosting.

The findings of the present research can be justified in the light of different socio-cultural contexts of the two groups of NEs. The noticeable contrast between the frequent use of hedging in

the ENEs and its rarity in the ANEs can strongly imply that ANErs, unlike their English counterparts, tend to view the world in binary terms, interpreting reality as strictly divided into two absolute scales. The findings of the present research suggest that there were two different socio-cultural models, which affected the use of hedging and boosting by the native ENErs and ANErs in their texts. As previously mentioned in chapter one, according to several linguists, writing is a cultural or social form. "It is a social product whose shape and influence depend upon prior political and ideological factors" (Rabab'ah & Abu Rumman, 2015, p. 40). According to Connor (2005), "writing is increasingly regarded as being socially situated; each situation may entail special consideration to audience, purposes, level of perfection, and correspondingly may require varying amounts of revision, collaboration, and attention to detail" (p. 293). To put it differently, the rhetorical patterns, rhetorical strategies, and writing conventions are likely to change according to the socio-cultural contexts where a piece of writing occurs. Similarly, the distinct rhetorical patterns (such as hedging and boosting) observed across the two groups of NErs likely stemmed from contrasting ideological frameworks including political, socio-cultural ideologies, belief systems, or values that shaped their respective sociocultural contexts (Gee, 2012; Sanjaya, 2013). In Arab sociocultural contexts (ANErs), dominant belief systems may prioritize presenting claims or knowledge with assertive certainty, reflected in a high frequency of boosting. Conversely, Anglo-American sociocultural contexts often emphasize cautious or tentative expression of ideas, characterized by the frequent use of hedging (Sanjay, 2013).

In other words, the findings of the present research suggest that ENErs and ANErs appeared to employ distinct cognitive frameworks and rhetorical strategies for processing, interpreting, and structuring knowledge, particularly through divergent use of hedging and boosting conventions (Al-Rickaby, 2016; Rabab'ah & Abu Rumman, 2015; Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed, 2019). However, the similarities between the ENEs and ANEs in terms of form and function might suggest that these rhetorical and metadiscursive features are an integral part of persuasive or argumentative genres such as NEs and common to all cultures or languages of the world. The differences in the frequency, distribution, or preferences of these features seemed to be determined by the cross-linguistic and cross-cultural *peculiarities* of these languages (Al-Rickaby, 2016; Rabab'ah & Abu Rumman's, 2015; & Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed, 2019). To put differently, the present research supports the claim that different cultural norms (cultural models), values, and belief systems of both ENErs and ANErs are very important factors in constructing the patterns of use of hedging

and boosting. In other words, every cultural or linguistic system employs hedging and boosting differently in terms of distribution, preferences, and frequencies of these features. To put it differently, the socio-cultural models adopted was an important factor that the ANErs preferred a more assertive, categorical, or direct style of writing and that the ENErs preferred a more tentative or indirect style of writing. This context required that the ANErs should use more assertive patterns of writing and that the ENErs should use more tentative patterns of writing.

According to several linguists (e.g., Connor, 1996; Sa'adeddin, 1989; El-Arousy, 2004; and others), Arab writers and speakers prefer direct and assertive structures, therefore, they used a less frequent number of hedging and a more frequent number of boosting. However, English writers and speakers preferred tentative structures and tended to use hedging features more frequently and boosting features less frequently. To reiterate, Connor (1996) and Sa'adeddin (1989) cited a great deal of research that describes Arabic rhetorical styles and structures as amplified and overassertive. This means that Arabic texts are supposed to contain a less frequent number of hedging and more frequent number of boosting. According to Wierzbicka (1999), Oriental cultures or languages are more assertive than the Western ones, which the findings of the present research support indicating that the ANErs (as oriental writers) seemed to be more assertive than their English counterparts in journalistic discourse.

Therefore, the use of these features, which are supposed to make the text persuasive, comprehensible, and natural, may differ from one language to another. For instance, what is expected and accepted in terms of use of metadiscursive markers such as hedging and boosting in a certain language may not be so in other languages. The prevalent use of the discourse marker *wa* (*و*/and) in Arabic, which is a linguistic feature used to maintain continuity and cohesion, is not merely optional but essential to achieve naturalness and coherence in written texts. However, in English translations, this marker is frequently deleted, as keeping it would make the text stylistically or structurally unnatural (AL-Semeiri et al., 2018). Similarly, it can be said that the frequent use of hedging in English discourse is linguistically and socio-culturally very natural, whereas it is socio-culturally unnatural or inappropriate in Arabic discourse. Moreover, the differences concerning the frequency of hedging and boosting in the two corpora can be explained in terms of the differing lengths of NEs in both corpora. It can be said that the longer the text is the more likely to contain such features with a high frequency. According to Villanueva (2014), the number of hedging features used in newspaper discourse can be affected by the number of

words the NEs have. However, this justification, although it is factual to some extent, is not applicable to the present corpora. One empirical evidence that refutes this justification is that some shorter-text ENEs or ANEs contained much more numbers of hedging or boosting than the longer-text ENEs or ANEs. Moreover, the ANErs boosted their claims more frequently than the ENErs (10.57 PTW for ENEs & 12.95 PTW for ANEs) despite the fact that the ENEs were longer than the ANEs. This is clear evidence that the length of text is not the only factor that affect the use of two features.

According to Mauranen (2001, p. 45), "in order to arrive at an explanation of why texts the way they are, it is necessary that researchers resort to social factors such as the size of the expected readership, degree of homogeneity of readership, and cultural characteristics as the sole determinants of rhetorical difference observed to draw on the social contexts where they occur" That is to say, the rhetorical patterns of writing conventions can be mostly determined by the size and degree of variability of readership and the cultural characteristics of the target community. In other words, when the writer produces a particular text; he/she is very concerned that he satisfies the requirements of his/her target community. Therefore, he/she shapes his/her rhetorical structures of the text according to these requirements. These requirements, which constitute the cultural models of writers and their readers, can affect the use of such features (Gee, 2011, 2012; Sanajaya, 2013, 2015). Similarly, Martín-Martín and Pérez (2014) argue that "in order to get their papers accepted, researchers need to meet the expectations of the members of their particular communities, especially those of the editors and reviewers of international English language journals" (p.1). Salager-Meyer (1994) argues that the use of hedging is determined by the general structure of the discourse community. In other words, obeying the rules of the discourse community might require the use of hedging and boosting in a particular pattern. Similarly, it seems that when the ENErs or ANErs wanted to publish their NEs in their newspapers; they should be able to satisfy the requirements of their target journalistic community or readership through obeying the rules of writing conventions of this community. For instance, the journalistic community of ENEs may have required that the ENErs should present their claims cautiously and indirectly (i.e. through using various hedging categories). However, it seems that the target journalistic community of ANEs required that ANErs should present claims or argumentation more precisely or categorically (i.e. through using a more frequent number of boosting).

The requirements of target community, which constitute an important part of the writer's

cultural models include: The writer/speaker's *intrapersonal factors,* low or high *power distance* between the writer/speaker and the reader/listener, the speaker/writer's degree of *individualism* vs. *collectivism*, and the speaker/writer's degree of high or low *uncertainty avoidance. Intrapersonal factor,* which refers to the writer's feelings, experiences, attitudes, and ideologies, are *cultural models* associated with the use of such rhetorical features by a particular individual in a particular context (Gee, 2011, 2012; Sanajaya, 2013). Intrapersonal factor include the writer's educational backgrounds and ideologies. Some discourse analysts argue that the use of hedging and boosting can be affected by the writers' educational backgrounds and ideologies (Vassileva, 2001; Khoshsima et al., 2016), or journalistic experiences (Zarza, 2018). In other words, another factor, which constructs the cultural thought patterns, seems to be the background and educational system of the writer. According to Khuwaileh's (2006, pp.41-42), one important justification for the frequent use of hedging in the English texts was that the English authors could be more experienced or socio-culturally cautious, as opposed to the Arab ones, who tended to present their claims assertively or incautiously. Similarly, writers might also have limited knowledge about the common features or rhetorical structures of journalistic writing of NEs as a specific genre, or they are unaware of the cultural pattern to use hedging and boosting, thus they failed to meet the discourse community requirements. Jalilifar (2011) suggests that the differences between Iranian and English patterns of use of hedging might stem from the insufficient awareness of the Iranian writers of the function of hedging in a discourse. Due to their distinct cultural backgrounds compared to English writers, Iranian writers may develop unique interpretations of norms related to formality, directness, politeness, and other pragmatic conventions (Jalilifar, 2011). To put it differently, the rhetorical patterns of a writer can be determined by his or her previous journalistic experiences. For instance, ENErs with regular exposure to ENEs may adopt rhetorical strategies in their NEs (such as hedging and boosting use) that closely resemble those used by their peers (Sanjaya, 2013, 2015).

Another important factor that constitutes a significant aspect of the *cultural models* of the writer is *power distance*. Power distance refers to the degree of distance between the writer and the reader in terms of their social statuses. For instance, the ANErs seemed in the present research to see themselves as more qualified and powerful than their readers; and hence they were not concerned to build a better relationship with them (i.e. thus they used a less frequent number of hedging). However, the ENErs seemed to consider themselves as qualified as their readers; and

thus they were concerned to build a strong relationship with their readers, so they tended to use more hedging and less boosting. Another factor constituting the cultural models of the writer is the factor of the writer's *individualism* and *collectivism. Individualism* refers the degree of individualistic freedom of the writer when he/she shapes his/her linguistic or rhetorical features in the text, whereas *collectivism* refers to the degree of the writer's obedience of the writing conventions of his/her target community. In the present research, the ENErs seemed to be more individualistic in constructing their rhetorical patterns than their Arab colleagues, who seemed to be more collectivistic. Being individualistic, the ENErs considered that their claims were subjective, so they were responsible for presenting these claims cautiously and tentatively in case these claims are true or false. However, as being more collectivistic, the ANErs considered that their claims objective or factual, so they were more direct and assertive in presenting their claims as they considered their reader as a participant in the state of knowledge. *Uncertainty avoidance* refers to how far the writer avoids being uncertain or vague, or "the extent to which the members of a culture feel threatened by ambiguous or unknown situations" (Sanjaya, 2013, p.191). In other words, in the present research, while the ENErs' degree of uncertainty avoidance was very low, the ANErs' degree of uncertainty avoidance was comparatively very high. In other words, since hedging is categorized as uncertainty markers, it seems that the socio-cultural prevalent beliefs or cultural models among the ANErs can be that hedging is a sign of one's lack of knowledge.

According to Alonso, Alonso, and Mariñas (2012), native speakers of Spanish language negatively consider that hedging is a sign of lack of knowledge or commitment to the truth-value of the claims presented. In other words, it seems that the ANErs viewed hedging as a sign of lack of knowledge; and thus they avoided to use such feature in order not to be considered inexperienced. Moreover, according to Moghadam (2017), hedging can "weaken the expression", and thus, they are often perceived as undermining an argument rather than serving as a tool to reinforce it. According to Moghadam (2017), this can be one reason why the Iranian journalists did not use hedging features in their texts as frequently as Anglo-American ones. Moghadam (2017) states that the Iranian journalists probably did not view expressions such as *perhaps*, *maybe*, *likely*, and others as "constructive to their persuasive goals." To put it differently, the differences between the two groups of ENErs and ANErs can be justified as the ANErs might have negative perception towards imprecision or uncertainty (i.e. use of hedging), whereas the ENErs had a positive perception towards uncertainty.

All these aspects are a part of *cultural models* or *belief systems* proposed by Gee (2011, 2012) which are determined by the socio-cultural circumstances of the writer (Sanjaya, 2013, 2015). In other words, the fact that the ANErs were more assertive than the ENErs can thus be attributed to the different *cultural models* followed by the two groups of NErs. To reiterate, *cultural models* are "informal *belief systems* held by an individual used to help the individual to carry on the business of his or her living" (Gee, 2012, p.43, as cited in Sanjaya, 2013). *Belief system* is supposed to play an important role in constructing the individual language use (Gee, 2011; Sanjaya, 2013, 2015). In the Arab context, the ANEs adopted an assertive or authoritative tone, reflecting the writer's unquestionable authority that readers were expected to accept without challenge. In contrast, the ENErs in this research did not perceive themselves as holding absolute textual authority, leading them to diverge from the cultural norms observed in the ANEs. While the ENErs were recognized as experts within their journalistic communities, their role differed markedly from that of ANErs, who were regarded as ultimate authorities. Consequently, the ANErs articulated claims with greater certainty, employing a more frequent number of boosting features and a less frequent number of hedging features. This implies that the ANErs, positioned as authoritative knowledge sources in Arab journalism, presented their assertions, as incontrovertible truths not open to reader's rejection (cf. Sanjaya, 2015; Al-Rickaby, 2016).

Similarly, Jalilifar (2011) states that the PNErs' direct structures and style in Farsi language as their texts contained a frequent number of *emphatics* (i.e. boosting features) can be attributed to Iranian convention of valuing and respecting the rules of those in power without questioning them or without refuting their claims. Moreover, Jalilifar (2011) attributes the ENErs' frequent use of hedging to their being more considerate and polite to their readers. Moreover, Bonyadi et al. (2012) reports that academic English writers used more hedging features and fewer boosting features than their Iranian counterparts; and according to these researchers, English writers were more tactful and cautious in presenting their claims; so they tended to interact with their readers indirectly and politely. However, the Iranian writers seemed to be less conservative and instead addressed their readers directly (Bonyadi et al., 2012). Mashhady, Fatollahi, & Shahraki (2015), in their research, attribute the frequent use of hedging by ENErs to the fact that the ENErs were more conservative and respectful to their readers than their Persian counterparts. Moreover, according to Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed's (2019) findings, the ENErs seemed to be very concerned about the interpersonal reader-writer interaction performed by the use of hedging. The ANErs, in contrast with the ENErs,

tended to use more boosters or emphatics such as ɨab'an (certainly/طبعاً), bi-tā'kīd (definitely/ بالتأكيد), and others in their texts in order to present their claims and views concerning a particular issue (Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed's, 2019). This is similar to Noorian and Biria's (2010) findings, who report that while the Persian writers preferred the use of emphatics in their texts, the American English writers tended frequently to use more hedges. According to Yang (2013), the use of hedging by Chinese scholars was considerably affected by Chinese national culture (i.e. Chinese cultural models), which is supported by findings of the present research.

Moreover, why did the ENErs use 19 categories and 143 subcategories of hedging to mitigate their claims? Why did the ENErs use 10 categories and 66 subcategories to boost their claims? Why did the ANErs use 20 categories and 126 subcategories of hedging to mitigate their propositions or claims? Why did the ANErs used 7 categories and 43 subcategories of boosting to boost their claims. Why did the ENErs prefer to use certain categories more than other and why did the ANErs use certain categories more than other? It seems that both the ENErs and ANErs' rhetorical strategies or use of hedging and boosting were constrained by the structural limitations and properties of languages within which they write. It seems that the ENErs and ANErs' usage of subcategories of hedging and boosting in the present research was constrained by the availability of linguistic choices in their languages (Khoshsima et al., 2016; Aldhulaee, 2011). Berg (2009) categorizes structural-linguistic variations between Arabic and English into two types. The first, *qualitative variation*, describes structural elements (e.g., morphemes, words, or syntactic patterns) present in one language but entirely absent in the other. The second, *quantitative variation*, refers to differences in the frequency or prominence of shared structural features across the two languages. These variations critically shape the divergences between English and Arabic, serving as defining characteristics of their respective linguistic systems. For instance, while non-existent in the English linguistic system, *qad structure* (might/قد) occurred very frequently in the Arabic discourse as a hedging feature. This might justify why the ANErs used different categories and subcategories of hedging and boosting or why the ENErs employed significantly more subcategories of hedging than the ANErs. Obviously, it seems that the ENErs had more lexico-grammatical, structural, and linguistic choices to use more various subcategories of hedging and boosting; whereas the ANErs had less lexico-grammatical options; and thus they hedged or boosted their propositions with a comparatively less various number of subcategories of such two features.

The two groups of NErs, as shown in the findings, to some extent, used different subcategories of hedging and boosting, since each language has its own linguistic system and structures. As previously mentioned, the linguistic system of Arabic language is quite different from the English linguistic system as they belong to two different linguistic families, therefore, we can find many hedging and boosting features and structures exist in Arabic language but do not exist in English language or vice versa. For instance, the Arabic linguistic system does not have a modal verbal system equivalent to the English one; and similarly, the English linguistic system does not have hedging features such as *qad structure* (may/would/قد), *similar- to-verb particles* (seem as if/لعل/كأنّ), and *rubbama particle* (may/maybe/ربّما). Research suggests that Arabic speakers or writers adapt to the lack of a modal verb system by relying on particles and lexico-grammatical strategies, whereas English speakers use modal verb subcategories to address structural gaps. Arabic, similar to Persian but distinct from English, has fewer modal verb subcategories, as noted by Tahririan and Shahzamani (2009). In contrast, English's complex system of modal verb subcategories (such as *could*, *might*, or *must*) offers the ENErs greater flexibility in hedging or boosting assertions (AL-Semeiri et al., 2018).

Additionally, why did both the ENErs and ANErs employ similar seventeen major categories of hedging and seven major categories of boosting? Similarly, why was it supposed that the different categories of hedging and boosting functioned similarly in both corpora? This can be justified in the light of *linguistic universals*. A linguistic universal is a pattern that occurs systematically across natural languages (Song, 2011). For instance, all languages have nouns and verbs, and thus in the present research, both the ENErs and ANErs shared a similar pattern of using major categories of hedging and boosting such as modal verbs, agentless passives, rhetorical questions, conditional clauses, and others. In fact, the similarities between the ENErs and ANErs in terms of using major categories of such features can be also justified in light of similar generic writing conventions of NEs between the two groups of NErs. In other words, although there were differences between the ENErs and ANErs in terms of usage of such features, there were also similarities, which are explained in terms of the similar linguistic universals and generic conventions prevailing similarly in the two languages or discourse communities. Generic conventions, which are the rhetorical structures and moves common in a particular discourse community, seemed to be relatively similar in English and Arabic newspaper discourse in terms of using such features.

Then, what are the reasons of differences or preferences in terms of usage of hedging and boosting between the ENErs and ANErs? One major reason of the similarities and differences between the ENErs and ANErs in terms of usage of such two features is the pattern of cultural models, which each group of NErs adopted in their socio-cultural contexts to achieve various rhetorical, persuasive, social, or ideological purposes. Accordingly, the cultural models, which constitute various aspects of socio-cultural belief systems such as the size and degree of *homogeneity of readership*, the *cultural characteristics* of the target community, *linguistic* and *lexico-grammatical properties* of language, the writer/reader's *power distance*, the writer's degree of *individualism* vs. *collectivism*, the writer's degree of *uncertainty avoidance*, *intrapersonal* factor, *generic* conventions, and *educational backgrounds* or *journalistic experiences*, seemed to play an integral role in constructing rhetorical patterns of NEs in the present research specifically the use of hedging and boosting features.

4.6 Summary

In this chapter, the descriptive, inferential, and qualitative findings of the present research were presented and compared with other researchers' findings. Moreover, the most important socio-cultural, rhetorical, and metadiscursive functions of hedging and boosting were identified. The factors determining the findings of the present research were also provided. One such important factor was the cultural models, which may constitute various aspects of socio-cultural belief systems. Belief systems or cultural models seemed to play an integral role in constructing the rhetorical patterns of NEs in the present research. Next chapter presents the conclusion, which includes the limitations, the recommendations, the contribution, and implications of present research.

Conclusion

After presenting and discussing the findings of this research, this chapter aims to provide some limitations the research encountered and recommendations that provide some pieces of advice for future researchers who are interested to conduct research in this area. Moreover, this chapter provides some theoretical and empirical implications for the present findings, and it concludes with a summary of the most important points the present research tackled. Finally, a list of references and appendixes were also provided in the last section of this research.

5.1 Limitations

It can be said that this research achieved its main objectives, and it answered its main research questions clearly and sufficiently. Although, the findings of present research provide some significant implications and recommendations for other researchers; and the current corpora, can be said, were representative of the genre of NEs, the research faced certain limitations that rendered the findings, to a particular extent, inconclusive. First, this research was limited to only 40 NEs (20 ENEs and 20 ANEs); hence, this amount of data was relatively small or not enough to generalize the results to other ENEs or ANEs regarding the use of hedging and boosting. Additionally, as initially proposed, the use of hedging and boosting in discourse may also be influenced by other significant factors, such as the writers' age, their level of proficiency, years of experience, and their gender and nativeness, which the present research did not tackle due to feasibility issues. For instance, some ENEs or ANEs were unsigned by their editors; so it was impossible to control the factor of their editors' nativeness (i.e. whether this editor was a native speaker of English or not). Likewise, in the present research, the rhetorical sections or moves within each ENE or ANE were not examined, which may be a relevant factor influencing the research findings.

Another limitation in the present research was the coding and identification of linguistic realizations of hedging and boosting, which were done by the researcher alone, because it was difficult for the researcher to find experienced English and Arab native-speaker volunteers in order to do the coding or identification job in the two corpora. In other words, in the present research, the researcher was not able to achieve the inter-rater reliability as there were not experts of English and Arabic available in order to compare the researcher's results with those of an independent rater.

In other words, the validity of a research's statistical analysis or data coding is partly dependent on the reliability of the coding system applied, which is typically measured through inter-rater reliability test. Moreover, it was not a simple task to decide whether a certain linguistic feature should be considered as a hedging feature or not or a boosting feature or not. In other words, during the data analysis, the researcher was not completely certain about whether a particular linguistic feature should be classified as a hedge or a booster. The determination of whether a linguistic expression was a hedging or boosting feature or not was based on the semantic and pragmatic meaning, which this expression had in a certain context. For example, the English modal verbs *will* and *must* can serve as either hedging or boosting features depending on the context. It was challenging to decide whether these modals expressed capability or probability (i.e., whether they functioned as hedges, boosters, or neither), as they can serve multiple functions in a given context. In fact, this methodological issue (i.e., determining whether a feature is a hedge or a booster) was faced by all researchers (Crompton, 1997). Moreover, applying a careful manual analysis and reading of each NE were very exhausting and time-consuming. Therefore, some expressions might have escaped the researcher's attention and some others would wrongly have been considered as hedging or boosting features. Accordingly, in the present research, if it was possible to involve at least one native speaker for each language or an assistant researcher to help the researcher in the coding process, the findings and conclusions derived from these findings might differ from those presented in the current research.

Another issue encountered in this research was the taxonomy of hedging and boosting used, which could also influence the findings. As Hyland (2017) points out, any taxonomy is inherently problematic because it is impossible to create an exhaustive classification of all the features present in a language. The various taxonomies of hedging and boosting proposed by different researchers, therefore, can make any attempt to provide a classification of such feature inherently problematic. In other words, Fraser's (2010) taxonomy of English hedging, which the present research was based on, was relatively inapplicable (specifically for the ANEs). Identifying the two features in the ANEs depending upon Fraser's (2010) taxonomies of English hedging was a difficult and time-consuming process. In other words, one challenge the research faced was applying an analytical model originally developed for English data to the Arabic corpus, since there was limited research on hedging and boosting in Arabic.

5.2 Recommendations

Considering the findings and limitations of the present research, further research needs to be conducted to investigate the validity of such insights and findings and overcome these limitations. In the present research, there was one main factor that affected the use of hedging and boosting features namely the *cultural model factor* that each group of NErs adopted within their socio-cultural contexts. It can be said this explanation was inconclusive, and thus further research should be conducted to validate it. Moreover, although hedging and boosting are important rhetorical, communicative, and metadiscursive features that have been studied across different types of discourse, languages, and genres (Clyne, 1991; Crismore et al., 1993; Vassileva, 2001; Hyland, 2005a, 2005b; Salager-Meyer, 1994, 2011), research on hedging and boosting in newspaper discourse is relatively limited. To the best of the researcher's knowledge, there has been no research that investigated hedging and boosting in ANEs except for Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed (2019) (cf. Abbadi, 2014); and very few studies have been conducted to explore the two features in English newspaper discourse and newspaper discourse in other languages. More research needs to be conducted to investigate such two features in Arabic newspaper discourse and specifically in ANEs. Similarly, given the limited scope of the current research's corpus, future research should expand the size of the corpus in comparative or contrastive analyses to examine the occurrence of these features in ENEs and ANEs and determine whether comparable results emerge. Furthermore, since the present research is restricted to analyze hedging and boosting in only NEs, future researchers might also conduct research to analyze the use of such features in other genres of newspaper discourse such as advertisements, news reports, business letters, and so on.

Similarly, future research needs to be done to compare not only two sets of languages with different sociocultural characteristics but also more sets of languages with different or similar characteristics. For instance, future researchers, in assistance with other native researchers in these languages, can include such languages as Arabic and Hebrew vs. German and English in a comparative analysis of hedging and boosting in NEs although this task is difficult to do. Similarly, the current research employed methodologies of corpus linguistics to address the research questions. However, as previously highlighted, the findings in the two corpora and conclusions derived from them were inconclusive. Therefore, it will be more beneficial if this corpus-based quantitative analysis is supported by the data obtained from qualitative analysis such as interviews or questionnaires to investigate the validity of these hypotheses. In other words, future research

should investigate to what degree these differences in terms of use of hedging and boosting have effects on readers. For instance, instead of claiming that hedging functions to mitigate statements or indicate imprecision; future researchers might identify the various meanings or functions of the feature depending the readers' perceptions of these meanings such as to avoid responsibility, to affect readers' views, and so on.

Future research should investigate additional socio-cultural and pragmatic dimensions of hedging and boosting, as well as conduct comparative analyses of their functional variations between ENEs and ANEs. Moreover, as mentioned above, the usage of hedging and boosting in a discourse can be determined by other important factors such as the age of the writers, their level of proficiency, years of experience, and gender, which the present research did not tackle due to availability or feasibility issues. Accordingly, other researchers are advised to conduct further research while considering such factors. Similarly, the present research investigated two types of interactional metadiscourse namely hedging and boosting in NEs; further research can analyze other interactional metadiscursive features such as *attitude* and *engagement markers*. Future research can also examine how ENErs and ANErs employ hedging and boosting across distinct rhetorical sections (e.g., introductions, problem statements, methodologies, or discussions) of their NEs, analyzing functional differences within these structural components.

5.3 Contributions and Implications

As has been mentioned earlier, to the best of the researcher's knowledge, the present research has been the second one that investigated hedging and boosting features in the genre of ANEs (the first was Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed, 2019). Most previous research conducted in this area has compared and focused on the use of such features in English and other languages such as English, Albanian, and Italian (Dheskali, 2017) and English vs. Malaysian (Zarza, 2018). Some research analyzed the use of the two features in other genres or discourses such as RAs, theses and dissertations, and so on (e.g., Vassileva, 2001; Hyland, 2005a, 2005b). Moreover, limited research has shown that these features played an important role in achieving persuasion or strengthening argumentation in newspaper discourse (Zarza, 2018; Amirrostami, 2019).

Furthermore, the findings of the present research have both theoretical and pedagogical implications: Theoretical implications can be useful in modifying the existing models of pattern of use of such features in ENEs and ANEs. The present findings can extend our knowledge and understanding of the metadiscursive, rhetorical, argumentative and persuasive properties of such

features in both English and Arabic languages specifically in newspaper discourse. The findings can also add to the existing literature of comparative linguistics and contrastive rhetoric and show how such rhetorical features are used differently in different languages, discourses, and genres. The pedagogical insights from the findings of the current research could enhance practices in curriculum design, instructional material development, and specialized language training programs, such as English for Specific/Academic Purposes (ESP/EAP) and Arabic for Academic Purposes (AAP). The findings may increase the awareness of press and media students, translators, and instructors of the socio-cultural, rhetorical, communicative, and metadiscursive functions and characteristics of such features in ENEs or ANEs. Moreover, the pedagogical implications of the findings, which showed that the ENErs were more tentative or cautious than the ANErs, can be very implicational. That is to say, ESP or EAP instructors in the Arab world should raise students' awareness of the fact that the Arabic newspaper discourse is quite different from English one in terms of patterns of use of these rhetorical features.

The findings of the research can also be beneficial to professional or beginner translators, instructors, and students in translation courses, as they clearly showed how two languages differed rhetorically in terms of use of such features. For instance, when Arab translators, researchers, readers, journalists, or students read English newspapers, they should take these cross-linguistic or cross-cultural differences into consideration and avoid unjustifiable or strong assertions when they write in English (i.e. boost their claims)(Sultan, 2011). Similarly, when English translators, researchers, readers, or journalists read Arabic newspapers or any discourse, they should take in account the assertive nature of the Arabic discourse (Jabbar, 2019). John Swales and Christine Feak (2012) argue that there are "pedagogical values in sensitizing students to the rhetorical effects and the rhetorical structures that tend to recur in genre-specific texts" (p.15). The findings of the present research can offer valuable guidance for cross-cultural translators, EFL/AFL learners, and EAP/AAP instructors by demonstrating how ENErs and ANErs employ hedging and boosting features, structure claims, and employ persuasive techniques within their written discourse. Thus, in light of the present findings, ESP or ASP students can be able to write persuasive and argumentative NEs that are appropriately and effectively hedged or boosted. Teachers, students, novice readers, and writers need to take into account how such factors as genre, discourse community, cultural values, belief norms, cultural models, and writing conventions of ENErs and ANErs play an important role in the use and distribution of these features in a particular discourse.

5.4 Summary

Hedging and boosting, as two rhetorical, communicative, and metadiscursive features, have been claimed to play an effective persuasive and argumentative role in the genre of NEs. The purpose of this contrastive corpus-based research was to investigate the usage of such features in ENEs and ANEs in their two different socio-cultural contexts. It aimed to explore how ENErs and ANErs structured their hedging and boosting features in their texts in the two languages and the effect of socio-cultural contexts on the realization of these features. To achieve this purpose, 40 NEs (20 ENEs and 20 ANEs) were randomly selected and downloaded from the electronic version of influential, national, and international Anglo-American and Arabic newspapers available on the internet and were analyzed in terms of their usage of such two features. The raw and mean frequency of each category or subcategory of hedging and boosting in each language and were quantified and classified based upon Gee's theoretical cultural model of linguistic features (1999, 2008, 2011, 2012), Fraser's (2010) taxonomy, and Hyland's (1996) definition of hedging and Hyland's (2005b) definition of boosting. In the present research, there was one independent variable and one dependent variable. The independent variable was the linguistic or sociocultural context where the NEs were written, and the dependent variable was the use of such two features. The findings of the present research revealed that, in the English and Arabic corpora, there were some similarities and differences in terms of use and occurrence of hedging and boosting. The similarities in terms of form and function was justified that these rhetorical and metadiscursive resources were an integral part of persuasive or argumentative genres such as NEs and common to all languages of the world. However, differences in the distribution or preference of these features were explained in terms of cross-linguistic, cross-cultural, and pragmatic peculiarities of these languages (Al-Rickaby, 2016).

The findings of descriptive statistics showed the ENErs used totally 768 hedging features, while the ANErs used 479 hedging features. On average, the ENErs used 48.94 tokens of hedging PTW, whereas the ANErs used 34.08 tokens of the feature PTW. Apparently, these findings demonstrated that hedging was used more frequently in the ENEs compared to the ANEs. These findings were similar to Al-Ghoweri and Al-Kayed's (2019) findings of the use of hedging in ENEs and ANEs. These researchers found that the ENEs were more heavily hedged than the Arabic ones. In fact, the ENErs, in the present research, hedged their propositions approximately twice more often than their Arab counterparts. The ENErs were more tentative or cautious when

they presented their opinions or facts in their texts than the ANErs. Moreover, the ENErs were very concerned about the reader-writer interaction than their Arab counterparts; so they tended to use more hedging features in their texts than the ANErs to establish a strong relationship with their readers. The overall ENEs and ANEs contained 1247 instances of hedging occurring in 41.92 tokens PTW in the whole two corpora. Moreover, the most frequent category of hedging in the English corpus was modal verbs recording 4.39 tokens PTW, whereas the most frequent category in the Arabic corpus was epistemic lexical verbs recording tokens 6.12 PTW. Similarly, the least category of hedging used in the English corpus was modal nouns recording 0.25 tokens PTW, while the least frequent category in the Arabic corpus was metalinguistic comments recording 0.14 tokens PTW. Moreover, the ENErs used totally 169 tokens of boosting. On average, the ENEs contained 10.57 tokens of boosting PTW. However, the ANErs used 182 tokens of boosting, i.e. ANEs contained 12.95 tokens of boosting PTW. In other words, the ANErs boosted their propositions more often than their English counterparts. Moreover, the most frequent category of boosting in the English corpus was modal verbs recording 4.39 tokens PTW, whereas the most frequent category of boosting in the Arabic corpus was adverbs of Degree, time, frequency recording 4.34 tokens PTW. Similarly, the least category of boosting used in the English corpus was metalinguistic comments recording 0.19 tokens PTW, while the least frequent category in the Arabic corpus was indefinite /impersonal pronouns recording 0.49 tokens PTW. The overall ENEs and ANEs contained 351 tokens of boosting recording 11.80 tokens PTW in the whole two corpora.

Similarly, the ENErs used 19 categories and 143 subcategories of hedging to mitigate their claims. However, the ENErs used 10 categories and 66 subcategories to boost their claims. Furthermore, the ANErs used 20 categories and 126 subcategories of hedging to mitigate their propositions or claims. Moreover, the ANErs used 7 categories and 43 subcategories of boosting to boost their claims. These findings indicated that the ENErs showed greater variability in terms of usage of hedging and boosting by using more varied subcategories of those two features than their Arab colleagues. This was similar to Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed's (2019) findings, who found that the ENErs hedged their texts more heavily and with a variety of features than the ANErs did, who used a more frequent number of boosting. As observed earlier, the NErs with different socio-cultural backgrounds preferred to use several different lexico-grammatical categories of hedging and boosting in their texts. In the English corpus, the six most frequently used hedging categories

were modal verbs (RF = 149, MF = 9.50), agentless passives (RF = 106, MF =6.76), adverbs of degree, time, or frequency (RF = 88, MF =5.61), quantifiers/determiners (RF =86, MF = 5.48), reference structures (RF = 70, MF =4.46), and epistemic lexical verbs (RF = 65, MF =4.14) occurring respectively. In the English corpus, the six most frequently used boosting categories were modal verbs (RF=69, MF=4.40), adverbs of degree, time, and frequency (RF=49, MF= 3.12), quantifiers/ determiners (RF= 15, MF= 0.96), adjectives (RF= 9, MF= 0.57), indefinite/impersonal pronouns (RF= 7, MF= 0.45), epistemic lexical verbs (RF= 5, MF= 0.32) occurring respectively. However, the rates and distribution of categories and subcategories of such features in the Arabic corpus were different from the English one. To put it differently, the six most frequent categories of hedging in the Arabic corpus were epistemic lexical verbs (RF = 86, MF = 6.12), adverbs of degree, time, or frequency (RF = 70, MF = 4.98), reference structures (RF = 56 , MF = 3.99), modal verbs (RF = 48, MF = 3), conditional clauses (RF = 29 , MF =2.06), and rhetorical questions (RF =29, MF = 2.06) occurring respectively. The six most frequent categories of boosting in the Arabic corpus were adverbs of degree, time, or frequency (RF = 61, MF =4.34), modal verbs (RF=59, MF=4.20), adjectives (RF= 27, MF=1.92), quantifiers/determiners (RF=12, MF=0.85), epistemic lexical verbs (RF =8, MF= 0.57), and nouns (RF=8, MF=0.57) occurring respectively.

The findings also showed that adjectives, and compound hedging as major categories of hedging in the English corpus, were not observed in the Arabic corpus altogether. Similarly, as prominent categories of hedging in the Arabic corpus, qad structure, similar-to-verb particles, and rubbama particle were non-existent categories in the English corpus. Similarly, while introductory phrases/verbs and metalinguistic comments exist as major categories of boosting in the English corpus, they were not observed in the Arabic one. Through comparing the use of hedging in the two subcorpora of NEs (ENEs & ANEs), it was observed that there were comparatively significant differences in terms of use of such features. To put it simply, the ENErs used 48.94 tokens of hedging PTW, whereas ANErs used 34.08 tokens PTW. This suggested that ENErs, in the present research were more tentative and cautious when they presented their claims or state of knowledge than their Arab counterparts. However, there were no relatively significant differences between ENErs and ANErs in terms of use of boosting, i.e. the ENErs used 10.56 tokens of boosting and the ANErs used 12.95 tokens of the feature. This suggested that both groups of NErs followed a similar cultural model or cultural norms when they used boosting, whereas their cultural model or behavior differed when they used hedging (Gee, 2011, 2012). The findings of qualitative analysis

of functions of hedging demonstrated that both the ENErs and ANErs employed these features to accomplish several pragmatic, rhetorical, and metadiscursive purposes in the present two corpora. The functional analysis of hedging categories showed that the ENErs and ANErs utilized different categories of hedging to modify their claims, indicate imprecision, avoid categorical commitment or complete responsibility, achieve politeness, and indicate modesty. Similarly, both the ENErs and ANErs seemed to use hedging to establish journalistic reputation, to avoid direct criticism, to interact with the reader, to present their claims as opinions rather than facts, and finally, to develop argumentation and achieve persuasion. Moreover, both the ENErs and ANErs seemed to use boosting to develop argumentation and achieving persuasion, to establish authority and power, to engage the reader, to establish conviction, and to obey cultural norms or models.

The differences in the distribution or preferences of these features were attributed to the cross-linguistic, cross-cultural, and pragmatic peculiarities of these languages (Al-Rickaby, 2016). In other words, these differences regarding the use of hedging and boosting between the ENErs and ANErs, which were observed in the findings, were explained in terms of difference of cultural models that each groups adopted in their linguistic or socio-cultural contexts. To put it differently, according to several scholars (e.g., Gee, 2012; Sanjaya, 2015), the rhetorical patterns, rhetorical features, and writing conventions were likely to change according to the change of cultural models determined by socio-cultural context where a piece of writing occurred. It was also suggested that the pattern of use of hedging and boosting by the ENErs and ANErs was determined by the availability of linguistic choices in their languages (Al-Rickaby, 2016; Rabab'ah & Abu Rumman’s, 2015; & Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kaye, 2019). However, the similarities in terms of form and function were justified as these rhetorical and metadiscursive features were an integral part of persuasive or argumentative genres such as NEs and common to all cultures or languages of the world (Al-Rickaby, 2016; Rabab'ah & Abu Rumman, 2015; & Al-Ghoweri & Al-Kayed, 2019). In other words, these similarities were justified in light of similar linguistic universals and generic conventions, which were supposed to be similar in the two languages (Gee, 2012; Song, 2011).

According to other views (Gee, 2012; Sanjaya, 2015), cultural models affecting the rhetorical patterns of writing conventions could be determined by the size and degree of variability of readership, the cultural characteristics of the target community including low or high power distance between the writer and the reader, the writer’s degree of individualism vs. collectivism, the writer’s degree of high or low uncertainty avoidance, and the intrapersonal factor. These socio-

cultural characteristics were very likely to affect the cultural models or belief systems, which each group of NErs adopted in the present research. Accordingly, the cultural models, which may constitute various aspects of socio-cultural belief systems such as the size and degree of homogeneity of readership, the cultural characteristics of the target community, linguistic and lexico-grammatical properties of language, power distance between readers and writers, and so on, seemed to play an integral role in constructing the rhetorical patterns of NEs in the present research.

Finally, the present research faced some limitations, which made the present findings inconclusive. One such limitation was the relatively small size of the data. Moreover, due to feasibility issues, the present research did not consider such important factors as the age of the writers, their level of proficiency, years of experience, and gender, which were supposed to affect the usage of hedging and boosting in the present two corpora. Similarly, in the present research, the rhetorical sections or moves of each ENE or ANE were not investigated, thus this factor can have been important in determining the findings of present research. Another limitation in the present research was the coding and identification of linguistic realizations of hedging and boosting which the researcher did alone. One more limitation was the difficulty the researcher faced in determining whether a certain linguistic features should be considered as a hedging or boosting or not. Another problem the current research faced was the taxonomy of hedging and boosting adopted in this research, which might have some effects on the findings.

Considering the findings and limitations of the present research, it was suggested that further research should be conducted to overcome these limitations and to check the validity of such insights and findings. Future research was strongly suggested to analyze a larger corpus containing more numbers of NEs, to include more than two languages in the analysis, to analyze or compare the use of hedging and boosting in other genres of newspaper discourse, and to explore more socio-cultural functions of such features in both ENEs and ANEs. It was also suggested that future researchers should also consider such factors as the age of the writers, their level of proficiency, years of journalistic experiences, and their gender. Moreover, it was shown that the findings of the present research had some theoretical and pedagogical implications. The present findings were argued to extend our knowledge and understanding of the metadiscursive, rhetorical, persuasive, and argumentative properties of hedging and boosting in both English and Arabic languages specifically in newspaper discourse. It was also suggested that the findings could add to

the existing literature of comparative linguistics and contrastive rhetoric that rhetorical features such as hedging and boosting were used differently in different discourses, languages, and genres. The present findings also suggested that its pedagogical implications contribute to such areas as designing syllabi, materials development, and ESP, EAP, or AAP instruction. The present findings were said to increase the awareness of press and media students, translators, and instructors about the socio-cultural, rhetorical, communicative, and metadiscursive functions and characteristics of hedging and boosting in newspaper discourse in general and in ENEs or ANEs in particular.

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Appendixes

Appendix A

1-Title and Length of English Newspaper Editorial (ENEs)

Number	Title of NEs	No. of Words Per Political ENED
1	Israelis, Palestinians and Their Neighbors Worry: Is This the Big One?	1360
2	As the Israeli-Palestinian conflict continues, where exactly is Joe Biden	685
3	Catalonia's jailed separatists: time for magnanimity.	510
4	Trump Abandoned the Climate. This Is Biden's Moment.	941
5	One Way Forward on Iran: A Nuclear-Weapons-Free Persian Gulf	1266
6	Why Cuba's youth are revolting now against the island's dictators	697
7	Biden's cold response to Afghanistan's collapse will have far-reaching consequences	617
8	Biden must undo Trump's original sin on the Iran nuclear deal	650
9	Hosting the G7: to Biden, Britain is still Europe	568
10	Israel's new coalition: not yet a new era	600
11	Afghanistan's future: withdrawal should not mean abandonment	903
12	Jerusalem and Gaza: old struggles bring fresh violence	934
13	Maximum Pressure' on Iran Has Failed	1308
14	Will Trump's Bluster Force His Hand on Iran?	856
15	Trump and Ahmadinejad Are Right	713
16	Iran's Covid-19 Death Toll Is Rising. Show Mercy, Mr. Trump	1103
17	This July Fourth, America will leave Afghanistan independence in its death throes	779
18	Iran's new president is an out-and-out monster — and enemy of minorities	640
19	Who will be Mexico's next president? The current one has too much say.	940
20	Afghan Resistance To The Taliban Needs U.S Support- And A Big Morale Boost	831
Total		15,692 WS

2. A Sample of Textual Analysis in ENEs

A Sample of Textual Analysis in ENEs

Subcategory	Hedging	Boosting
Modals		
Might	1	
Should	1	
Would	1	
Will		4
May	1	
Could	2	
Can		
Can't		
Must		
Have to		
Need to		
Nouns	1	
Modal nouns	1	
Adjectives of frequency	1	
Modal adjectives		

Modal adverbs		
Adverbs of Freq. Manner time Prepositional Phrases	8	6
Quantifiers	3	2
Epistemic lexical verbs	3	
Conditional Clauses	1	
Concessive clauses	1	
Agentless Passive	3	
Rhetorical Questions		
References	6	
Impersonal pronouns		
Introductory Phrases	2	
Metalinguistic Comments	1	
Compound Feature: Double		1
Triple		
Total	37	13

July 1/ 2021
The Editorial Board
USA TODAY
This July Fourth, America will leave Afghanistan independence in its death throes With predictions of a Taliban victory within months of an American exit from Afghanistan, White House critics are already declaring that Joe Biden will own the result.
That isn't fair, of course, since the war was never decisively waged by four successive presidents, the Kabul regime was chronically corrupt and the American public has long since lost patience with 20 years of spent blood and treasure.
But it isn't entirely wrong, either.
Exit President Donald Trump
In Biden's race for the exit, any chance of pressuring opposing factions into a peace settlement was forfeited.
The Trump administration last year brought the Taliban to the table to begin negotiating an end to the war. And at first it looked promising.
There was a seven-day reduction of violence (not quite a cease-fire). An agreement between the United States and Taliban that included an initial U.S. reduction in forces from 13,000 to 8,600, a Taliban promise to renounce terror organizations operating on Afghan soil, and initiation of final peace talks with the Kabul government. That last provision was key.
But as months passed without any serious effort by Taliban leaders to talk peace with the democratically elected government of President Ashraf Ghani, President Donald Trump gave away leverage by continuing to withdraw U.S. troops and negotiating a May 1 exit deadline with the Taliban. He wanted to boast in an election year that he was "bringing our soldiers back home." 6
Enter President Joe Biden
Meanwhile, Taliban attacks across the country mounted. By the time Biden took office, U.S. troop levels were down to 2,500, supplemented by 7,000 NATO soldiers, devoted not to ground combat but to training Afghan forces, providing air support for Afghan operations or conducting counterterrorism missions.
U.S. casualties were nonexistent. Biden might have slowed down the exodus of troops and made further drawdowns contingent on the Taliban at least making a good faith effort to reach a peace deal with the Kabul government.
Instead, Biden did the opposite, announcing in April that all troops would leave. And soon. He first set a deadline of Sept. 11. Then moved it way up to July 4 (which is this Sunday) or shortly thereafter. Several hundred troops will remain to provide security for diplomats.
Biden said it was "time to end the forever war." But, of course, that war wasn't ending. America was simply pulling up stakes, a move that only encouraged more war as the Taliban stepped up offensive operations.
Taliban battlefield successes
Militants have captured 50 district capitals since May 1, and they now control a third of the country and contest 42% more. Even their commanders are startled by their rapid battlefield successes. Meanwhile, battered and homeless Afghan women are fleeing shelters in the north to escape the brutally restrictive Taliban, and the rights of women across the country are in jeopardy.
The latest U.S. intelligence assessment is that the government in Kabul could collapse in six months, according to The Wall Street Journal. And the top U.S. military commander in Afghanistan, Gen. Austin "Scott" Miller , told reporters Tuesday of his concern that the nation could devolve into civil war once NATO troops leave.
Nor is there a guarantee terrorist organizations such as al-Qaida won't once again use Afghanistan as a base of operations. The Taliban and al-Qaida have never severed ties. With U.S. troops gone, America's ability to monitor terrorism activities will diminish.
Evacuate Afghan interpreters
The Biden administration is at least planning to evacuate thousands of Afghans who worked with U.S. forces and now risk retribution from the Taliban. They're to be taken to other countries while processing U.S. entry applications. The lives of 18,000 are at stake, along with about 53,000 family members.
The task is daunting. Necessary. And the time to accomplish is quickly running out.
But America is certainly leaving. "Afghans are going to have to decide their future," Biden said on June 25, as he met with Ghani and promised $266 million in humanitarian aid, $3.3 billion in security assistance and millions of COVID-19 shots.
There's some talk in the Pentagon of seeking authorization to launch airstrikes from outside Afghanistan in support of beleaguered government forces. This would be important if it's approved by the White House, though logistically challenging.
But Biden may say no. He seems hellbent to wash his hands of this forever war.
So be it. But the reality is that should there be harrowing images of a democracy in its death throes beamed back into American mobile devices and living rooms in the months to come, the stain left on the Biden presidency will never go away.

3- Modal Verbs in English Newspaper Editorial (ENEs)

Modal Verbs in English Newspaper Editorial (ENEs)			
Hedging Modal Verbs	**Raw Frequency**	**Boosting Modal Verbs**	**Raw Frequency**
Might	5	Will	41
Should	11	Must	**18**
Would	43	Can't	**5**
May	17	Have to	**3**
Could	39	Shouldn't	2
Can	2**4**		
Need to	7		
Ought to	3		
Total	**149**	Total	**69**

4- Distribution of Hedging in English Newspaper Editorial (ENEs)

Hedging Features		**English Newspaper Editorial (ENEs)**																				
		1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**	**7**	**8**	**9**	**10**	**11**	**12**	**13**	**14**	**15**	**16**	**17**	**18**	**19**	**20**	**Raw Frequency**
1	**Modal Verbs**	9	5	4	11	17	6	13	8	3	4	7	3	7	14	8	5	6	3	6	10	149
3	**Adverbs of Degree, time, frequency**	10	3	2	4	3	4	1	1	2	5	6	3	3	1	2	9	8	8	9	4	88
2	**Quantifiers/ Determiners**	3	6	3	10	3	4	1			3	3	1	8	5	1	8	3	3	9	12	86
4	**Modal Adverbs**	3			1	4		2		1		1	1		2	1				3	1	20
5	**Adjectives**	2			1	1		1			1	1	1	3				1	1	1	1	15
6	**Modal Adjectives**						1				1		2						1	2	1	8
7	**Modal Nouns**											1				2		1				4
8	**Nouns**		1				1				5		1				1	1			2	12
10	**Epistemic Lexical Verbs**	4	3	2	2	1	4	4	3	5	4	3	2	3	2	5	1	3	6	3	5	65
11	**Indefinite /Impersonal Pronouns**	5	5				3							1		1				3		18
12	**Concessive Conjunctions**		3			2		2	2		2	2	1	3	1	1	3	1	2	1	2	28
13	**Introductory Phrases**		1											1		1	1	2			3	9
14	**Agentless Passive**	12	4	5	6	11	5	1	3	3	2	3	7	11	2	2	7	3	10	3	6	106
15	**Compound Hedges**			1	3	3										1						8
16	**Conditional Clauses**	5	2	1		3		2	3		3	2		8	3			1	2	2	4	41

17	**Reference Structures**	3		6	5	3	3	5	5	2		1	2	4	4	9	2	6	4	4	2	70
18	**Rhetorical Questions**	12	2				2						1		1					1		19
19	**Conditional Subordinators**		2			2		2						2						2		10
20	**Metalinguistic Comments**	1	1	1		2	1	2	1						1			1		1		12
	Total	69	38	25	43	55	34	35	26	16	30	30	25	54	36	34	37	37	40	50	53	768

5- Distribution of Boosting in English Newspaper Editorials (ENEs)

Boosting Features		**English Newspaper Editorial (ENEs)**																				
		1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**	**7**	**8**	**9**	**10**	**11**	**12**	**13**	**14**	**15**	**16**	**17**	**18**	**19**	**20**	**Raw Frequency**
1	**Modal Verbs**	3	2	2	9	1	1	4	10	1	7	5	2	5	1	1	4	4	2		5	69
3	**Adverbs of Degree, time, frequency**	3	3	1	2	2	4	1	5	2	2	1	1	4	3		1	6	3	4	1	49
2	**Quantifiers/ Determiners**			1	2	1					1		1		1			2	3	3		15
4	**Modal Adverbs**																					
5	**Adjectives**	1		1		1	1		1							1	1		1	1		9
6	**Modal Adjectives**																					
7	**Modal Nouns**																					
8	**Nouns**	1	2		1																	
10	**Epistemic Lexical Verbs**	1				1														1	2	5
11	**Indefinite /Impersonal Pronouns**	1	1		1		1								1					2		7
12	**Concessive Conjunctions**																					
13	**Introductory Phrases**												1		1				1	1		4
14	**Agentless Passive**																					
15	**Compound Feature**			1		2												1				4
16	**Conditional Clauses**																					
17	**Reference Structures**																					
18	**Rhetorical Questions**																					
19	**Conditional Subordinators**																					
20	**Metalinguistic Comment**																		1	1	1	3
	Total	10	8	6	15	8	7	5	16	3	11	5	5	9	7	2	6	13	11	13	9	169

Appendix B

1-Title and Length of ANEs

Number	Title	No. of Words per Political ANED
1	جوع العالم ...وثقافة العائلة البشرية	768
2	التغريد بالإنجليزية في أزمة السد	577
3	«أميركا قلقة ولا تهتدي للبوس مناسب لـ»الحلبة	863
4	بريطانيا وحلم العودة للاستعمار من جديد	656
5	بايدن يحشد لمواجهة التنين	785
6	إيران على أعتاب دور إقليمي كبير	896
7	موسكو وقوتها الرادعة الجديدة في مجابهة واشنطن	625
8	حول مصير محاولات واشنطن لتحطيم العلاقات الروسية-الصينية	1045
9	ما المتوقع من لقاء بايدن أردوغان؟	671
10	هل ستستطيع» إسرائيل «تَحمُّل ثَمَنِ» لعبها «بالنار في إيران؟	754
11	أقنعة مكشوفة	658
12	أفغانستان :عقارب الساعة تعود عشرين عاما	484
13	إبراهيم رئيسي ومفاوضات النووي :لا جديد تحت سماء فيينا	433
14	الرئيس التونسي وإحياء دستور :1959 صب الزيت على النار	439
15	لبنان: الوقوف أمام الهاوية	406
16	حماس لا تزال تحاول إزاحة عباس!	1002
17	القاهرة والخرطوم على موعد مع موسكو وبروكسل!	979
18	تركيا والناتو ...أوان الانصراف	678
19	لبنان: إسقاط الحصانات مدخل لتغيير جذري	818
20	أثر الفراشة والنظام العالمي الجديد	515
Total		14,052 Ws

2- A Sample of Textual Analysis in ANEs

A Sample of Textual Analysis in ANEs		
Subcategory	**Hedging**	**Boosting**
A Frequency of Adverbs of Frequency, Time, or Degree (Adverbials)	1	1
Modal Verbs		8
Epistemic lexical verbs	6	
Quantifiers/Determiners		
Reference Structures	4	
Conditional Clauses		
Impersonal/Indefinite pronouns		1
Rhetorical Questions		
Qad Structure		
Nouns		
Agentless Passives	1	
Similar- to-verb Particles		
Rubbama Particle		
Modal adverbs		
Conditional subordinators		

Concessive clauses	1	
Introductory Phrases		
Modal nouns		
Modal adjectives		
Adjectives		1
Total	13	11

تحسين الحلبي الأحد 11-07-2021 ,الوطن السورية

بريطانيا وحلم العودة للاستعمار من جديد

بعد الحرب العالمية الأولى كانت بريطانيا وفرنسا تقتسمان وحدهما **تقريباً** السيطرة والاحتلال في معظم منطقة الشرق الأوسط وخاصة في العالم العربي، وفي أعقاب الحرب العالمية الثانية رسمت قمة يالطا التي عقدتها دول ثلاث هي الاتحاد السوفييتي وبريطانيا والولايات المتحدة خريطة طريق لنظام عالمي يخلف النظام العالمي الذي سيطرت فيه بريطانيا وفرنسا لوحدهما على النظام العالمي بعد الحرب العالمية الأولى.

ومنذ مؤتمر يالطا انتقل العالم إلى حالة اتفاق ثم صراع بين القوى الثلاث العظمى الاتحاد السوفييتي وحلفائه من جهة والولايات المتحدة وبريطانيا وحلفائهما من الجهة الأخرى وسادت مرحلة الحرب الباردة عقوداً طويلة إلى أن انتهى العهد السوفييتي وأصبحت الولايات المتحدة القطب الأوحد منذ عام.1991

ويبدو في هذه الأوقات أن اهتمام بريطانيا بمستعمراتها السابقة في العالم العربي والشرق الأوسط بدأ يزداد على حين اتجه تركيز الاهتمام الفرنسي نحو مستعمرات الاستعمار الفرنسي السابقة في أفريقيا بل اتسعت أطماع فرنسا لتشمل ليبيا أيضاً، بينما اتجهت بريطانيا إلى الخليج وشبه الجزيرة العربية وخاصة اليمن الذي يتعرض منذ عام 2015 لحرب سعودية -أميركية تستهدف إخضاعه للسياسة الخليجية والسعودية بدعم أميركي وبريطاني واضح.

فقد تبين أن وحدات عسكرية بريطانية تتمركز الآن في شرقي اليمن في منطقة المهرة الواقعة بين سلطنة عمان ومحافظة حضرموت اليمنية **على الرغم** من معارضة اليمنيين في المهرة لهذا الوجود الذي **سيشكل** عودة للهيمنة البريطانية إلى اليمن الجنوبي الذي كان قد تحرر من الاستعمار البريطاني عام 1967 بعد كفاح مسلح مرير و**طويل** ضد القوات البريطانية المحتلة هناك.

وكان السفير البريطاني في اليمن قد تعمد القيام بزيارة إلى مطار المهرة الذي تديره وحدات عسكرية بريطانية في كانون الأول الماضي وهو الشهر الذي انسحبت فيه القوات البريطانية من اليمن الجنوبي مهزومة، وهذا ما أعلنه أحد قادة محافظة المهرة الذي طالب بسحب هذه الوحدات العسكرية البريطانية المتحالفة مع السعودية بهدف إعادة الاستعمار البريطاني **لليمن وكشفت المجلة** الالكترونية البريطانية» ديكلاسيفايد « في 6 تموز الجاري أن بريطانيا أنشأت سجناً يضم 100 زنزانة تضع فيه عدداً من السجناء قرب مطار المهرة دون معرفة أي سلطات محلية أو إعلامية بما يجري فيه وأن الوحدات البريطانية التي **يزعم السفير** البريطاني في اليمن أن عددها **لا يزيد** على 30 إلى 50 ضابطاً وخبيراً تقوم بمهمة لوجستية وتدير المطار في المهرة وبتدريب المجموعات المسلحة بحجة محاربة الإرهاب ويرفض المسؤولون البريطانيون تحديد عددها الحقيقي في تلك المنطقة.

ويبدو أن تاريخ اقتسام المستعمرات بين القوى الاستعمارية التاريخية في العالم قد بدأ يأخذ مظاهر جديدة بين كل من الولايات المتحدة وبريطانيا وفرنسا وألمانيا هذه المرة؛ **فمن الواضح** أن ألمانيا تتطلع مع حليفها الفرنسي إلى الحصول على حصة في ليبيا إلى جانب إيطاليا التي كانت قد استعمرت ليبيا في السابق، وتتنافس كل هذه القوى الآن على الجزائر الدولة العربية المستقلة التي تحيط بها دول عربية تتمتع فيها فرنسا والولايات المتحدة بنفوذ كبير، لكن بريطانيا في واقع الأمر كانت قد تخلت للولايات المتحدة عن معظم دول شبه الجزيرة العربية وها هي تسعى للعودة إلى جزء من اليمن ولا تستطيع تقاسم دول الخليج مع الولايات المتحدة ولا أن تتقاسم مع فرنسا ليبيا **بل لن يكون** لها مكان في العراق الذي احتلته وصنعت ملوكه بعد الحرب العالمية الأولى ثم غزته القوات الأميركية والبريطانية معاً عام 2003 وها **هي ستسحب** آخر جنودها منه ومن أفغانستان مستعمرتها السابقة.

ويرى الخبراء بالسياسة البريطانية أن رئيس الحكومة البريطانية بوريس **جونسون لن يكون** أمامه بعد الخروج من الاتحاد الأوروبي سوى الالتصاق المتزايد بالسياسة الأميركية وخدمة النفوذ الأميركي في أوروبا أو الشرق الأوسط والحصول مقابل ذلك على حصة صغيرة من المستعمرات البريطانية السابقة، و**ستجد** الولايات المتحدة في هذه المعادلة ادخال بريطانيا لهذه المنطقة أو تلك بدلاً من دخول فرنسا أو ألمانيا إليها بل لمنع روسيا والصين في توسيع علاقاتهما ومصالحهما مع دول كثيرة.

فبريطانيا التي كانت توظف إسرائيل في خدمة أغراضها الاستعمارية في منطقة الشرق الأوسط بدأت تتحول هي بنفسها إلى القيام بهذا الدور الوظيفي للولايات المتحدة التي **تعد** أكبر دولة استعمارية إمبريالية مقابل حصول بريطانيا على حصة من النفوذ **ويلاحظ/ الجميع** أن الصين وروسيا **ستشكلان** في هذه المعادلة القوتين الكبريين اللتين **ستحدان** بفضل سياستهما العسكرية والاقتصادية مع دول كثيرة من اتساع نفوذ الاستعمار القديم والجديد ومنع الولايات المتحدة من فرض نظامها الامبريالي على الدول المستقلة والمناهضة للهيمنة الاستعمارية ولذلك **لن تنجح** بريطانيا في تحقيق أهدافها.

3- Distribution of Hedging in Arabic Newspaper Editorials (ANEs)

Hedging Features		Arabic Newspaper Editorials (ANEs)																				
		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	Raw Frequency
1	Adverbs of Degree, time, frequency	6	2		1	1	9	1	12	5	4		4	1	5	2	1	4	5	2	5	70
2	Modal Verbs	10	2	1			4		4	4		4			1	1	4	6	2	4	1	48
3	Epistemic Lexical Verbs		6	7	6	8	7	4	3	4	2	1	1	1	2	9	4	6	10	3	2	86
2	Quantifiers/ Determiners		1	1		2	9	2			1	1					1		1	2	1	22
4	Modal Adverbs																					
5	Reference Structures	2	3		4	4	4	5	6	3	7	1	1	2	1	4	1	2	3	2	1	56
6	Conditional Clauses	2	2	1		1	1	1	1	2	1		2	3	1	1	3	2		2	3	29

7	**Indefinite /Impersonal Pronouns**	1								1					2	2	1	1	1	2		11
8	**Rhetorical Questions**	5	3			2			6	1	4	2	1		2				2	1		29
9	**Qad Structure**			1			1		3	1			1		2					1	2	12
10	**Nouns**	1							2		1							1				5
11	**Agentless Passives**	1		4	1		4		3		1	5			1		1	1	1	3	2	28
12	**Similar-To-Verb Particles**		1	4					1								1					7
13	**Rubbama Particle**					1	1			1	2						2	2	1	2	2	14
14	**Modal Adverbs**					1			3						1	1	1	3			2	12
15	**Conditional subordinators**									2			1					2				5
16	**Concessive clauses**	1		2	1			1		1	1	2	2		1	4			1	1	2	20
17	**Introductory Phrases**	1		1													1					3
18	**Modal Nouns**									1		1			1		1	3		2		9
19	**Modal Adjectives and Adjectives**	1	3						1				1	3	1					1		11
20	**Metalinguistic Comments**																				2	2
	Total	31	23	22	13	20	40	14	45	26	24	17	14	10	21	24	22	33	27	28	25	**479**

4- Distribution of Boosting in Arabic Newspaper Editorials (ANEs)

Boosting Features		**Arabic Newspaper Editorials (ANEs)**																				
		1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**	**7**	**8**	**9**	**10**	**11**	**12**	**13**	**14**	**15**	**16**	**17**	**18**	**19**	**20**	**Raw Frequency**
1	**Adverbs of Degree, time, frequency**	4		4	1	2	8	1	4	3	2	1	1	3	4	2	9	5	4		3	61
2	**Modal Verbs**	1	4	4	8	8	5	2	4	3	4			2	1	2	5	3			3	59
3	**Epistemic Lexical Verbs**						1		3						1					3		8
2	**Quantifiers/ Determiners**			1		1	2	1	2	1								2	1		1	12
4	**Modal Adverbs**																					
5	**Reference Structures**																					
6	**Conditional Clauses**																					
7	**Indefinite /Impersonal Pronouns**		1		1			1	2						1		1					7

8	**Rhetorical Questions**																					
9	**Qad Structure**																					
10	**Nouns**					1						3					2		1	1		8
11	**Agentless Passives**																					
12	**Similar-To-Verb Particles**																					
13	**Rubbama Particle**																					
14	**Modal Adverbs**																					
15	**Conditional subordinators**																					
16	**Concessive clauses**																					
17	**Introductory Phrases**																					
19	**Modal Nouns Modal Adjectives**																					
20	**Adjectives**		1	4	1	1	7	2	4				2	1				3			1	27
21	**Metalinguistic Comments**																					
	Total	5	6	13	11	13	23	7	19	7	6	4	3	6	7	4	17	13	6	4	8	182